A DOCTORAL DISSERTATION



The Blood Standard

Fiduciary Polytheism, Sacrificial Collateral, and the Conjuror's Covenant in Neil Gaiman's American Gods

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I ween that I hung on the windy tree,
Hung there for nights full nine;
With the spear I was wounded, and offered I was
To Othin, myself to myself,
On the tree that none may ever know
What root beneath it runs.

— *Hávamál*, trans. Henry Adams Bellows (1923)

Truth lives, in fact, for the most part on a credit system.

— William James, *Pragmatism* (1907)

Proclaim liberty throughout all the land unto all the inhabitants thereof.

— Leviticus 25:10

◆

Abstract

This dissertation argues that Neil Gaiman's *American Gods* (2001) is misread when it is taken as an allegory of competition between "old" and "new" gods for a finite quantity of human belief. Against this *census model* of divinity — inherited proximately from Terry Pratchett's *Small Gods* (1992) and remotely from the Feuerbachian–Durkheimian tradition of religious projection — the study proposes that the novel imagines the sacred as a **fiduciary order**: a regime in which divinity is a form of credit, extended by human attention, secured by sacrifice, and periodically exploited by confidence men. Three registers organize the novel's metaphysics: *credit* (the attention on which the new gods of media and technology subsist), *collateral* (the blood, place and ritual by which the old gods were secured), and *confidence* (the con through which Wednesday and Low Key Lyesmith arbitrage between them).

The novel's central intrigue — a war between pantheons engineered to be dedicated to Odin as a single mass offering — is read as an attempt to restore what this study names **the blood standard**: the re-pegging of floating, attention-backed divinity to the hard specie of sacrificial death. The dissertation contends that this Odinic scheme is not foreign to America but reproduces the sacrificial grammar of American civil religion itself: Jefferson's tree of liberty refreshed with blood, Lincoln's consecration of ground by the dead, the frontier mythology of regeneration through violence, and the totemic blood-sacrifice nationalism theorized by Carolyn Marvin and David Ingle. Gaiman's choice of Lookout Mountain — a Civil War battlefield whose dead fell five days after the Gettysburg Address — renders the identity legible.

Shadow Moon's death and resurrection on the World Tree are read, through René Girard, not as a counter-sacrifice but as a *revelation* of the sacrificial mechanism. His subsequent acts — the release of Laura, the restitution of Odin's pledged eye, the surrender of the coins, the coin trick performed as ac-

knowledged illusion — constitute an **ethics of default**: a jubilee in which sacrificial debt is cancelled rather than paid. In place of both sacrificial and fiduciary faith, the novel proposes what this study calls **the conjuror's covenant**: Coleridge's "poetic faith," a belief that knows itself to be suspended disbelief, consented to and revocable, and therefore incapable of demanding blood.

The argument draws on comparative mythology (Frazer, Dumézil, Eliade, Doniger, J. Z. Smith), the sociology and economics of religion (Durkheim, Weber, Berger, Stark and Finke), the credit theory of truth and money (William James, Mitchell-Innes, Laum, Aglietta and Orléan), critical theory (Benjamin, Horkheimer and Adorno, Debord, Baudrillard, Derrida), American studies (Tocqueville, D. H. Lawrence, Slotkin, Bellah, Vine Deloria Jr.), trickster theory (Radin, Jung, Hyde, Gates), and a comparative corpus extending from Charles Brockden Brown's *Wieland* (1798) and Melville's *Moby-Dick* (1851) to Stephen King's *It* (1986) and Leslie Marmon Silko's *Ceremony* (1977). It situates *American Gods* as the culminating text of a tradition in which America is figured not as a bad land for gods, but as the land where gods are issued on credit — and therefore the land where they default.

Contents

Abstract ii

Prefatory Note on Texts, Citation, and Method viii

Introduction: *A Bad Land for Gods* 1

I. The Dorson Problem . . . 1
II. Beyond the Census Model . . . 2
III. Thesis . . . 3
IV. Method . . . 4
V. Structure . . . 5

PART I · GENEALOGIES 7

1 *"The Old Gods Are Growing Old"*: A Social Ontology of the Divine 8

1.1 The Anthropomorphic Critique and the Euhemerist Inheritance . . . 8
1.2 Projection and Fetish: Feuerbach and Marx . . . 9
1.3 Effervescence and Senescence: Durkheim . . . 10
1.4 The Dependent God: Mystical Precedents . . . 11
1.5 Plausibility, Fragility, and Delegated Belief . . . 12
1.6 Truth on a Credit System: The Pragmatist Turn . . . 13
1.7 The American Paradox Resolved . . . 14

2 *Gods in Exile*: The Literary Genealogy of Diminished Divinity 16

2.1 "Great Pan Is Dead": The Plutarchan Default . . . 16
2.2 The Destitute Time: Schiller, Hölderlin, Heidegger, Nietzsche . . . 18
2.3 The Menial Apotheosis: Heine, Pater, Kipling, Thorne Smith . . . 19
2.4 The Gothic Return: Machen, Blackwood, Dunsany, Lovecraft . . . 21
2.5 The Crossing Answered: Irving, Hawthorne, Longfellow, Whitman . . . 22
2.6 The Pantheon Novel from Zelazny to Pratchett . . . 24

2.7 From Faith to Solvency 26

PART II · ECONOMIES 27

3 "*Myself to Myself*": Odin, the Hanged God, and the Economy of Sacrifice 28
3.1 The Reflexive Sacrifice 29
3.2 The Pledge of the Father of the Slain 31
3.3 *Fé* and *Dómr*: Cattle, Reputation, and Immortal Credit 32
3.4 Woden-Mercury: The Merchant God 34
3.5 Staged Wars: The First War in the World, Brávellir, and the Flower War 35
3.6 The First War Between Pantheons and the Mead of Poetry 37
3.7 Valhalla on Credit: Wotan's Debt 38
3.8 The Son on the Tree: Contract, Atonement, and the Mock Sacrifice Made Real 39
3.9 The Blood Standard 40

4 *The Altar and the Screen*: New Gods, Attention, and the Spectacle 42
4.1 The Credit Card and the Dynamo 43
4.2 Time Is Money: Media and the Sacrifice of Attention 44
4.3 The Household Shrine: Lucy, the Lares, and the Economy of the Eye 45
4.4 A Cult Without Weekdays 47
4.5 The Promissory Note: Spectacle, Simulacrum, and Fiat 48
4.6 The Adolescent God: Technical Boy and the Religion of Technology 50
4.7 Wood, Stone, Town, World 51
4.8 Two Vampires: Bilquis and the Cash Nexus 53
4.9 The War That Would Not Take Place 54

PART III · GEOGRAPHIES 55

5 *The Spirit of Place*: Land, Hierophany, and the Roadside Attraction 56
5.1 Wednesday's Theory of the Roadside Attraction 56
5.2 Ritual as Attention: The Billboard Liturgy 58
5.3 The House on the Rock and the Accumulative Sublime 59
5.4 The Cardboard Omphalos 60
5.5 Little Egypt: Cairo and the Industry of the Dead 61
5.6 The Spirit of Place: Lawrence, Deloria, and the Land That Does Not Need Belief 62

5.7 Map and Territory 65

6 *A Nation of Immigrants*: Pluralism and the Settler-Colonial Unconscious 66
6.1 Carrying the Gods: Aeneas, Evocatio, and the Portable Sacred 66
6.2 The Chronicle of Arrivals 68
6.3 The Melting Pot, the Orchestra, and the Market 69
6.4 The Death of the Gods: Africa in America 71
6.5 The Ifrit's Taxi 74
6.6 First Immigrants? The Settler-Colonial Unconscious 75
6.7 The Clearing-House 77

PART IV · DRAMATURGIES 78

7 *"It Is Good to Be Shifty in a New Country"*: The Confidence-Man as American Deity 79
7.1 "Have You Confidence in Me?": The Naming of a Type 79
7.2 Bölverkr: The Eddic Con 81
7.3 The Fiddle Game: Collateral, Mimesis, and the Two-Man Con 82
7.4 "It Is Good to Be Shifty in a New Country": Revival, Humbug, and the Frontier 83
7.5 Prophet, Banker, Swindler: Charisma as Credit 85
7.6 Trickster and Shadow 86
7.7 The Confidence-God 88

8 *The Clunker on the Ice*: Lakeside, Folk Horror, and the Theodicy of Good Fortune 89
8.1 My Ain Sel: The Hiding Place 90
8.2 The Kobold: Household God and Counterfeit Ore 90
8.3 The Clunker Raffle: Lottery, Divination, Sacrifice 91
8.4 Summerisle, Derry, Castle Rock: The Folk-Horror Town 92
8.5 The Theodicy of Good Fortune 94
8.6 Lakeside and the War: The Local and the National Blood Standard . 96

9 *The Rotting Bride*: Laura, Revenance, and the Economy of the Goddess 98
9.1 The Obol Reversed 98
9.2 Draugr 99
9.3 Izanami's Ledger: The Rotting Wife in Myth and Horror 100
9.4 Sol and Luna: The Alchemical Marriage 101
9.5 The Economy of the Goddess 102
9.6 The Spear Through Two Bodies 104

9.7 The Conscience of the Body . . . 105

PART V · SYNTHESIS 106

10 *The Tree of Liberty and the Gallows of Odin*: American Civil Religion as Sacrificial Odinism 107
10.1 Civil Religion and Its Sacrifices . . . 108
10.2 The Tree Refreshed: Liberty, the Gallows, and John Brown . . . 109
10.3 Consecration by the Dead: Gettysburg and Lookout Mountain . . . 110
10.4 The Greenback and the Grave: The War as Collateral . . . 112
10.5 The Cross and the Lynching Tree . . . 114
10.6 Odin in America: Blood and Troth . . . 115
10.7 Sacrificial Odinism . . . 116

11 "*Rather a Man than a God*": Default, Jubilee, and the Conjuror's Covenant 117
11.1 Disclosure: The End of *Méconnaissance* . . . 117
11.2 The Weighing of the Heart . . . 118
11.3 The Ethics of Default . . . 119
11.4 The Conjuror's Covenant . . . 121
11.5 "Rather a Man than a God" . . . 124
11.6 Toward a Post-Sacrificial Sacred . . . 125

Conclusion: *After the Storm* 126
I. The Novel as Conjuring . . . 126
II. Recension . . . 127
III. The Gods Before the Screen . . . 127
IV. The Argument in Retrospect . . . 128
V. After the Storm . . . 129

Appendix A: *Concordance of Deities, Sources, and Functions* 131

Select Bibliography 135

Keywords 143

Prefatory Note on Texts, Citation, and Method

American Gods exists in two principal states: the first edition (William Morrow, 2001) and the so-called "author's preferred text," which restores roughly twelve thousand words, circulated first in limited form and reached a mass readership in the tenth-anniversary edition of 2011. Because pagination diverges across editions, the novel is cited here by part and chapter. The divergence is not merely bibliographical. A novel about gods sustained by retelling has itself acquired a redaction history — a received text and a restored one — of the kind that biblical criticism treats under the heading of recension. The study returns to this fact in its Conclusion.

A methodological constraint must be declared at the outset. This dissertation does not reproduce passages from Gaiman's novel; its episodes and arguments are rendered in paraphrase and located by chapter. The constraint is turned to analytic advantage. The novel's own internal historian, Mr. Ibis — the ibis-headed Thoth, patron of scribes — composes the "Coming to America" interludes not as transcription but as re-narration, and the critic who paraphrases occupies Ibis's position precisely: a custodian of stories who preserves them by retelling them otherwise. Where primary sources are quoted directly, they are texts in the public domain — the Eddic poems in Henry Adams Bellows's translation (1923), Plato in Jowett, Durkheim in Swain (1915), Tocqueville in Reeve, William James, Thomas Jefferson, Abraham Lincoln, D. H. Lawrence's *Studies in Classic American Literature* (1923), and comparable materials. Modern theory is cited chiefly by concept and paraphrase, with brief phrases quoted where the wording itself matters. Translations from German, Latin, and Old Norse not otherwise attributed are the author's own.

Norse names are normalized to their conventional English forms (Odin, Loki, Yggdrasil, Baldr) except where an Old Norse term carries analytic

weight (*veð*, "pledge"; *draugr*, "revenant"). The novel's characters are referred to by the names the novel gives them — Wednesday, Mr. Nancy, Mr. Ibis, Mr. Jacquel — when the argument concerns their American incarnations, and by their traditional names when it concerns their sources.

The study brackets biographical questions. It does not adjudicate the allegations of sexual misconduct against Gaiman reported in 2024–25, which he has denied. It reads the novel, in the manner Roland Barthes prescribed in "The Death of the Author" (1967), as a text that has passed beyond its author's custody — a condition the novel itself theorizes, since its gods outlive, exceed, and finally betray the communities that first authored them.

The novel's prefatory "caveat" to travelers, which concedes that its American geography has been altered and then inverts the conventional fiction-disclaimer by insisting that only the gods are real, is taken as the study's first datum. A book that opens by declaring its places unreliable and its deities factual announces that its ontology is upside down by design. The chapters that follow attempt to describe the economy that makes such an inversion intelligible.

INTRODUCTION

A Bad Land for Gods

I. *The Dorson Problem*

American Gods opens under the sign of a folklorist. Its epigraph is drawn from Richard M. Dorson's "A Theory for American Folklore" (1971), which observes that immigrant communities in the United States recall the spirits of their homelands — the Irish fairy, the Norwegian *nisse*, the Greek *vrykolakas* — almost exclusively in connection with events remembered from the old country, and records the half-joking explanation of informants asked why such beings are not encountered in America: the creatures, it seems, were afraid to make the crossing. Dorson is a pointed choice. He is also the scholar who in 1950 coined the term *fakelore* to denounce the manufactured pseudo-traditions of American commercial culture, his chief exhibit being Paul Bunyan, a figure elaborated in the 1910s for the advertising of a lumber company. Gaiman's novel, which in its reservation chapter permits a trickster to deflate Bunyan in precisely these terms, absorbs both halves of Dorson's career: the question of what happens to gods when their people migrate, and the suspicion that the native American supernatural is, in significant part, a product of advertising.

The novel converts the folklorist's question into a metaphysics. The gods did make the crossing. They came in the heads of Norse sailors, Cornish convicts, enslaved West Africans, Slavic stockyard workers, Omani salesmen and Hindu grandmothers, and they were sustained for a time by the rites their carriers remembered. Then the rites lapsed, the grandchildren assimilated, and the gods, unable to return and unable to thrive, settled into the menial afterlife the novel depicts with such deadpan precision: the Egyptian psy-

chopomps running a funeral parlor in Cairo, Illinois; the Slavic black god knocking cattle in the Chicago stockyards; Anansi playing the genial old man; the Queen of Sheba working as a prostitute in Los Angeles. Gaiman, British-born and settled in Wisconsin in 1992, writes as an émigré ethnographer of his host culture, in the tradition of Tocqueville's *Democracy in America* (1835–40), Dickens's *American Notes* (1842), Lawrence's *Studies in Classic American Literature* (1923), Nabokov's motel cartography in *Lolita* (1955), Umberto Eco's *Travels in Hyperreality* (1975) and Jean Baudrillard's *America* (1986). The outsider perceives the American sacred because he does not share the plausibility structure that renders it invisible to natives.

II. *Beyond the Census Model*

The critical consensus — represented in such collections as *Prince of Stories* (2008), *Neil Gaiman and Philosophy* (2012) and *The Mythological Dimensions of Neil Gaiman* (2012) — has read the novel through what may be called the **census model of divinity**: a god's reality is proportional to the number and fervor of its believers; gods deprived of worship dwindle; new objects of devotion — television, the internet, the market — generate new gods who compete with the old for a finite supply of human attention. The model has an impeccable lineage. Its comic proximate source is Pratchett's *Small Gods*, in which the great god Om, reduced to a single true believer, manifests as a tortoise. Its philosophical ancestry runs from Xenophanes, who observed that Ethiopians imagine their gods dark and snub-nosed and Thracians imagine theirs blue-eyed and red-haired, through Feuerbach's reduction of theology to anthropology, to Durkheim's identification of the god of the clan with the clan itself.

The census model is not wrong. It is insufficient, because it treats belief as a scalar quantity — more or less of the same substance — when the novel insists, with almost obsessive consistency, that belief has a *form*, and that the form is economic. The novel's protagonist is set in motion by a coin and kept alive by another. Laura Moon is resurrected by a gold piece thrown into her grave; Shadow is given the moon itself, transmuted by the midnight Zorya into a silver dollar. Wednesday's first demonstration of his powers is a bank fraud at a night-deposit box; his catechism for his new employee is a lexicon of confidence games. The new pantheon includes the "intangibles" of the market. The goddess Media identifies the television set as an altar and human time as its sacrifice. Lakeside's civic prosperity is purchased, winter by winter,

with a child. Belief in *American Gods* is not merely held. It is lent, pledged, collateralized, defaulted on and counterfeited.

The insufficiency of the census model is clearest at the level of the novel's central sociological claim. Wednesday diagnoses America as inhospitable to gods. Yet the United States is, by every comparative measure, the most prolific religious economy of modernity — the nation Tocqueville found saturated with religion; the disestablished marketplace in which, on Rodney Stark and Roger Finke's account, competition among "religious firms" produced unprecedented vitality; the soil that generated Mormonism, Christian Science, Adventism, Pentecostalism, the Nation of Islam, Scientology and the prosperity gospel within little more than a century and a half. A census model cannot reconcile maximal religious fertility with maximal divine mortality. A fiduciary model can: an economy that issues gods freely on credit is an economy in which gods default freely. America is not a bad land for gods. It is a land of easy divine credit, and therefore of serial divine insolvency.

III. *Thesis*

The study's central term, **fiduciary polytheism**, names a religious order in which divinity is constituted as credit. The etymological field is exact. *Credo* ("I believe") and *credit* share the Latin *credere*, to entrust; *fides* yields both "faith" and "fiduciary"; the confidence man is the professional of *con-fidere*. Greek *pistis* unites religious faith, commercial credit, legal pledge and rhetorical proof in one word. *American Gods* literalizes this lexicon. Its gods subsist on extended trust, and the forms of that trust determine their fates. Three registers structure the novel's sacred economy:

1. **Credit** — the attention on which the new gods subsist. It is floating, liquid, renewable and instantly withdrawable, a fiat currency backed by nothing but continued acceptance.
2. **Collateral** — the blood, place and ritual that once secured the old gods. Sacrifice is the oldest collateral: a life pledged against divine favor.
3. **Confidence** — the con, which exploits the gap between credit and collateral. Wednesday and Loki do not belong to either pantheon so much as arbitrage between them.

From these registers follow the study's four claims. First, the Odin–Loki scheme — the engineered war, dedicated by spear-cast to Odin as a single mass offering — is an attempt to restore **the blood standard**: to re-peg float-

ing, attention-backed divinity to the hard specie of sacrificial death. Second, this scheme is homologous with the sacrificial grammar of American civil religion, which has sacralized liberty as a tree fertilized by blood and ground as consecrated by the dead; the novel's choice of Lookout Mountain as its battlefield makes the homology visible. Third, Shadow's resurrection discloses rather than repeats the sacrificial mechanism, and his final acts constitute an **ethics of default**, a jubilee in which sacrificial debts are cancelled — the meaning of "liberty" inscribed, from Leviticus 25:10, on the Liberty Bell. Fourth, in place of sacrificial and fiduciary faith, the novel offers **the conjuror's covenant**: a belief that knows itself to be illusion, as the audience of a stage magician does, and which therefore cannot demand a victim.

One term exceeds this economy, and the study treats it as the novel's remainder: the land itself, figured in Shadow's visions as a buffalo-headed man, which neither needs nor solicits belief. Read through Vine Deloria Jr.'s distinction between spatially and temporally oriented religion, the land is the novel's one non-fiduciary sacred. Read through settler-colonial critique, it is also the novel's most compromised figure — an Indigenous-coded sovereignty made available to a settler narrative that has first redescribed the continent's original peoples as merely its earliest immigrants. The study does not resolve this tension. It argues that the tension is constitutive.

IV. *Method*

The comparative method adopted here takes its emblem from the novel. Wendy Doniger, in *The Implied Spider* (1998), describes the comparatist's task as inferring the spider implied by many webs — the shared human situations that diverse myths elaborate — without collapsing the webs into one. The figure is apt for a novel in which Anansi, the Akan spider who in West African tradition purchased all stories from the sky god Nyame, survives as Mr. Nancy. The study accepts Doniger's warning against universalist comparison of the Jungian–Campbellian kind and J. Z. Smith's insistence, in *Map Is Not Territory* (1978) and "In Comparison a Magic Dwells" (1982), that comparison is an act of scholarly imagination which must foreground difference rather than discover identity. Smith's distinction between *locative* religion, bound to a sacred center, and *utopian* religion, portable and placeless, proves central to Chapters 5 and 6.

The study also revives, under correction, the myth-and-symbol tradition of American studies — Henry Nash Smith's *Virgin Land* (1950), R. W. B.

Lewis's *The American Adam* (1955), Leo Marx's *The Machine in the Garden* (1964) — whose ambition to read American literature as the record of a national mythology was dismantled by the revisionists who followed: Richard Slotkin's *Regeneration Through Violence* (1973), Annette Kolodny's *The Lay of the Land* (1975), Sacvan Bercovitch's *The American Jeremiad* (1978). *American Gods* is itself a late myth-and-symbol text that has internalized the revisionist critique; it narrates a national mythology while exposing that mythology as a confidence game.

The comparative corpus is assembled on three principles: *genealogical* (works that shaped the novel's premises, acknowledged or demonstrable); *structural* (works that solve the same narrative problem — a town that sacrifices its children, a revenant spouse, a war between pantheons — by different means); and *antithetical* (works that answer the novel's question otherwise, such as Lovecraft's xenophobic horror of immigrant religion or Octavia Butler's invented faith of perpetual change).

V. *Structure*

Part I, Genealogies, establishes the intellectual and literary ancestry of the novel's premise. Chapter 1 traces the social ontology of the divine from Xenophanes to William James and derives the concept of fiduciary polytheism. Chapter 2 reconstructs the literary tradition of diminished divinity, from Schiller's lament for the gods of Greece and Heine's gods in exile through Zelazny, Ellison, Pratchett and Gaiman's own *Sandman*.

Part II, Economies, analyzes the novel's two sacred economies. Chapter 3 treats Odin and the economy of sacrifice; Chapter 4 treats the new gods and the economy of attention.

Part III, Geographies, examines the novel's sacred spaces. Chapter 5 reads the land, the road and the roadside attraction through Eliade, Lawrence and Deloria. Chapter 6 reads the "Coming to America" interludes against the ideology of the nation of immigrants and its settler-colonial unconscious.

Part IV, Dramaturgies, examines the novel's three dominant modes. Chapter 7 reads Wednesday as the culmination of the American confidence-man tradition. Chapter 8 reads Lakeside as folk horror and theodicy. Chapter 9 reads Laura and the novel's goddesses through the Gothic body and the alchemical marriage.

Part V, Synthesis, advances the study's central claims. Chapter 10 identifies the Odinic con with the sacrificial logic of American civil religion. Chap-

ter 11 develops the ethics of default and the conjuror's covenant. The Conclusion reads the novel as its own conjuring trick and its adaptation history as a demonstration of its thesis. An appendix provides a concordance of the novel's deities and their sources.

PART

I

Genealogies

1 *"The Old Gods Are Growing Old"*

2 *Gods in Exile*

CHAPTER

1

"The Old Gods Are Growing Old"

A Social Ontology of the Divine

The premise of *American Gods* — that gods are made, sustained and starved by human practice — is the oldest heresy in Western thought and the founding axiom of the modern sociology of religion. This chapter reconstructs that lineage in order to show what Gaiman adds to it. The addition is decisive: where the tradition from Xenophanes to Durkheim understood gods as *projections*, the novel understands them as *liabilities* — entities that exist on a ledger, that are owed and that owe, that can be pledged, counterfeited and defaulted upon. The chapter culminates in William James's pragmatist theory of truth as credit, the point at which the projection theory becomes a fiduciary theory, and from which the concept of fiduciary polytheism is derived.

1.1 *The Anthropomorphic Critique and the Euhemerist Inheritance*

Xenophanes of Colophon (fl. c. 530 BCE) inaugurated the critique in two fragments: that if horses and oxen had hands they would draw their gods as horses and oxen, and that Ethiopians make their gods dark and snub-nosed while Thracians make theirs blue-eyed and red-haired (frs. B15–16). The fragments establish what the novel assumes: a god bears the impress of its people, and therefore travels with them. Gaiman's deities are visibly ethnic. They

wear the faces, accents and occupations of the communities that carried them, and they age as those communities assimilate.

The second classical inheritance is euhemerism. Euhemerus of Messene, in his *Sacred History* (c. 300 BCE), proposed that the gods had been mortal kings deified by grateful subjects. Christian apologists seized on the theory to demote the pagan pantheons, and its most consequential medieval application concerns the novel's own presiding deity. In the Prologue to the *Prose Edda* (c. 1220) and in *Ynglinga saga*, Snorri Sturluson explains the Æsir as men from Asia — descendants of Troy — who migrated into Scandinavia and were taken for gods by the peoples they ruled. The etymological pun (*Æsir* from *Asia*) is false; the narrative structure is prophetic. In the very text that preserves Norse mythology for posterity, Odin is already an immigrant whose divinity is an effect of his reception. *American Gods* doubles Snorri's migration. The Odin whom Snorri brought from Asia to Sweden is carried again, by the novel's first interlude, from Scandinavia to Vinland, where the voyagers who brought him are slaughtered and the god is left behind to wait a thousand years for worshippers.

A third ancient source is woven into the novel's fabric with particular economy. Shadow reads Herodotus in confinement. Herodotus remarks (*Histories* 2.53) that the Greeks had known whence each god came, and what forms they bore, only since yesterday or the day before, as it were — because Homer and Hesiod, living some four centuries before his time, composed the Greek theogony, named the gods, assigned their honors and arts, and described their shapes. The father of history thus attributes the Greek pantheon to two poets. Cicero called Herodotus *pater historiae*; Plutarch, in *On the Malice of Herodotus*, accused him of fabulation. The novel inherits this double patronage. Its protagonist's reading matter authorizes the claim that gods are made by those who tell of them, and the reputation of that reading matter authorizes the suspicion that history and myth are produced by the same faculty.

1.2 *Projection and Fetish: Feuerbach and Marx*

Ludwig Feuerbach's *The Essence of Christianity* (1841; translated by George Eliot, 1854) gave the anthropomorphic critique its modern form. God is the objectified essence of the human species: humanity projects its own predicates — reason, love, will — into an external being, and then worships the projection as other. The secret of theology is anthropology. Feuerbach's project

was therapeutic. Recognition of the projection would restore to humanity the powers it had alienated.

American Gods accepts the projection and refuses the therapy. Its gods are Feuerbachian projections that have acquired independent agency, appetites and interests that diverge from those of their projectors. Hinzelmann, the kobold of Lakeside, is the limit case: a projection of communal desire for prosperity that consumes the community's children in exchange. Feuerbach's alienated essence has become a creditor.

Karl Marx supplied the decisive conversion from theology to economy. In the section of *Capital* (1867; translated by Samuel Moore and Edward Aveling, 1887) devoted to the fetishism of commodities, Marx explains the commodity by analogy with religion: to find an analogy, he writes, we must have recourse to "the mist-enveloped regions of the religious world," where "the productions of the human brain appear as independent beings endowed with life." A definite social relation between people assumes, in the commodity as in the god, the fantastic form of a relation between things.

Gaiman reverses the direction of the analogy. Marx explains commodities by gods; *American Gods* explains gods by commodities. The new gods are fetishes in Marx's technical sense: social relations — between viewers and broadcasters, users and networks, drivers and highways — appearing as autonomous beings. The Technical Boy is the internet's social relations congealed into a petulant adolescent; Media is the broadcast relation incarnate. The old gods, for their part, are revealed as having always been fetishes of an older economy — the relation between a tribe and its hunting grounds, a city and its harvest, a household and its luck — whose social basis has dissolved. The novel thereby extends Marx's analysis backwards: all gods are commodity fetishes, differing only in the mode of production that sustains them.

1.3 *Effervescence and Senescence: Durkheim*

Émile Durkheim's *The Elementary Forms of the Religious Life* (1912; translated by Joseph Ward Swain, 1915) remains the most powerful single theory behind the novel's premise. Durkheim defines religion as "a unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things" that unite their adherents "into one single moral community." His analysis of Australian totemism yields the identification on which the novel rests: the god of the clan can be nothing other than the clan itself, personified and represented to the imagination under the

form of its totem. Gods are generated and renewed in *collective effervescence*, the heightened energy of assembled crowds in ritual, and they decline when the assemblies cease.

In the conclusion to *Elementary Forms*, Durkheim diagnosed his own age in terms that read as the novel's premise stated nine decades early: "the old gods are growing old or already dead, and others are not yet born." He dismissed Auguste Comte's attempt to manufacture a positivist Religion of Humanity from historical souvenirs, insisting that only life itself, not a dead past, can produce a living cult.

The Durkheimian frame illuminates the failure at the novel's center. Wednesday's council of the old gods, convened backstage after a ride on the House on the Rock's carousel, is an attempt at collective effervescence that cannot reach critical mass: the gods assemble without a congregation. The new gods present the converse anomaly. They command vast congregations that never assemble — the dispersed audience of broadcast and network — and so enjoy worship without effervescence, a sacred without a church. Durkheim could not imagine this. His theory requires co-presence; the new gods subsist on simultaneity without co-presence, the condition Benedict Anderson identified in the newspaper reader's imagined community. The novel's war is, at one level, the attempt of the old gods to restore co-presence to the sacred — to assemble, at a single place and moment, a congregation large enough to be felt.

1.4 *The Dependent God: Mystical Precedents*

The proposition that God requires the believer did not originate in sociology. It is a recurrent paradox of Christian mysticism, and its most compressed statement is a couplet of Angelus Silesius in the *Cherubinischer Wandersmann* (1657):

> *Ich weiß, daß ohne mich Gott nicht ein Nu kann leben;*
> *Werd' ich zunicht, er muß von Not den Geist aufgeben.*

— "I know that without me God cannot live for an instant; were I brought to nothing, He would of necessity give up the ghost." Rilke restated the paradox in the *Stundenbuch* (1905): "*Was wirst du tun, Gott, wenn ich sterbe? / Ich bin dein Krug* (*wenn ich zerscherbe?*)" — "What will you do, God, when I die? I am your jug (when I shatter?)." C. G. Jung's *Answer to Job* (1952) gave the

paradox a psychological rationale: the divine requires human consciousness in order to become conscious of itself.

What the mystics held as a paradox of love, *American Gods* presents as a fact of social reproduction. Silesius's God gives up the ghost if the soul is annihilated; Gaiman's gods give up the ghost when the grandchildren stop leaving out milk. Rilke's image is especially apt for the novel's economics, for a jug is a vessel of storage and exchange. The believer is the container in which divinity is kept. When the believer shatters — dies, forgets, assimilates — the god is spilled.

1.5 *Plausibility, Fragility, and Delegated Belief*

Peter Berger and Thomas Luckmann's *The Social Construction of Reality* (1966) and Berger's *The Sacred Canopy* (1967) provide the sociology of knowledge for the novel's immigrant gods. Any religious world is maintained by a *plausibility structure* — the network of social relations, conversations and institutions within which its reality is taken for granted. Migration destroys plausibility structures. The immigrant's gods remain real only so long as the community that confirms them remains intact, and assimilation into a pluralist host society dissolves that community within two or three generations. Berger's *The Heretical Imperative* (1979) adds that pluralism converts religion from fate into choice: in a society of competing worldviews, every believer is compelled to choose, which is to say compelled to heresy in the etymological sense (*hairesis*, choice). Charles Taylor's *A Secular Age* (2007) names the resulting condition *fragilization*: in the presence of credible alternatives, every belief becomes provisional. The old gods of *American Gods* are fragilized gods, maintained by communities that know they might believe otherwise.

The novel adds a refinement absent from the sociology of knowledge. Belief, in Gaiman's America, need not be held by anyone in particular. Easter thrives, to Wednesday's irritation, on a festival whose celebrants neither know her name nor credit her existence. Robert Pfaller's concept of *illusions without owners* names exactly this phenomenon: illusions — the Easter bunny, knocking on wood, the polite fiction — maintained by everyone and believed by no one, because each participant attributes the belief to some imagined naïve observer. Octave Mannoni's formula of fetishistic disavowal, *je sais bien, mais quand même* — "I know very well, but all the same" — and Slavoj Žižek's elaboration of *interpassive* belief, in which belief is delegated to others or to objects, describe the same structure.

The structure is not merely psychological. It is the structure of fiat money, which is accepted by each holder because each holder expects others to accept it. The gods of *American Gods* are sustained by expectations of expectations. This is the bridge from the sociology of religion to the theory of money, and the novel's own philosophical tradition supplies the crossing.

1.6 *Truth on a Credit System: The Pragmatist Turn*

In the sixth lecture of *Pragmatism* (1907), William James — whose philosophy is the most distinctively American contribution to the discipline — formulated his theory of truth in explicitly monetary terms:

> Truth lives, in fact, for the most part on a credit system. Our thoughts and beliefs "pass," so long as nothing challenges them, just as bank-notes pass so long as nobody refuses them.

James's metaphor is not ornamental. His pragmatism repeatedly asks for the "cash-value" of an idea, and "The Will to Believe" (1896) defends the legitimacy of belief in cases where the belief itself helps to create the fact believed in. *American Gods* literalizes James. Its gods pass so long as nobody refuses them. They are bank-notes of the sacred, circulating on the strength of continued acceptance and collapsing the moment acceptance is withdrawn.

The credit theory of money, developed contemporaneously with James, completes the translation. A. Mitchell-Innes argued in "What Is Money?" (1913) that money is not a commodity but a credit, a record of debt. Bernhard Laum's *Heiliges Geld* (1924) traced Greek coinage to the sacrificial cult: the *obol* derives from the *obelos*, the iron spit on which sacrificial meat was distributed, and the ox, unit of sacrifice, served as an early unit of account. Michel Aglietta and André Orléan's *La violence de la monnaie* (1982), drawing on René Girard, theorized money as an institution that resolves the mimetic violence of exchange in the manner that sacrifice resolves the mimetic violence of the community. Orléan's later work describes monetary value as self-referential belief: money is accepted because it is expected to be accepted.

Nietzsche had already supplied the genealogical link between debt and divinity. In the second essay of *On the Genealogy of Morals* (1887), he argued that the tribe's sense of indebtedness to its founding ancestors grows in proportion to the tribe's power, until the ancestor is necessarily transfigured into a god; the Christian God, as the maximum god yet attained, brought with Him the maximum feeling of indebtedness; and the decline of faith might bring a

"second innocence," freedom from debt to one's origins. Walter Benjamin's fragment "Capitalism as Religion" (1921) inverted the relation: capitalism is a purely cultic religion without dogma, celebrated without pause, which produces guilt and debt (German *Schuld* means both) rather than atoning for them, and whose god must remain hidden. Horkheimer and Adorno's *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944/47) closed the circuit by proposing that exchange is secularized sacrifice and sacrifice is already a cunning exchange — a human device for controlling gods, who are overthrown by the very system of homage paid to them.

From these convergent analyses the study derives its central definition:

> **Fiduciary polytheism**: a religious order in which a god exists as a liability on the books of a human community and as an asset on its own; in which divinity circulates as credit, secured by collateral, and exploited by confidence; and in which a god lives exactly as long as its notes pass.

The definition yields predictions the census model cannot. Gods can be sustained by belief that no one holds (Easter). Gods can be counterfeited (Wednesday's serial aliases; the dwarf-king Alviss, whose name the American ear cannot but hear as Elvis). Gods can be arbitraged (Wednesday and Loki working both sides of the war). Gods can be revalued (Czernobog, the black god, drifting toward his white twin Bielebog with the season). And gods are subject to panic — a run on divinity, which is what the war is designed to provoke.

1.7 *The American Paradox Resolved*

The fiduciary model resolves the paradox stated in the Introduction. Tocqueville, writing in the 1830s, judged that religion in America, though it took no direct part in government, must be regarded as "the foremost of the political institutions" of the country, and predicted that in democratic nations "faith in public opinion will become a species of religion," with "the majority its ministering prophet." Tocqueville's insight is fiduciary. Where opinion is sovereign, credibility is a function of circulation, and the sacred is whatever the majority currently accepts.

America's religious history bears out both halves of the paradox. Harold Bloom's *The American Religion* (1992) argued that the nation's indigenous faith is a Gnosticism of the solitary self, issuing in such native creations as Mormonism, whose doctrine of eternal progression was compressed in

Lorenzo Snow's couplet of the 1840s — "As man now is, God once was; as God now is, man may be." The Book of Mormon (1830) answers Dorson's informants directly: Christ, it narrates, did come to America. The twentieth century added the Nation of Islam, founded on the claim that God appeared in person in Detroit in 1930; Scientology, devised by a writer of science fiction; and Heaven's Gate, whose members died in 1997 to board a spacecraft trailing a comet. America is the world's most prolific issuer of new gods. It is also, as *American Gods* insists, the world's most efficient destroyer of them. Both facts follow from a single premise. Where gods are issued freely on credit, they default freely.

The United States has inscribed this premise on its currency. The motto "In God We Trust" first appeared on the two-cent piece of 1864, struck in the midst of the Civil War, and has appeared on paper money since 1957. The nation's god is, constitutionally and numismatically, an object of *trust* — the fiduciary relation itself. Chapter 10 returns to the coins Shadow carries. Before that, the study must establish the literary tradition from which the novel's diminished gods descend.

CHAPTER

2

Gods in Exile

The Literary Genealogy of Diminished Divinity

The diminished god is a figure with a literary history of nearly two thousand years: a deity that outlives its cult, shrinks in stature, takes work beneath its station, or comes back from oblivion degraded or monstrous. *American Gods* is the fullest synthesis of that history. This chapter reconstructs it in order to separate three regimes in which the diminished god has been imagined. In the **elegiac** regime the god is an absence to be mourned (Plutarch, Schiller, Hölderlin, Heidegger). In the **gothic** regime the god is a return to be feared (Machen, Blackwood, Lovecraft). In the **economic** regime the god is a worker to be pitied or mocked (Heine, Kipling, Adams, Pratchett). Gaiman's novel inhabits all three. Its originality lies in a fourth regime, which the tradition approaches but never enters: the **fiduciary**, in which a god's diminishment is a question not of faith but of solvency.

2.1 *"Great Pan Is Dead": The Plutarchan Default*

The founding text of the tradition is Plutarch's dialogue *De defectu oraculorum* (c. 100 CE), conventionally titled *On the Obsolescence of Oracles*. Its speakers, gathered at Delphi, ask why the oracles of Greece have fallen silent, and they offer two explanations that together contain the ontology of *American Gods* in embryo.

The first explanation is demographic. Greece, one speaker observes, has been so depopulated that the whole country could now barely field the three thousand hoplites that Megara alone had sent to Plataea. The god has therefore withdrawn the oracles that are no longer needed, much as an economy closes outlets when demand falls. This is the earliest census theory of the sacred: divine presence rises and falls with the population that sustains it.

The second explanation is metaphysical. The *daimones*, the intermediaries between gods and men, are not immortal but only long-lived. The speakers estimate their lifespans from a riddling fragment of Hesiod that ranks the longevity of the crow, the stag, the raven, the phoenix and the nymph. On this account, divine beings age and die.

The evidence offered for the mortality of daemons became the most famous anecdote in the history of religion. Epitherses, a teacher of grammar, recalls a voyage in the reign of Tiberius on which the ship drifted near the islands of Paxi. A voice from the shore called the Egyptian pilot Thamus by name and ordered him, on reaching Palodes, to announce that Great Pan was dead. Thamus obeyed, and a great lamentation, mixed with cries of astonishment, rose from the land. Tiberius then summoned scholars to determine which Pan had died.

The anecdote's afterlife traces the history of the tradition itself. Eusebius (*Praeparatio evangelica* 5.17) read it as the expulsion of demons at the time of Christ's ministry. Rabelais (*Quart Livre*, ch. 28) identified the dead Pan with Christ, the "All" who died for all. Milton's ode "On the Morning of Christ's Nativity" (1629) declared the oracles dumb and drove the pagan pantheon from the earth: Peor and Baalim, Moloch, and the animal-headed gods of the Nile — Isis, Orus and "the dog Anubis" — all flee the infant in the manger. Elizabeth Barrett Browning's "The Dead Pan" (1844) made the story a Victorian commonplace.

Milton's catalogue and Gaiman's novel describe the same deities at two different moments. The Egyptian gods whom the Nativity Ode banished from the world turn up again in Cairo, Illinois, running a funeral home. Anubis and Thoth, as Mr. Jacquel and Mr. Ibis, keep their ancient offices — guide of the dead and scribe of the dead — inside a small family business. The distance between banishment and underemployment is the whole distance between the Christian narrative of triumph and the modern economic one. Milton's gods are defeated by a rival god. Gaiman's are outcompeted by an absence.

Plutarch's title also names the condition that this study places at the center of the novel's ethics. *Defectus* means failure, desertion and lack. In astro-

nomical Latin, *defectus solis* and *defectus lunae* are the eclipses of the sun and the moon. English *default*, through Old French *defaute*, descends from *fallere*, which means both to fail and to deceive. The *defectus* of the oracles is therefore at once a failure of presence, a failure of payment and an eclipse. The novel's protagonist bears a name that describes the last of these: a shadow on the moon. Chapter 11 returns to what it means that the hero's name is an eclipse.

2.2 *The Destitute Time: Schiller, Hölderlin, Heidegger, Nietzsche*

German Hellenism turned Plutarch's anecdote into a philosophy of history. Schiller's elegy "Die Götter Griechenlandes" (1788) set the terms. In the Greek world, the poem holds, every tree sheltered a dryad and every spring a nymph. When the gods were more human, humans were more divine (*Da die Götter menschlicher noch waren, / Waren Menschen göttlicher*). Modern nature, by contrast, is *die entgötterte Natur*, nature stripped of its gods, which serves the law of gravity as slavishly as the dead beat of a pendulum clock.

Schiller's image deserves emphasis: the first modern figure for what replaces the gods is a machine. The pendulum clock is the ancestor of Technical Boy. Commentators have traced Max Weber's "disenchantment of the world" (*Entzauberung der Welt*) back to Schiller's *Entgötterung*, and Chapter 4 follows Weber's argument to its end, where the disenchanted gods return.

Hölderlin's "Brot und Wein" (1800–01) refined Schiller's elegy into a doctrine of divine absence:

> *Aber Freund! wir kommen zu spät. Zwar leben die Götter,*
> *Aber über dem Haupt droben in anderer Welt.*

"But, friend, we come too late. The gods are living, it is true, but above our heads, up in another world." The gods are not dead but withdrawn, and the age that has lost them is a *dürftige Zeit*, a destitute or needy time. The same poem asks what poets are for in such a time (*und wozu Dichter in dürftiger Zeit?*). Its answer is that they are like the priests of the wine-god, who wander from land to land through the holy night. The poet keeps vigil through the night of the gods' absence.

Heidegger took Hölderlin's question as the title of a lecture of 1946, "Wozu Dichter?" There he names the condition of the destitute time *der Fehl Gottes*, a phrase that Albert Hofstadter's English translation renders as "the default of God." For Heidegger, the default consists in this: no god any longer gath-

ers human beings and things to itself and thereby gives order to the world's history. The poet's task is to trace the track of the fugitive gods.

The convergence of terms is not accidental. Plutarch's *defectus* and Heidegger's *Fehl* both conceive the absence of the divine as a default — a failure of presence that is also, latently, a failure of obligation. *American Gods* inverts the Heideggerian figure. Its gods have not defaulted on humanity. They are present, visible and destitute; it is their worshippers who have defaulted on them. Hölderlin's night-watching poet nonetheless survives in the novel in transfigured form. Shadow Moon's nine-day vigil on the ash tree is a literal night-watch: a man keeping watch over a dead god through the night of that god's absence.

Nietzsche supplied the tradition's counter-voice. The madman of *The Gay Science* (§125, 1882) announces that God is dead and that we have killed him, which turns the death of the divine from an event into a deed. In *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* (Part III, "Of the Apostates," 1884), Zarathustra tells a comic theogony. The old gods did not "twilight" themselves to death — a jab at Wagner's *Götterdämmerung* — but laughed themselves to death, on the day one god spoke the most godless word of all: that there is only one God, and no other shall be had beside him. At that, all the gods laughed, rocked on their chairs and cried: *Ist das nicht eben Göttlichkeit, dass es Götter, aber keinen Gott giebt?* — "Is not precisely this divinity, that there are gods but no God?"

Nietzsche's joke is the polytheist manifesto of modernity, and its anti-Wagnerian edge anticipates Gaiman's resolution. *American Gods* prepares a twilight of the gods and then refuses it. Its war is dissolved by a revelation and a story rather than consummated in flame. The novel's genius of laughter is Mr. Nancy — Anansi the spider, god of stories — whose comic tales punctuate the gods' councils. In Gaiman as in Nietzsche, laughter is the alternative to the twilight.

2.3 *The Menial Apotheosis: Heine, Pater, Kipling, Thorne Smith*

The economic regime begins with Heinrich Heine. "Die Götter im Exil" (1853), developing hints from his earlier *Elementargeister* (1837), proposes that after the triumph of Christianity the Olympians did not perish. They went underground and, like other émigrés, had to find work. Apollo hired himself out as a herdsman in Lower Austria, where his singing was so beautiful that he was recognized and tried as a heretic. Bacchus became father superior of a Tyrolean monastery whose brothers hold secret bacchanals at

the autumn equinox. Mercury, in a reworking of Procopius's ancient legend of fishermen forced to ferry the souls of the dead across the sea to Britain, appears as a merchant who hires a fisherman to carry a cargo of invisible passengers. Jupiter, old and destitute, lives on a bleak island in the Arctic Sea, trading rabbit skins to passing whalers.

Heine's essay is the closest structural ancestor of Gaiman's novel. Its gods outlive the death of their cults as wage-laborers and petty traders, their divinity visible only to the initiated eye. Gaiman's psychopomps in the funeral trade reproduce Heine's Mercury almost exactly: the office of conducting souls persists inside a commercial form. Czernobog in the slaughterhouse, the Queen of Sheba in the sex trade, Mad Sweeney in the barroom and Wednesday in the grift extend Heine's catalogue to an entire pantheon.

The difference between the two texts is instructive. Heine's gods are refugees from a victorious monotheism, and they hide because they are persecuted. Gaiman's gods face no victorious rival faith. The Christian God is almost wholly absent from *American Gods*, and its deities are defeated not by a competing creed but by a market without a creed — by distraction. Heine's gods are hunted; Gaiman's are ignored.

Walter Pater took up Heine's conceit explicitly. "Denys l'Auxerrois" (1886, collected in *Imaginary Portraits*, 1887) opens by invoking the gods in exile and imagines Dionysus returning to medieval Auxerre as a mysterious youth whose presence revives the vintage and ends in his dismemberment by a frenzied crowd. "Apollo in Picardy" (1893) brings Apollo to a monastery in Picardy, where he again kills a beloved boy in a game of throwing, as in the myth of Hyacinthus. Pater adds to Heine the principle that the exiled god's return re-enacts the violence of his myth. Gaiman's revenant gods obey the same principle: the Hanged God, returned to America, requires another hanging.

Rudyard Kipling's *Puck of Pook's Hill* (1906) offers the most exact anticipation of Gaiman's premise. In "Weland's Sword," Puck tells two Sussex children how Weland, the smith-god of the North, came to England with Scandinavian seafarers and was honored with sacrifice. As belief failed, he dwindled, until he was reduced to shoeing travelers' horses for a penny left on a stone at Weland's Smithy. He was released from this servitude only when a young Saxon novice thanked him for his work. In "Dymchurch Flit," the People of the Hills leave England en masse during the upheavals of the Reformation.

Kipling's god is carried in by Scandinavian seafarers, sustained by sacrifice and reduced by disbelief to a tradesman's labor — Gaiman's Odin in every

particular except scale. The mechanism of Weland's release deserves attention, because this study will argue that Gaiman's novel rediscovers it. The god is freed not by a sacrifice but by gratitude: a gift of words that cancels a servitude no payment could discharge. Gaiman has acknowledged Kipling's *The Jungle Book* as the model for his own *The Graveyard Book* (2008).

The menial-god conceit first crossed to the United States as farce. Thorne Smith's *The Night Life of the Gods* (1931) brings to life the statues of the Olympians in the Metropolitan Museum of Art and turns them loose in Prohibition-era Manhattan, where they drink, brawl and court. Smith establishes that the American comedy of the gods is a comedy of appetite in a commercial city. Gaiman inherits the comedy and adds the bill.

2.4 *The Gothic Return: Machen, Blackwood, Dunsany, Lovecraft*

The gothic regime inverts the elegiac. Its gods are not absent but terribly present, and their return is experienced as horror. Arthur Machen's *The Great God Pan* (1894) is its charter. A surgeon's operation on a young woman's brain allows her to "see the great god Pan," and the child of that vision, Helen Vaughan, moves through London society leaving a trail of suicides among the men she meets. Machen's Pan is the antithesis of Plutarch's: not dead but unbearably alive, the fullness of nature experienced as annihilation.

The Edwardian weird tale elaborated the type. In E. F. Benson's "The Man Who Went Too Far" (1904), a man who seeks union with Pan is found dead with the marks of hooves on his body. In Saki's "The Music on the Hill" (1911), a woman who scorns the rustic god's cult is gored to death. Algernon Blackwood's "The Willows" (1907) and "The Wendigo" (1910) followed; the latter brings an Algonquian spirit of hunger into the English-language weird tale and so prefigures the land-spirits of Gaiman's America.

Lord Dunsany's *The Gods of Pegāna* (1905) contributed an invented theogony of precarious gods. The deities of Pegāna exist only while their maker, Mana-Yood-Sushai, rests, lulled by the drummer Skarl, who must drum forever. When the maker wakes, he will make new gods and unmake the old. A century early, Dunsany formulated two principles of Gaiman's novel: that gods depend on an act of sustained attention, and that new gods are made through the obsolescence of the old.

Machen made a second contribution to the tradition, this one outside fiction. "The Bowmen," a short story published in the London *Evening News* in September 1914, described the phantom bowmen of Agincourt, summoned

by a soldier's prayer to Saint George, rescuing the British Expeditionary Force during the retreat from Mons. Within months the story was circulating as fact. Sermons, pamphlets and soldiers' testimonies confirmed the "Angels of Mons," and Machen's repeated insistence that he had invented the episode was brushed aside. His readers preferred the legend to its author.

The Angels of Mons are the cleanest modern case of a fiction becoming credit beyond its issuer's power to recall it — an illusion without owners, in Robert Pfaller's sense, entering history. This study calls the phenomenon **the Machen effect**: the author of a sacred fiction forfeits the right to redeem it, because belief, once in circulation, belongs to those who hold it. *American Gods* is a novel about the Machen effect on the scale of civilizations. Its gods are fictions that their peoples can no longer recall, even when they would.

H. P. Lovecraft is the tradition's antithetical figure. "The Horror at Red Hook" (1927) imagines an immigrant district of Brooklyn as the breeding ground of an ancient cult of Lilith. "The Call of Cthulhu" (1928) assigns the worship of the Great Old Ones to racially mixed congregations in the swamps of Louisiana and the islands of the South Seas. Lovecraft's horror of immigrant religion is the inverse image of Gaiman's sympathy for it. The two writers share a premise — that immigrants carried their gods to America — and differ on its emotional valence. For Lovecraft the transported gods are contamination; for Gaiman they are pathos.

Gaiman knew the Lovecraftian tradition from the inside. His pastiches "Only the End of the World Again" (1994) and "Shoggoth's Old Peculiar" (1998) treat its cosmic horror as comedy. *American Gods* moves the horror from the immigrant enclave to the assimilated small town. The monster of Lakeside is an imported spirit, but the horror lies in the town's prosperous and willing complicity.

2.5 *The Crossing Answered: Irving, Hawthorne, Longfellow, Whitman*

Dorson's informants held that the spirits of the old country did not cross the ocean. American literature had answered otherwise from the start. In Washington Irving's "Rip Van Winkle" (1819), the crew of Hendrick Hudson plays ninepins in the Catskills, and their game is heard in the valley as thunder: the Dutch dead naturalized as American weather. When Rip returns from his twenty-year sleep, he finds that the inn's signboard portrait of King George has been repainted, the red coat turned to blue and buff and the scepter to a sword, and relabeled "General Washington." The Revolution appears as an

iconographic substitution on a tavern sign: the image of sovereignty kept, its referent changed. This is the novel's dialectic of old and new gods in miniature, and its lesson is Gaiman's: the face on the sign persists, and only the name is new. Irving's "The Legend of Sleepy Hollow" (1820) supplied America's best-known revenant, the ghost of a Hessian mercenary — an immigrant who would not leave.

Nathaniel Hawthorne's "The May-Pole of Merry Mount" (1836) narrates the first American war of the gods. In 1627 Thomas Morton and his companions raised a maypole at Merry Mount, near present-day Quincy, Massachusetts, and kept the revels of old England — rites that Morton's *New English Canaan* (1637) dressed in the trappings of pagan antiquity — until John Endecott's Puritans cut the pole down. Hawthorne frames the episode as a contest in which "jollity and gloom were contending for an empire." The old gods of English festivity lost that contest on American soil before the nation existed.

Charles Brockden Brown's *Wieland* (1798), the first major American novel of religious horror, staged a darker version. The ventriloquist Carwin's imitation of disembodied voices precedes Theodore Wieland's murder of his wife and children in obedience to what he believes is a divine command to sacrifice them. Chapter 7 reads *Wieland* as the American ur-text of the con that becomes a sacrifice.

The Norse gods entered American letters as antiquarian romance. Longfellow's "The Skeleton in Armor" (1841) gave voice to the ghost of a Viking warrior imagined as the builder of the old stone tower at Newport, Rhode Island. His *Tales of a Wayside Inn* (1863) opens "The Saga of King Olaf" with Thor's challenge to Christ:

> *I am the God Thor,*
> *I am the War God,*
> *I am the Thunderer!*

Thor goes on to defy the Galilean to single combat. The poem appeared in 1863, the year of Gettysburg and of the battle on Lookout Mountain. An American poet staged a war between the old gods and the new in the very year that the novel's own battlefield was consecrated by the dead.

The cult of Norse priority in America culminated in the Kensington Runestone. It was "discovered" in 1898 on a Minnesota farm owned by a Swedish immigrant, carries an inscription describing a Norse expedition of 1362, and is now generally regarded as a modern fabrication. It is displayed in a museum

in Alexandria, Minnesota, near a fiberglass Viking colossus. The American cult of the Norse is fakelore in Dorson's exact sense, and it ends, as Gaiman's novel predicts, in a roadside attraction.

The decisive American precedent, however, is Whitman's. In section 41 of "Song of Myself" (1855; final text 1891–92), the poet surveys the gods of the world in the language of the exchange:

> *Magnifying and applying come I,*
> *Outbidding at the start the old cautious hucksters,*
> *Taking myself the exact dimensions of Jehovah,*
> *Lithographing Kronos, Zeus his son, and Hercules his grandson,*
> *Buying drafts of Osiris, Isis, Belus, Brahma, Buddha,*
> *In my portfolio placing Manito loose, Allah on a leaf, the crucifix engraved,*
> *With Odin and the hideous-faced Mexitli and every idol and image,*
> *Taking them all for what they are worth and not a cent more*

The vocabulary is commercial, with an exactness critics have rarely remarked. The poet outbids hucksters. He buys *drafts* — bills of exchange — drawn on Osiris and Brahma. He holds the gods in a *portfolio*. He values them at what they are worth and not a cent more. Odin and Mexitli — that is, Huitzilopochtli, war god of the Mexica — stand side by side: the two great sacrificial war gods of the novel's two hemispheres.

Whitman's procedure is to acquire the world's gods at face value and then redistribute their divinity. As the section continues, he accepts the rough sketches of the gods in order to fill them out better in himself, and he bestows them freely on every man and woman he sees. Whitman anticipates both halves of the present thesis. His America is a clearing-house in which gods circulate as financial instruments. His resolution — the free bestowal of divinity on every citizen — is a democratic jubilee, a cancellation of divine debt by universal distribution. *American Gods* rediscovers both moves. It shows the gods as instruments of credit, and it ends with a man who refuses to be a god's instrument and declines to become a god.

2.6 *The Pantheon Novel from Zelazny to Pratchett*

The second half of the twentieth century produced a dense literature of transplanted, commodified and contractual gods, of which *American Gods* is the summation.

Roger Zelazny's *Lord of Light* (1967) imagines the crew of a colony ship who use advanced technology to set themselves up as the Hindu pantheon

over the descendants of their passengers. Godhead becomes a technological monopoly, which the revolutionary Sam subverts by reviving Buddhism. Zelazny's *Creatures of Light and Darkness* (1969) did the same for the Egyptian gods.

Jack Kirby's "Fourth World" comics (1970–73) begin with the death of the old gods in a final battle and the rise of new ones. Their founding myth is a peace sealed by the exchange of sons as hostages between the rival gods Highfather and Darkseid — a structure that reproduces the hostage exchange ending the Eddic war of the Æsir and the Vanir (Chapter 3). Kirby's hostage son, Scott Free, becomes Mister Miracle, an escape artist: a conjuror-hero who, like Shadow, practices the art of acknowledged illusion. Gaiman, who began as a writer of comics, inherited from Kirby the very phrase "new gods."

Harlan Ellison's *Deathbird Stories: A Pantheon of Modern Gods* (1975) anticipated the new-gods half of Gaiman's premise. Its stories present the deities of the modern city — the god of the slot machine, the god of the freeway — as the true objects of contemporary worship. In "Pretty Maggie Moneyeyes" (1967), a dead woman's soul inhabits a Las Vegas slot machine and consumes the gambler who plays it.

Diana Wynne Jones's *Eight Days of Luke* (1975), a novel for children, embodies the Norse gods as the days of the week: Odin appears as "Mr. Wedding," Loki as the boy Luke. Gaiman has acknowledged the debt. Douglas Adams's *The Long Dark Tea-Time of the Soul* (1988) installs Odin in a private hospital in England, where he has signed away his divinity in exchange for clean sheets and attentive care, while Thor rages through airports. The transfer of godhead takes the form of a legal contract. Gaiman knew Adams's work intimately; his companion to *The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy*, *Don't Panic*, appeared the same year.

Terry Pratchett's *Small Gods* (1992) gave the census model its canonical comic form. Divine power is proportional to belief. The great god Om, whose vast church believes in its own institutions rather than in him, manifests as a tortoise with a single true believer, and the desert is full of small gods who have never gained a follower. Pratchett's satire contains a fiduciary insight: the Omnian church has become a financial vehicle detached from its underlying asset, a structure that keeps trading after the asset has failed.

Pratchett's *Hogfather* (1996) adds the theory that Gaiman's novel completes. Death, standing in for the Discworld's midwinter gift-bringer, argues that human beings must learn to believe small fictions in order to believe the large ones — justice, mercy, duty — of which there is not a single atom in

the physical universe. Pratchett's case for acknowledged fiction as the school of moral life is the closest antecedent of what Chapter 11 calls the conjuror's covenant. Tom Robbins's *Jitterbug Perfume* (1984), in which Pan fades as belief fades, and Dan Simmons's *Song of Kali* (1985), in which a goddess is the horror at the heart of a modern metropolis, complete the field.

Gaiman's own *Sandman* (1989–96) served as the laboratory for *American Gods*. In *Season of Mists* (1990–91), the gods of many pantheons converge on the realm of Dream to bid for the key to an abandoned Hell — a divine real-estate auction. In *Brief Lives* (1992–93), the Babylonian Ishtar, working as a dancer in a strip club, releases her divinity in a final dance that destroys the club and herself; she is the direct prototype of the novel's Bilquis. In "Three Septembers and a January" (*Sandman* #31, 1991), Gaiman told the story of Joshua Norton, the bankrupt San Franciscan who in 1859 proclaimed himself Emperor of the United States and whose self-issued scrip local merchants honored — the purest American case of fiduciary sovereignty, a dream that circulated because no one refused it. In *The Kindly Ones* (1994–95), Dream dies in settlement of a blood debt. By the time he wrote *American Gods*, Gaiman had spent a decade imagining gods at auction, gods in the sex trade, sovereigns on credit and deities paying blood debts.

2.7 *From Faith to Solvency*

The genealogy permits a precise statement of the novel's originality. In the elegiac regime, the god is absent and mourned. In the gothic regime, the god is present and feared. In the economic regime, the god is present and pitied. In every case, the god's condition is a function of faith: more of it or less, given or withdrawn. Heine's gods are refugees, Kipling's are servants, Adams's and Pratchett's are dependents.

American Gods completes the economic regime by transforming it. Its gods are debtors and creditors, and their condition is a function of solvency: their ability to meet obligations, to secure their claims and to survive a loss of confidence. The novel is the first in the tradition to grasp that the decisive question about a god is not whether anyone believes in it. The decisive questions are on what terms its credit is extended, what secures that credit, and who profits when it fails.

The literary genealogy explains the novel's materials. It does not explain the novel's economics. For those, the study turns to the god whose mythology already contains a complete theory of pledge, sacrifice and interest.

PART

II

Economies

3 *"Myself to Myself"*

4 *The Altar and the Screen*



CHAPTER

3

"Myself to Myself"

Odin, the Hanged God, and the Economy of Sacrifice

Wednesday is the engine of *American Gods*, and the god he incarnates is the most economically articulated deity in any European mythology. The Eddic and saga corpus records a god who pledges his eye as security for wisdom and sacrifices himself to himself for the runes. He acquires the mead of poetry by seduction and fraud, betrays his own champions to stock his hall with the dead, and stirs up wars in order to harvest their casualties.

Criticism has generally treated Wednesday as a degraded Odin, the Allfather reduced to a grifter by the indignities of American life. This chapter argues the reverse. Wednesday is an exact Odin, and every element of the con at the novel's center is an Eddic or saga motif. The Odinic corpus contains, in compressed mythic form, a complete theory of the sacred as an economy of pledge, sacrifice, interest and reserve. The chapter reconstructs that theory and closes with a definition of the regime Wednesday seeks to restore: the blood standard.

3.1 *The Reflexive Sacrifice*

The central text is the passage of the *Hávamál* known as Odin's Rune Poem, in which the god recounts his own self-sacrifice:

> *Veit ek, at ek hekk*
> *vindga meiði á*
> *nætr allar níu,*
> *geiri undaðr*
> *ok gefinn Óðni,*
> *sjalfr sjalfum mér,*
> *á þeim meiði,*
> *er manngi veit*
> *hvers hann af rótum renn.* (st. 138)

In Henry Adams Bellows's translation (1923), which numbers the stanza 139:

> I ween that I hung on the windy tree,
> Hung there for nights full nine;
> With the spear I was wounded, and offered I was
> To Othin, myself to myself,
> On the tree that none may ever know
> What root beneath it runs.

The phrase *sjalfr sjalfum mér*, "myself to myself," describes a transaction in which sacrificer, victim and recipient are one. Nothing leaves the system; the god deals only with himself. In the vocabulary of finance this is self-dealing. In the comparative study of sacrifice it is what Henri Hubert and Marcel Mauss, in their *Essai sur la nature et la fonction du sacrifice* (1899), identified as sacrifice's logical culmination: the *sacrifice of the god*. For Hubert and Mauss, sacrifice opens communication between the sacred and the profane through the mediation of a victim. When the victim is itself divine, that communication becomes a circuit inside the sacred, and sacrifice reveals its essence as divinity renewing itself through its own destruction.

The Vedic tradition states the principle with the same reflexivity. The *Puruṣa Sūkta* (*Ṛgveda* 10.90) narrates the creation of the world from the dismemberment of a cosmic Person and concludes: *yajñéna yajñám ayajanta devā́s* — "with the sacrifice the gods sacrificed to the sacrifice." The Brāhmaṇas elaborate the same structure in the self-sacrifice of the creator Prajāpati.

James George Frazer set Odin's hanging beside the effigy of Attis hung on the sacred pine in the chapter of *The Golden Bough* titled "The Hanged God"

(in *Adonis, Attis, Osiris*, 1906). T. S. Eliot's note to *The Waste Land* (1922) explained that the Hanged Man of the Tarot suited his purpose because "he is associated in my mind with the Hanged God of Frazer." Germanic Christianity had already made the connection. In the Old English *Dream of the Rood*, the cross speaks. It calls itself a gallows (*gealga*) and describes Christ as a young warrior who strips himself and mounts it eagerly, a hero climbing to his own sacrifice. The crucified God of the north is an Odinic god: one who goes willingly to the tree.

The stanzas after the hanging describe what the sacrifice yields. No one revived the god with bread or drink. He peered downward, took up the runes, took them up screaming, and fell back (st. 139). Then, having drunk of the precious mead, he began to flourish:

> *Þá nam ek frævask*
> *ok fróðr vera*
> *ok vaxa ok vel hafask;*
> *orð mér af orði*
> *orðs leitaði,*
> *verk mér af verki*
> *verks leitaði.* (st. 141)

"Then I began to be fruitful and wise, to grow and to thrive; word sought word for me from word, deed sought deed for me from deed." The return on the sacrifice is generative. Each word begets another word; each deed begets another deed. The figure is compounding.

Aristotle condemned interest as the most unnatural way of acquiring wealth precisely because in it money breeds money; the Greek *tokos* means both "interest" and "offspring" (*Politics* 1258b). Benjamin Franklin, advising a young tradesman in 1748, praised money for exactly that property: it "is of the prolific, generating nature," and its offspring can beget more. The *Hávamál* presents the Odinic sacrifice as the mythic prototype of capital: an initial self-expenditure that returns as self-multiplying yield.

Wednesday's scheme replays the Rune Poem on American soil. He arranges his own death — an assassination carried out under a truce, whose instigator turns out to be his confederate Loki — so that his martyrdom will set off the war whose dead will be offered to him. He sacrifices himself to himself a second time, through his partner as intermediary. Shadow's nine-day vigil on the ash tree then re-enacts the hanging with the son in the father's place.

3.2 *The Pledge of the Father of the Slain*

The Eddic name for Odin's eye is a term from the law of security. The seeress of the *Völuspá* tells Odin that she knows where he hid his eye, in the famous well of Mímir. Every morning, she says, Mímir drinks mead *af veði Valföðrs* — "from the pledge of the Father of the Slain" (st. 28).

Old Norse *veð* means a pledge, a surety, a stake or a wager. It is cognate with Gothic *wadi*, Latin *vas, vadis* ("surety") and Old English *wedd* ("pledge"), and so with English *wed*, *wedding*, *wage* and *wager*. The eye is collateral. Odin deposits it in Mímir's well as security for a draught of wisdom, and the deposit pays a perpetual return: every morning Mímir drinks mead from it. Odin's omniscience is bought on secured credit, and the security stays in the creditor's reservoir.

The mythology does not leave the relationship there. In *Ynglinga saga* (ch. 4), Mímir is sent as a hostage to the Vanir at the end of their war with the Æsir. The Vanir behead him and send back the head, which Odin preserves with herbs and charms and consults as an oracle. The god of the pledge ends up in possession of his creditor's head.

A second Eddic pledge completes the first. In Snorri's *Gylfaginning* (ch. 34), the gods resolve to bind the wolf Fenrir with the magical fetter Gleipnir and present the binding as a test of strength. The wolf suspects fraud and demands a pledge of good faith: one of the gods must put a hand in his mouth. Tyr does so. The gods' promise is false, the wolf is bound, and Tyr loses his hand.

Georges Dumézil read Odin and Tyr as the Germanic forms of the two Indo-European types of sovereign: the magical, terrible sovereign of the Varuṇa type and the juridical, contractual sovereign of the Mitra type. He saw in the binding of Fenrir the founding of cosmic order on a false oath. The two pledged body parts define the Norse sovereign's relation to the pledge. The magician-sovereign pledges and is repaid in wisdom; the jurist-sovereign pledges falsely and pays with his hand. Wednesday combines both types. He pledges, he defrauds, and he arranges for others to pay.

The *Hávamál* itself warns against its speaker. Recounting how Odin obtained the mead of poetry from the giant Suttungr by seducing his daughter Gunnlöð, the poem comments:

> *Baugeið Óðinn*
> *hygg ek at unnit hafi;*
> *hvat skal hans tryggðum trúa?* (st. 110)

"A ring-oath, I believe, Odin swore; how can his pledges be trusted?" He left Suttungr cheated of his drink and Gunnlöð in tears. The text that codifies the Norse ethics of the gift contains a reflexive warning that its own divine author defaults on his oaths. No reader of the *Hávamál* should have been surprised by Wednesday.

Émile Benveniste's analysis of the Indo-European vocabulary of belief supplies the philological ground for this mythology. In *Le vocabulaire des institutions indo-européennes* (1969), he reconstructs the ancestor of Latin *credo* and Vedic *śraddhā* as a compound meaning "to place one's **kred*," a kind of magical force, in a god or hero from whom a return is expected. To believe, on this reconstruction, was to deposit part of one's own power with a divine trustee who was obliged to repay it. Benveniste insists that the religious sense of *credo* and its economic sense — entrusting goods with the certainty of their return — are not metaphorically related but were originally a single institution.

Odin's eye in Mímir's well is the mythic image of **kred-dhē*: a portion of the self deposited in a sacred reservoir, against which wisdom is drawn. The novel's coda, in which Shadow returns to an older, Icelandic Odin the glass eye of his American avatar, is read in Chapter 11 as the restitution of a pledge outside the economy that created it.

3.3 Fé *and* Dómr*: Cattle, Reputation, and Immortal Credit*

The most quoted stanzas of the *Hávamál* oppose two kinds of value:

> *Deyr fé,*
> *deyja frændr,*
> *deyr sjalfr it sama;*
> *ek veit einn*
> *at aldri deyr:*
> *dómr um dauðan hvern.* (st. 77)

Bellows renders it: "Cattle die, and kinsmen die, / And so one dies one's self; / One thing I know that never dies, / The fame of a dead man's deeds."

The opposition is economic before it is moral. Old Norse *fé* means cattle, livestock, property and money all at once. It is cognate with Gothic *faihu*, Old English *feoh* (the source of *fee*), Latin *pecus* (the root of *pecunia*) and Sanskrit *paśu*. The first rune of the futhark, ᚠ, bears its name. The rune poems gloss it with ambivalence. The Norwegian poem says that wealth causes strife among kinsmen. The Old English poem says that wealth is a comfort to every man, but that each must give it out freely if he wishes to win *dom* before the Lord.

Against perishable *fé*, the *Hávamál* sets *dómr* and, in the stanza before, *orðstírr*: judgment and word-glory. Movable wealth dies with the cattle; reputation survives its bearer. This is the structure of the fiduciary god. On this study's argument, a god is a *dómr* — a standing judgment, a reputation in circulation — that outlives the death of all collateral, the herds, the kin and the self, for as long as it continues to be spoken.

The gods of *American Gods* are the *orðstírr* of peoples whose *fé* has died. They are the word-glory of Norse farmers, West African villages and Slavic hamlets, still circulating among strangers after the communities that backed them have dissolved. Mr. Ibis's chronicle of arrivals is the instrument that keeps this word-glory in circulation. The Old English rune poem's alternative — wealth given out freely in order to become *dom* — anticipates the gift economy into which, this study will argue, Shadow converts the sacrificial one.

The convergence of words for cattle, money and sacrifice runs across the Indo-European languages and is the philological core of Bernhard Laum's *Heiliges Geld* (1924). Laum observed that the Homeric unit of account was the ox: the golden armor of Glaukos was worth a hundred oxen, the bronze armor of Diomedes nine (*Iliad* 6.234–36). He argued that the Greek *obolos* derives from *obelos*, the iron spit used to share out the meat of sacrifice.

The Germanic languages preserve a parallel archive. Old English *gield* (also *gild*, *gyld*) means payment and tribute, but also worship, offering and idol; *deofolgield*, literally "devil-payment," means idolatry. The word is cognate with German *Geld*, "money," and English *yield*, and the guild began as an association bound together by a sacrificial feast. In the Germanic north, the word for money and the word for sacrifice are one.

The *Hávamál* states the rule of this economy right after Odin's catechism of the runes, which ends by asking whether the hearer knows how to pray, how to sacrifice, how to send and how to slaughter (st. 144):

> *Betra er óbeðit*
> *en sé ofblótit,*
> *ey sér til gildis gjöf;*
> *betra er ósent*
> *en sé ofsóit.* (st. 145)

"Better unasked than over-sacrificed; a gift always looks to its *gildi*; better unsent than over-slaughtered." The *gildi* is the return: the repayment, the yield. Sacrifice is exchange, and its first law is proportion. The offering must be calibrated to the return it seeks.

Mauss opened the *Essai sur le don* (1925) with a sequence of stanzas from the *Hávamál*, so that the founding text of the anthropology of the gift begins with Odin's sayings. In the Odinic economy, the gravest danger is over-sacrifice: an inflation of offerings beyond their exchange value. Wednesday's war is exactly such an inflation, a hecatomb of gods, an offering without measure. The American Odin violates the law his Icelandic original laid down.

3.4 *Woden-Mercury: The Merchant God*

The earliest classical description of the god the novel calls Wednesday identifies him with Mercury. Tacitus, writing about the Germans in 98 CE, reports: *Deorum maxime Mercurium colunt, cui certis diebus humanis quoque hostiis litare fas habent* — "Of the gods they chiefly worship Mercury, to whom on fixed days they hold it right to sacrifice even human victims" (*Germania* 9).

The formula echoes Caesar's description of the chief god of the Gauls. They held him to be the inventor of all the arts, the guide of roads and journeys, and the god with the greatest power *ad quaestus pecuniae mercaturasque* — over the making of money and over trade (*De bello Gallico* 6.17). The Roman identification held. Paul the Deacon writes of Wotan "whom the Romans call Mercury," and Ælfric's homily *De falsis diis* explains that the heathen Danes honored Mercury under the name Óðon and named the fourth day of the week for him. Latin *dies Mercurii* survives in *mercredi*, *miércoles* and *mercoledì*; Germanic *Wōdnesdæg* survives in *Wednesday*. Mercury's name shares a root with *merx* (merchandise), *mercari* (to trade), *merces* (wages) and *mercenarius* (the hireling).

The god after whom Gaiman named his confidence man was therefore, in his oldest classical identification, the patron of money-making, of trade and of the road. Gaiman's Wednesday — itinerant, eloquent, larcenous, leading a dying pantheon toward its end — is the Roman identification restored.

The Greek Hermes, Mercury's original, makes the lineage explicit. In the *Homeric Hymn to Hermes*, the god is born at dawn and invents the lyre by noon. By evening he has stolen Apollo's cattle and invented the fire-drill and, with it, the first sacrifice, dividing the meat of two cows into twelve portions while refusing to eat any himself. He finally trades the lyre to Apollo in settlement for the stolen herd, and receives the offices of patron of herdsmen, thieves and commerce and guide of souls to Hades.

Norman O. Brown's *Hermes the Thief* (1947) read Hermes's evolution from a trickster of the boundary-stone into the god of the marketplace as the mythic

record of archaic Greece's transformation by trade. Lewis Hyde's *Trickster Makes This World* (1998) made the infant's refusal to eat the sacrificial meat the hinge of his deification: the trickster becomes a god by mastering the appetite that drives his thefts. Gaiman's Wednesday reverses the hinge. His appetite for women, food, drink and money is unmastered, and his scheme aims to feed it on a scale no sacrifice has ever satisfied.

The names of the days preserve this god in the purest form of belief without believers. Every speaker of English invokes Tiw, Woden, Thor and Frigg every week without belief or even knowledge. The calendar is an illusion without owners in Pfaller's sense, a cult maintained entirely by circulation. Gaiman chose for his Odin the form in which the god is most often spoken of in the modern world: as a day of the week. Diana Wynne Jones, in naming her Odin "Mr. Wedding," stumbled on a further truth. Old English *weddian*, "to pledge," is cognate with Old Norse *veð*. Mr. Wedding is, etymologically, Mr. Pledge.

3.5 *Staged Wars: The First War in the World, Brávellir, and the Flower War*

The *Völuspá* attributes the first war in the world to an Odinic act of dedication:

> *Fleygði Óðinn*
> *ok í fólk um skaut;*
> *þat var enn fólkvíg*
> *fyrst í heimi.* (st. 24)

"Odin hurled his spear and shot it into the host; that was yet the first war in the world." A spear cast over an enemy army consecrated its dead to the god. In the *Styrbjarnar þáttr Svíakappa*, preserved in *Flateyjarbók*, the Swedish king Eiríkr the Victorious pledges himself to Odin and throws a reed over the army of his nephew Styrbjörn, crying *Óðinn á yðr alla!* — "Odin owns you all!" The reed becomes a spear in flight, the enemy is struck blind, and a landslide destroys them. *Eyrbyggja saga* records a chieftain's spear thrown over an opposing force *at fornum sið*, "according to ancient custom."

The climax of *American Gods* is built on this rite. The battle on Lookout Mountain is designed to be consecrated in exactly this way: by a spear cast over the field that dedicates every casualty, old god and new, to Odin.

The saga-historical Odin also manufactures the wars he consecrates. In the seventh and eighth books of Saxo Grammaticus's *Gesta Danorum* (c. 1200), Odin takes the shape of Bruni, the trusted counselor of the aged Danish

king Harald Wartooth. In that guise he sows enmity between Harald and his nephew Ring until the two meet at Brávellir, in a battle whose combatants Saxo catalogues from many nations. During the battle, Bruni — Odin — drives Harald's chariot and kills the king with his own club.

Saxo's Odin impersonates an intermediary, engineers the hostility of two parties, assembles a battle of many nations, harvests its dead and murders his own devotee. Every element of Wednesday's con appears in a Danish chronicle eight centuries old.

The *Eiríksmál* (c. 954), the memorial poem for Eiríkr Bloodaxe, explains the purpose of Odin's betrayals. Asked why he denied victory to so great a king, Odin answers that the grey wolf is watching the dwelling of the gods: he needs warriors for the final battle. The *einherjar*, the chosen slain, are a strategic reserve. The *Grímnismál* (st. 23) counts five hundred and forty doors in Valhalla, through each of which eight hundred warriors will march out together to meet the wolf. Valhalla is a reserve institution — a central bank of the slain, holding the dead against the final crisis. Odin's betrayals of his champions are acts of capital accumulation: transfers of the living into the reserve.

The most exact historical analogue to Wednesday's war was fought in the Americas. The *xochiyaoyotl*, or "flower wars," waged in the fifteenth and early sixteenth centuries between the Mexica Triple Alliance and the states of the Puebla valley, above all Tlaxcala, were pre-arranged battles whose purpose was the capture of victims for sacrifice. That is the account preserved by the Dominican Diego Durán in his *Historia de las Indias de Nueva España* (1581). Durán attributes the institution to the counselor Tlacaelel, who in his report compared the arrangement to a market where the god could buy victims as one buys tortillas.

Georges Bataille, in *La part maudite* (1949), took the Mexica as the paradigm of a society that spent its surplus on sacrifice and war. He argued that sacrifice returns to the sacred order what servile use has degraded into a mere thing. Wednesday's war is a flower war: a battle arranged by agreement between apparent enemies, organized as a market, whose real purpose is to feed a god.

3.6 *The First War Between Pantheons and the Mead of Poetry*

The first war in the world was a war between pantheons, and it began over gold. The *Völuspá* (st. 21) recalls that the Æsir pierced Gullveig with spears and burned her in the hall of Hár, the High One. Three times they burned the thrice-born, and still she lives. Gullveig's name — "gold-draught" or "gold-might" — has invited readings of her as the personified corruption of gold, the substance that cannot be destroyed and returns from every burning.

The war she provokes sets the Æsir, gods of sovereignty and force, against the Vanir — Njörðr, Freyr and Freyja — gods of fertility, prosperity and wealth. Dumézil read the conflict as the mythic integration of the "third function," production and wealth, into a divine society constituted by the first two, sovereignty and war. He found its cognates in Rome's war with the wealthy Sabines and in Indra's resistance to admitting the Aśvins to the sacrifice in the Vedic tradition.

The war does not end in a twilight. It ends in an exchange. The Vanir send Njörðr and Freyr to the Æsir; the Æsir send Hœnir and Mímir to the Vanir. In Snorri's *Skáldskaparmál*, the two pantheons seal the truce by spitting into a common vat, and from the spittle they make Kvasir, the wisest of beings. Two dwarfs murder him and mix his blood with honey in the vessels Óðrerir, Boðn and Són, producing a mead that makes whoever drinks it a poet or a scholar. Odin later steals it from the giant Suttungr, in the episode the *Hávamál* recounts with such disapproval. Dumézil paired Kvasir with the Vedic Mada, "Intoxication," a monster created to force a divine peace and afterward divided among drink, women, dice and the hunt.

The significance of this myth for *American Gods* has gone unrecognized. Beside the Odinic war-sacrifice, the Eddic corpus contains an alternative settlement of a war between pantheons. Its terms are not the consecration of the dead but the exchange of hostages and the transformation of the truce's sacramental fluid into poetry. The blood that would have been shed in battle is converted, after the peace, into the medium of song.

The war of the Æsir and the Vanir — a conflict between gods of sovereignty and gods of wealth, between an order of blood and an order of commerce — is the precise mythic antecedent of the novel's war between old and new gods. Its resolution is the precise antecedent of the novel's resolution.

Adam of Bremen glossed Odin's name in his account of the temple at Uppsala (c. 1075): *Wodan, id est furor* — "Wodan, that is, fury." Old Norse *óðr* means at once frenzy, mind and poetic inspiration, and Óðrerir, "stirrer of *óðr*," is one of the vessels that hold the mead. The god's fury is either the

battle-madness that fills Valhalla or the inspiration the mead confers. *American Gods* stages the choice between these two forms of *óðr*: a war that would turn gods into sacrificial dead, or a story that turns the war into speech.

Gaiman's later retelling of the myth in *Norse Mythology* (2017) lingers with evident relish over its comic coda, the "rhymesters' share" — the drops of mead that Odin, flying in eagle form, lets fall from his rear for bad poets. That retelling confirms the myth's hold on his imagination. *American Gods* had already enacted it.

3.7 *Valhalla on Credit: Wotan's Debt*

The modern Odin is Wagner's, and Wagner understood the god as a debtor. *Das Rheingold* (1869) begins its divine action with an unpaid construction contract. Wotan has hired the giants Fasolt and Fafner to build Valhalla and has promised them Freia, the goddess whose golden apples keep the gods young. When the giants come to collect and carry Freia off as a pledge until payment is made, the gods grow pale and old before the audience's eyes. A century and a quarter before Gaiman, Wagner staged the exact image of gods aging as their sustaining asset is withdrawn into pawn.

Payment is made, on the advice of the trickster Loge, in gold stolen from the Nibelung Alberich. The ring that completes the sum carries Alberich's curse, and Fafner's murder of Fasolt over the hoard is the curse's first fulfillment. Wotan's spear is carved with the runes of his treaties, and his power is identical with the contracts that bind him. In *Siegfried*, the hero who knows no fear shatters the spear, and the god — now the Wanderer, one-eyed and broad-hatted, the visual source of every modern Odin including Gaiman's — can no longer hold him back. In *Götterdämmerung*, Valhalla burns.

George Bernard Shaw's *The Perfect Wagnerite* (1898) read the cycle as an allegory of capitalism. Alberich is the plutocrat who renounces love for gold; Wotan is the godhead of church and state, compromised by its bargains; Loge is the intellect that serves power with illusion.

Gaiman's novel inherits the entire configuration. Wednesday is Wotan as both Wanderer and debtor. Loki is Loge, the clever adviser whose expedients keep the god solvent. The war is a settlement in blood whose formula the god's partner has devised. Shadow is the son who breaks the father's contract by refusing its terms. The difference lies in the ending. Wagner's Valhalla burns; Gaiman's does not, because the war is never fought. *American Gods* is a *Götterdämmerung* cancelled in rehearsal.

3.8 *The Son on the Tree: Contract, Atonement, and the Mock Sacrifice Made Real*

Shadow enters Wednesday's service through a contract sealed with mead, the drink of the Odinic covenant. Among its terms is the duty to keep vigil over Wednesday's body should Wednesday die. The contract's fulfillment is death on the World Tree.

The arrangement has deep precedent. In *Ynglinga saga* (ch. 25), the Swedish king Aun sacrifices nine of his sons to Odin, one each decade, in exchange for successive extensions of his own life. The Swedes refuse him the tenth, and he dies senile, drinking from a horn like an infant. The father who converts his sons into credit is an Odinic type. The biblical *Akedah* — Abraham's binding of Isaac in Genesis 22, which Kierkegaard in *Fear and Trembling* (1843) made the paradigm of a "teleological suspension of the ethical" — supplies the Abrahamic counterpart, in which the son is spared.

Christian theology developed two economic models of the Son's death, and Wednesday's scheme fuses them. Anselm of Canterbury's *Cur Deus Homo* (1098) formulated the theory of satisfaction. Humanity owes God a debt of honor that it cannot pay, and only a God-man, who owes nothing on his own account, can pay it on humanity's behalf. The crucifixion is a settlement.

The older patristic theory of ransom conceived Christ's death as a price paid to the devil, and in its boldest forms as a fraud practiced on him. Gregory of Nyssa (*Catechetical Oration* 24) compared the incarnation to a fishhook concealed in bait: the devil swallowed the humanity and was caught by the divinity hidden inside it. Augustine preached that the cross was the devil's mousetrap, *muscipula diaboli*, baited with the Lord's death (*Sermon* 263). Gustaf Aulén's *Christus Victor* (1931) sorted these traditions into the classic, the Latin and the subjective types of atonement. For present purposes, the decisive point is simpler. Western atonement theory oscillates between the debt and the con, between Anselm's ledger and Gregory's hook. Wednesday's scheme places a sacrificial debt — the vigil clause — inside a con, the staged war.

One more saga episode supplies the mechanism by which the scheme converts ritual into death. In *Gautreks saga* (ch. 7), a fleet is becalmed, and lots demand the sacrifice of King Víkarr. At Odin's prompting, the hero Starkaðr stages a mock sacrifice. He loops a calf's intestine around the king's neck, ties it to a slender branch, touches him with a reed, and says, "Now I give you to

Odin." The reed becomes a spear, the gut becomes a strong rope, the branch becomes a stout bough, and the king dies.

This is the paradigmatic Odinic con: a ritual performed as theater that becomes actual. Shadow undertakes his vigil as an observance, a ritual duty owed under contract, and it becomes a real death. Odin's economy converts the symbolic into the literal, the "as if" into the "is." It is the exact inverse of the conjuror's covenant described in Chapter 11, which keeps the "as if" as "as if."

3.9 *The Blood Standard*

The Odinic corpus describes a complete sacred economy in five terms. The first is the **pledge** (*veð*): the eye in the well, the deposit of **kred* in a divine trustee. The second is **sacrifice** (*blót*): measured exchange, governed by the rule that a gift looks to its return. The third is **interest**: word from word and deed from deed, the compounding yield of self-expenditure. The fourth is the **reserve**: Valhalla, the dead held against the final crisis. The fifth is **fraud**: the ring-oath that cannot be trusted, the false counselor Bruni, the mock sacrifice made real.

From these terms the study derives its second central definition:

> **The blood standard**: a regime in which divine credit is convertible, at a rate the god guarantees, into sacrificial death; in which a god's solvency is measured by the dead it holds in reserve; and in which crises of divine credit are resolved by recapitalization through war.

Wednesday's America is a regime of floating divine credit. The attention-currency of the new gods is inconvertible: it cannot be redeemed in blood, and nothing guarantees its value but its continued acceptance. Wednesday's war is an attempt to restore convertibility. It would re-peg the sacred to the hard specie of death, refill the reserve, and re-establish a god — himself — as the guarantor of the exchange rate. The phrase is chosen deliberately to evoke the gold standard. Chapter 10 shows that the most famous speech in American monetary history already imagined the gold standard as a crucifixion.

One condition of the scheme must be stated now, because the novel's resolution turns on it. René Girard argued in *La violence et le sacré* (1972) and *Des choses cachées depuis la fondation du monde* (1978) that the sacrificial mechanism works only through *méconnaissance*: its participants must not recognize the victim as arbitrary or the violence as their own. A scapegoating under-

stood as a scapegoating no longer pacifies anyone. Wednesday's war likewise works only if both pantheons believe their enmity real — if neither sees that the war has been arranged, by partners, for a third party's profit.

The blood standard is therefore a confidence regime in the strictest sense. It requires the confidence of its victims, and it collapses the moment someone explains it. The next chapter examines the currency that Wednesday set out to replace: the attention on which the new gods subsist.

CHAPTER

4

The Altar and the Screen

New Gods, Attention, and the Spectacle

The new gods are the least admired element of *American Gods*. Readers have often found them schematic beside the old gods, and time has made them look dated, since a pantheon that includes the beeper ages faster than one that includes Odin. This chapter argues that their thinness is structural. The new gods are gods of inconvertible credit, and their flatness is the flatness of fiat money, which has a face value and nothing behind it.

The argument proceeds through six claims. The new gods' worship is attention, and attention is labor-time, so their sacrifice is the substance of value itself, drawn from worshippers as living hours. Their temporality is the continuous flow of broadcast and network, which abolishes the weekday — the very form in which Wednesday survives. Their ontology is the simulacrum. Their enforcers bear the names that biblical polemic gives to idols. Their chief executive proves to be the oldest trickster in the northern pantheon. Finally, in Bilquis, the novel shows the blood economy surviving inside the cash economy until the new gods destroy her.

Chapter 2 traced Max Weber's "disenchantment of the world" to Schiller's elegy for the gods of Greece. Weber's lecture "Wissenschaft als Beruf" (delivered 1917; published 1919) carried the argument to its end, where the gods return:

> *Die alten vielen Götter, entzaubert und daher in Gestalt unpersönlicher Mächte, entsteigen ihren Gräbern, streben nach Gewalt über unser Leben und beginnen untereinander wieder ihren ewigen Kampf.*

"The many old gods, disenchanted and therefore in the form of impersonal powers, climb out of their graves, strive for power over our lives, and resume their eternal struggle with one another." Weber meant the plurality of irreconcilable value spheres — science, politics, art, eros, the economy — each demanding absolute allegiance. Gaiman personifies them again. His new gods are Weber's impersonal powers given faces, and his war is Weber's eternal struggle given a battlefield.

4.1 *The Credit Card and the Dynamo*

In his address to the assembled old gods, Wednesday catalogues their rivals: gods of the credit card and the freeway, of the internet and the telephone, of radio, hospital and television, of plastic, the beeper and neon. The list mixes kinds with deliberate disorder. It includes media of broadcast (radio, television) and of connection (telephone, internet, beeper), infrastructure (the freeway, neon), a material (plastic), an institution (the hospital) and a financial instrument (the credit card). What unites them is that each organizes human time and attention at scale.

The first god named is the credit card. The general-purpose charge card dates from Diners Club in 1950, and revolving bank credit from BankAmericard in 1958. The card is a plastic token of trust, the object in which two of Wednesday's new gods, credit and plastic, coincide. It is also the purest fiduciary object in the culture: an instrument whose whole value lies in the expectation that it will be honored. That credit heads the new pantheon in the novel's own catalogue is the first textual warrant for this study's thesis.

American letters had recorded a conversion to the new gods a century before Gaiman. Visiting the Gallery of Machines at the Paris Exposition of 1900, Henry Adams stood before the great electrical generators. In *The Education of Henry Adams* (privately printed 1907; published 1918), he recorded the result in the third person:

> As he grew accustomed to the great gallery of machines, he began to feel the forty-foot dynamos as a moral force, much as the early Christians felt the Cross. … Before the end, one began to pray to it; inherited instinct taught the natural expression of man before silent and infinite force.

Adams set the Dynamo against the Virgin of Chartres, who had been, in his account, the greatest force the Western world had ever felt. The grandson and great-grandson of presidents, writing as a historian of force, recorded the passage of devotion from the cathedral to the powerhouse. Gaiman's new gods are Adams's dynamo multiplied, personified and given bad manners.

David Nye's *American Technological Sublime* (1994) traces the crowds that gathered to marvel at the railroad, the bridge, the skyscraper, the dam and the atomic test — collective effervescence, in Durkheim's sense, assembled around machines. Roland Barthes, in *Mythologies* (1957), proposed that the new Citroën was the modern equivalent of a Gothic cathedral: the supreme creation of its age, consumed by a whole population as a magical object, more often as image than in use. The freeway on Wednesday's list belongs to this order. The Federal-Aid Highway Act of 1956 authorized the Interstate system, a network of pilgrimage laid across a continent.

The hospital is the one new god that is an institution, and its presence is precise. Philippe Ariès, in *L'homme devant la mort* (1977), traced the twentieth-century removal of dying from the household to the hospital. The institution in which modern Americans are born and die has absorbed the rites of passage once performed by the parish and the family. Chapter 5 shows where that leaves the old gods of death: in a family funeral home in Cairo, Illinois.

4.2 *Time Is Money: Media and the Sacrifice of Attention*

The goddess Media first speaks to Shadow from a motel television, wearing the face of Lucy Ricardo. She tells him that the television is an altar, a household shrine around which the family gathers. What her worshippers sacrifice to her, she explains, is chiefly their time, and sometimes one another.

The statement is economic before it is theological. Benjamin Franklin's "Advice to a Young Tradesman" (1748) opens with the most famous maxim of American economic life: "Remember, that time is money." Max Weber began his account of the spirit of capitalism in *The Protestant Ethic* (1904–05) with Franklin's maxims, treating the American printer as the purest exponent of an ethic in which wasted time is a moral failing. If time is money, a sacrifice of time is a sacrifice of money. Media's congregation pays.

Marxian value theory sharpens the point. For Marx, the value of a commodity is the socially necessary labor-time congealed in it. Dallas Smythe's essay "Communications: Blindspot of Western Marxism" (1977) argued that the principal commodity produced by commercial broadcasting is not pro-

grams but audiences. Their attention is assembled, measured and sold to advertisers, so that watching is a form of unwaged labor. Sut Jhally and Bill Livant formalized the claim as "watching as working" (1986).

Herbert Simon had observed in 1971 that "a wealth of information creates a poverty of attention." By the late 1990s, as Gaiman was writing, Michael Goldhaber ("The Attention Economy and the Net," 1997) and Georg Franck (*Ökonomie der Aufmerksamkeit*, 1998) were describing attention as the scarce currency of the networked economy. Franck treated attention received as income and celebrity as accumulated wealth.

On this analysis, Media's claim is literal. Her worshippers offer living time, and living time is the substance of value. Marx had supplied the image for a power that subsists on it:

> Capital is dead labour, that, vampire-like, only lives by sucking living labour, and lives the more, the more labour it sucks.

The new gods are vampires in Marx's precise sense: they live on living time and swell as they draw more of it. The old gods drank blood, and the new gods drink hours. The difference is less than it appears, since hours are the substance of a life.

The second clause of Media's account — that people sometimes sacrifice one another to her — opens the attention economy onto the blood economy. George Gerbner's cultural-indicators research, begun in the late 1960s, tallied the violent deaths of prime-time drama and argued that heavy viewers came to see the world as meaner and more dangerous than it was. The new gods also accept human victims, but as images, consumed nightly at no cost to the consumer. Chapter 10 argues that the boundary between the image of sacrifice and its reality is exactly what Wednesday's con is designed to erase.

4.3 *The Household Shrine: Lucy, the Lares, and the Economy of the Eye*

Media's description of the television as a household shrine has a Roman name. The *lararium* was the domestic shrine of the Lares, guardians of the household, and of the Penates, whose name derives from *penus*, the storeroom, and who protected the household's provisions. The domestic gods of Rome were gods of the household economy.

Latin *focus* means hearth, the household's center of warmth and worship and the seat of Vesta; the modern sense of a point of convergence derives from it. By the 1950s the television had become the focus of the American liv-

ing room in both senses. Cecelia Tichi's *Electronic Hearth* (1991) documented the industry's marketing of the set as a substitute hearth. Gregor Goethals's *The TV Ritual: Worship at the Video Altar* (1981) and George Gerbner's essay "Television: The New State Religion?" (1977) had already given Media her self-description. The novel's goddess speaks the language of a generation of media scholarship that had reached for religious terms.

The face Media chooses is overdetermined. *I Love Lucy* (CBS, 1951–57) staged the medium's first great nativity. When Lucille Ball became pregnant in 1952, the network barred the word "pregnant" from the air, and one episode was titled "Lucy Is Enceinte." By Desi Arnaz's account, a priest, a minister and a rabbi reviewed the pregnancy scripts. On January 19, 1953, "Lucy Goes to the Hospital" drew an estimated forty-four million viewers, by most accounts more than watched Dwight Eisenhower's inauguration the following day.

Will Herberg argued in *Protestant–Catholic–Jew* (1955) that the three faiths had become denominations of a single American religion, "the American Way of Life." The interfaith committee that vetted Lucy's confinement enacted Herberg's thesis two years before he published it. The next evening's audience showed which rite the nation preferred: the televised nativity or the civil liturgy of the inauguration.

Walter Benjamin's essay on the work of art in the age of its technical reproducibility (1935–36) explains what Media is. Art, Benjamin argued, originated in ritual, and its aura derived from that cult value. Technical reproduction emancipates the artwork from ritual and replaces cult value with exhibition value. The film industry's cult of the star preserves not the aura but its counterfeit, the spell of the personality, which is the spell of a commodity. Media is a goddess of exhibition value who wears a star's face. Her wish to be honored as an altar is cult value returning inside exhibition value: the reproducible image demanding the worship once reserved for the unique.

The name Lucy derives from *lux*, light, and Saint Lucy of Syracuse is the patron of eyes. Late medieval legend had her tear out her own eyes, and she is painted carrying them on a dish. Media, wearing a Lucy, presents herself to Shadow as the screen that watches and is watched. The novel's two sovereign figures of vision thus face each other: the one-eyed god who pledged his eye in a well, and the television goddess who wears the face of a woman named for the patron of eyes.

Both pantheons run an economy of the eye. Odin pawned his own eye for wisdom; the new gods take the eyes of their worshippers as collateral. In the

late 1990s, as Gaiman wrote, internet companies were valued by "eyeballs," the count of eyes their sites attracted. Media's name, a near-homophone of Medea, the mother who murders her children, points ahead to the novel's other devourer of the young, examined in Chapter 8.

4.4 *A Cult Without Weekdays*

Benjamin's fragment "Capitalism as Religion" (1921) supplies the decisive temporal analysis. Capitalism, Benjamin wrote, is a purely cultic religion, perhaps the most extreme there has ever been, and its cult is of permanent duration:

> *Es gibt da keinen "Wochentag", keinen Tag, der nicht Festtag in dem fürchterlichen Sinne der Entfaltung allen sakralen Pompes, der äußersten Anspannung des Verehrenden wäre.*

"There is no 'weekday,' no day that is not a feast day in the terrible sense of the unfolding of all sacred pomp, the utmost exertion of the worshipper." In the same passage Benjamin describes the cult as celebrated *sans rêve et sans merci* — "without dream and without mercy." Editors generally take *rêve* as a slip for *trêve*, "truce."

Both readings describe Gaiman's new gods. Their cult knows no truce: the parley at which Wednesday dies is held under one. Their cult also knows no dream: the novel's dreams belong to the land, in the buffalo-headed figure who visits Shadow, and to Shadow himself.

Wednesday is a weekday. The planetary week, assembled in the Hellenistic and Roman world from the seven classical planets, entered the Germanic languages by a translation of gods. Mars became Tiw (Tuesday), Mercury became Woden (Wednesday), Jupiter became Thor (Thursday), and Venus became Frigg (Friday). Tacitus gave the procedure its name, *interpretatio Romana* (*Germania* 43): the equation of one people's gods with another's.

The week is therefore an exchange table between pantheons, fixed in late antiquity and still honored, unwittingly, by every speaker of English. It is the last stronghold of the old gods: a calendar in which they recur by name every seven days. Gaiman gave his Odin the form in which the god is most often spoken of in the modern world.

The new gods' cult abolishes the week as a unit of sacred time. Raymond Williams identified "planned flow" as the defining property of broadcasting in *Television: Technology and Cultural Form* (1974): the discrete event gives way to a continuous sequence designed to carry the viewer from one item to the

next. Round-the-clock cable news arrived with CNN in 1980, and the always-on network followed. Jonathan Crary's *24/7* (2013) describes the resulting assault on every interval, sleep included.

At the level of form, the war between Wednesday and the new gods is the war between the week and the stream: festal, recurrent time against continuous time. Abraham Joshua Heschel's *The Sabbath* (1951) described the Sabbath as a sanctuary built in time rather than space. The cult without weekdays abolishes sanctuaries in time, and with them the god who is a day of the week.

Easter, the most prosperous of the novel's old gods, illustrates the calendrical alternative. Her festival is computed by the moon: Easter falls on the Sunday after the paschal full moon, the first full moon on or after the spring equinox by ecclesiastical reckoning. The only early testimony to her existence is a single sentence in Bede's *De temporum ratione* (725, ch. 15). Bede reports that the Anglo-Saxon month *Eosturmonath*, now called the paschal month, was once named for a goddess called Eostre, in whose honor feasts were held. Jacob Grimm's *Deutsche Mythologie* (1835) reconstructed from Bede and the German *Ostern* a continental goddess, Ostara.

Scholars have long disputed whether Bede invented Eostre; Philip Shaw's *Pagan Goddesses in the Early Germanic World* (2011) defends her as a local deity. Either way, the novel's Easter is a goddess whose existence rests on one sentence by a Northumbrian monk and its elaboration by a German philologist. She is the Herodotean principle of Chapter 1 made flesh: a deity underwritten by scholarship. She flourishes, as the new gods do, on a festival whose celebrants do not know her name. Her credit, however, is calendrical and recurrent, renewed each spring by the moon rather than drawn without interval. Chapter 11 shows that it is this recurrent goddess, not any god of flow, who restores Shadow to life.

4.5 *The Promissory Note: Spectacle, Simulacrum, and Fiat*

The critical theory of mass culture described its object in fiduciary terms long before the novel. In the chapter of *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944/47) devoted to the culture industry, Horkheimer and Adorno argue that the industry perpetually cheats its consumers of what it perpetually promises. Their German is financial: *der Wechsel auf die Lust*, the bill of exchange drawn on pleasure, is endlessly rolled over. The culture industry issues paper that never falls due, and its promise is all it has to offer. A bill rolled over forever is not a debt but a currency.

Guy Debord's *La société du spectacle* (1967) completed the analysis. Its first thesis rewrites the first sentence of *Capital*: where Marx had said that the wealth of capitalist societies appears as an immense accumulation of commodities, Debord says that all of life now presents itself as an immense accumulation of spectacles. The twentieth thesis calls the spectacle the material reconstruction of the religious illusion. Technology, on this account, has not dispersed the clouds into which humanity projected its powers; it has anchored them to an earthly base. The thirty-fourth thesis defines the spectacle as capital accumulated to the point where it becomes image.

Media is that image: capital in the form of a picture, religious projection in the form of a broadcast. Debord gives Feuerbach's projection (Chapter 1) its technical apparatus.

Jean Baudrillard's *Simulacres et simulation* (1981) opens with the iconoclasts of Byzantium. Their rage against images, Baudrillard argued, expressed the fear that images might conceal not God but his absence, and that God himself might be nothing but his own simulacrum. Media realizes the iconoclasts' fear. She has no face of her own and appears only in borrowed images, the sitcom wife and the news anchor among them. Behind her images there is no original, only further images. She is a god whose essence is circulation.

The novel names the gods of the market with a term from accounting: the "intangibles." Intangible assets — goodwill, brand value, intellectual property — are those whose worth consists in expected future earnings. Their value is a belief about the future capitalized as a present asset. The market's gods are, by definition, beliefs carried on the books.

The new pantheon also has a date. On August 15, 1971, President Nixon suspended the convertibility of the dollar into gold. The Bretton Woods system ended, and by 1973 the major currencies floated against one another, backed by nothing but the expectation of their continued acceptance. The new gods of *American Gods* are the gods of the post-1971 economy. Their credit is inconvertible: it cannot be redeemed for anything, blood included, and its value is its circulation.

The old gods, by contrast, were convertible. Their credit could be redeemed, at a rate the god guaranteed, in sacrifice. Wednesday's war is an attempt to restore convertibility. By a coincidence the argument may be permitted to savor, the volume of Dorson's essays from which the novel's epigraph is drawn, *American Folklore and the Historian*, appeared in 1971.

The thinness of the new gods follows. Fiat money has a face value and nothing behind it; a pantheon of fiat has faces and nothing behind them. The complaint that Gaiman's new gods lack depth mistakes a structural property for a failure of execution.

4.6 *The Adolescent God: Technical Boy and the Religion of Technology*

The Technical Boy, god of the network, is introduced as an adolescent in a limousine. He has Shadow seized and beaten, smokes cigarettes of synthetic toad skin, and sends Wednesday a message: that he is history, that he is forgotten, and that the new gods are the future. In the same scene he reduces language to a virus, religion to an operating system and prayer to spam.

The first reduction echoes William S. Burroughs, who argued in *The Ticket That Exploded* (1962) that the word had passed from symbiosis to parasitism and become a virus. Laurie Anderson made the idea a song, "Language Is a Virus" (1986). The Technical Boy's materialism is itself a borrowed theology. Burroughs's virus was a Gnostic figure for a parasitic demiurge; the Technical Boy speaks a Gnosticism stripped of its salvation.

The religion of technology was a scholarly subject by the time Gaiman wrote. David Noble's *The Religion of Technology* (1997) traced Western technological ambition to medieval Christian hopes of restoring Adam's lost perfection. Erik Davis's *TechGnosis* (1998) documented the mysticism, millenarianism and magic that had attached themselves to information technology from the telegraph to the internet. Apple had employed "evangelists" since the early 1980s, and its "1984" advertisement, broadcast during the Super Bowl on January 22, 1984, staged an act of iconoclasm: a runner hurls a hammer into the screen of a totalitarian idol. Vernor Vinge's essay "The Coming Technological Singularity" (1993) and Ray Kurzweil's *The Age of Spiritual Machines* (1999) gave the network an eschatology. The Technical Boy embodies a culture that had already described its machines in the vocabulary of salvation.

Marshall McLuhan supplies the irony the novel exploits. In *The Gutenberg Galaxy* (1962) and *Understanding Media* (1964), McLuhan argued that electric media were dissolving the linear, individualist culture of print and restoring the simultaneous, collective, acoustic conditions of tribal life: the "global village." Walter Ong called the resulting condition "secondary orality" (*Orality and Literacy*, 1982).

If McLuhan and Ong were right, the new gods are re-creating the very conditions in which the old gods flourished. The network that starves Wednes-

day of worship revives the tribe in electronic form. The new gods are not the opposite of the old but their return in another medium, a point Shadow will press on both sides at Lookout Mountain.

Heidegger's lecture "Die Frage nach der Technik" (1954) describes the essence of modern technology as *Gestell*, enframing: a mode of revealing that challenges everything to stand ready as *Bestand*, standing-reserve, available on demand. The river becomes a power supplier, the forest a stock of timber, the human being a resource. Heidegger's standing-reserve rhymes with the Odinic reserve of Chapter 3. Valhalla holds the dead in reserve against the final battle; the new gods hold the living in reserve as attention on call. Both pantheons convert human beings into reserves, and they differ only in whether the reserve is drawn before death or after it.

The Technical Boy's adolescence is his theology. He is a god without a past, and so a god without a mythology: he has updates rather than stories. Joseph Schumpeter called the "perennial gale of creative destruction" the essential fact of capitalism (*Capitalism, Socialism and Democracy*, 1942). Marx and Engels had described it a century earlier in terms that read as the new gods' fate:

> All fixed, fast-frozen relations, with their train of ancient and venerable prejudices and opinions, are swept away, all new-formed ones become antiquated before they can ossify. All that is solid melts into air, all that is holy is profaned.

New-formed gods become antiquated before they can ossify; the beeper in Wednesday's catalogue has long since done so. At Lookout Mountain, Shadow tells the new gods that they fear being superseded as much as the old gods fear being forgotten, and the novel's own date confirms him. *American Gods* was written during the dot-com bubble, when firms without earnings were valued by their eyeballs and their "burn rate." The NASDAQ peaked on March 10, 2000; the novel appeared in June 2001, after the crash. The Technical Boy is a god of the bubble, published after it burst.

4.7 *Wood, Stone, Town, World*

The new gods' enforcers, the "spooks" who interrogate Shadow, are called Mr. Wood and Mr. Stone. The names repeat the formula with which the Hebrew Bible ridicules idols. Deuteronomy warns that in exile Israel will serve "gods, the work of men's hands, wood and stone, which neither see, nor hear,

nor eat, nor smell" (4:28). Hezekiah's prayer explains why Assyria could destroy the gods of conquered peoples: "for they were no gods, but the work of men's hands, wood and stone" (2 Kings 19:18; Isaiah 37:19).

Isaiah's satire of the idol-maker (44:13–20) is the classical text. A carpenter cuts down a tree, burns half of it to roast his meat and warm himself, and carves the rest into a god, before which he falls down and prays to be delivered. The same log is fuel and god, use-value and fetish. Marx's analysis of the commodity is anticipated in a single piece of wood.

Psalm 115 extends the polemic to precious metal and ends in the vocabulary of trust:

> Their idols are silver and gold, the work of men's hands. They have mouths, but they speak not: eyes have they, but they see not ... They that make them are like unto them; so is every one that trusteth in them. O Israel, trust thou in the LORD. (115:4–5, 8–9)

The psalm identifies idols with silver and gold — the substance of money. It defines idolatry as misplaced trust and warns that those who trust in idols become like them: eyes that do not see. The biblical critique of idolatry is already a critique of fiduciary religion, and its antithesis, trust in the Lord, is the formula the United States would stamp on its coins (Chapter 1).

The spooks' names escalate. After Wood and Stone come Mr. Town and Mr. World. The first city in Genesis is built by Cain, the first murderer, who names it after his son (Genesis 4:17). The Gospel of John calls Satan "the prince of this world" (12:31), and Paul calls him "the god of this world," who "hath blinded the minds of them which believe not" (2 Corinthians 4:4). Wood, Stone, Town, World: the materials of idols, the city of the first murderer, and the blinding prince of this world.

Their folklore is also new. The "men in black" entered American legend through Gray Barker's *They Knew Too Much About Flying Saucers* (1956), which told how three dark-suited visitors silenced the saucer researcher Albert K. Bender. The spooks are fakelore of the national-security state, a modern American legend enlisted as a god's enforcers.

The novel's final revelation completes the series. Mr. World, the executive who directs the new gods' campaign, is Loki: the same figure who, as Low Key Lyesmith — smith of lies — shared Shadow's prison cell in the opening chapters. Snorri introduces Loki as the slanderer of the gods, the originator of deceits and the disgrace of gods and men (*Gylfaginning* 33). The new gods'

operation is run by the oldest trickster of the northern pantheon, in partnership with Odin.

The opposition between old and new gods is the novel's premise, and the revelation exposes it as a front. The partners make the market on both sides of the trade, as a casino does. The "god of this world" who blinds the minds of unbelievers is a Norse trickster in a good suit. The new gods are not the old gods' opposite; they are the old gods' instrument.

Laura Moon kills Mr. Wood and Mr. Stone when she frees Shadow from their custody. The dead wife breaks the idols. Chapter 9 returns to her.

4.8 *Two Vampires: Bilquis and the Cash Nexus*

The novel's first "Somewhere in America" interlude shows the oldest form of divine consumption surviving inside the newest form of commerce. Bilquis, the Queen of Sheba, works in Los Angeles as a prostitute. She asks a client to worship her, and as he does, she takes him wholly into her body. He pays twice: in cash, the profane currency, and with his life, the sacred one.

Bilquis's origins are commercial. In the biblical account, the queen of Sheba comes to Jerusalem "to prove him with hard questions," with camels bearing spices, gold and precious stones, and gives Solomon "an hundred and twenty talents of gold" (1 Kings 10:1–10). The Sabaean kingdom of southern Arabia grew rich on the incense trade, and its queen enters scripture at the head of a trade mission. In the Qur'an (27:20–44), she rules a sun-worshipping people, and the turning point of her story is a floor of glass in Solomon's palace that she mistakes for water. She bares her legs to cross what she takes for a pool; told that it is glass, she submits to Solomon's God. Ethiopian tradition, codified in the fourteenth-century *Kebra Nagast*, names her Makeda and makes her the mother of Menelik I, founder of the Solomonic dynasty.

In the Qur'anic story, a queen of a sun-worshipping people is undone by a sheet of glass mistaken for depth — the earliest scene in which a screen deceives a sovereign. In Gaiman's America, the screen belongs to Media, and Bilquis dies at the new gods' hands, run down in the street.

Henry Adams had predicted her fate. In the same chapter as the dynamo, he observed that "an American Virgin would never dare command; an American Venus would never dare exist." Bilquis is the American Venus who dares exist and is killed for it. Gaiman had rehearsed her in *Sandman: Brief Lives*,

in which Ishtar dances in a strip club until she releases her full divinity and destroys the club and herself. Chapter 9 returns to both goddesses.

Thomas Carlyle called the modern bond between persons the "cash nexus," and Marx and Engels wrote that the bourgeoisie had left no bond between man and man but "naked self-interest" and "callous 'cash payment'," drowning religious fervor "in the icy water of egotistical calculation." Bilquis inverts the formula. Beneath the cash payment lies a blood payment; the profane transaction conceals a sacrifice. She is Marx's vampire in its pre-capitalist form, and the new gods are its capitalist form. The novel's two economies are not opposites but two vampirisms, one drinking lives and the other hours.

The new gods kill Bilquis; they do not end the blood economy. Wednesday's war is that economy's return at the scale of nations, and its battlefield is a mountain consecrated by the dead.

4.9 *The War That Would Not Take Place*

In January 1991, as the United States prepared to attack Iraq, Jean Baudrillard published in *Libération* an essay titled "La guerre du Golfe n'aura pas lieu" — "The Gulf War will not take place." He followed it with "Is the Gulf War really taking place?" and, after the fighting, "The Gulf War did not take place." The essays argued that a war conducted and consumed as a televised simulation, its outcome known in advance, was not a war in the classical sense, whatever its real dead.

Gaiman's war between pantheons does not take place either. Shadow halts it before the first blow by revealing it as a con. The new gods' war is a media event whose script was written by two old gods, and its only possible real outcome is a sacrifice.

The attention economy and the blood economy are therefore not alternatives between which the novel asks its reader to choose. Each requires the other: attention supplies the confidence the con needs, and blood supplies the convertibility the con seeks. Jonathan Z. Smith's definition of ritual as a mode of paying attention, examined in the next chapter, shows that the two are joined at the roadside. The one sacred that neither economy can liquidate is the one that does not circulate: place.

PART

III

Geographies

5 *The Spirit of Place*

6 *A Nation of Immigrants*



CHAPTER

5

The Spirit of Place

Land, Hierophany, and the Roadside Attraction

American Gods is a road novel, and its itinerary is a sacred geography: the House on the Rock in Wisconsin, a funeral home in Cairo, Illinois, a motel at the geographic center of the contiguous United States, a Lakota reservation in South Dakota, the town of Lakeside, and Rock City on Lookout Mountain. This chapter argues that the novel's places fall into three kinds, which correspond to the three registers of the fiduciary order.

Roadside attractions convert the attention of travelers into the sacrality of a site; they mediate between credit and collateral and are the natural habitat of confidence. Places consecrated by the dead — the battlefield and the funeral home — are collateral in its purest form. The land itself neither circulates nor needs belief, and so stands outside the fiduciary order altogether. The chapter ends with the land and with the problem its figuration raises.

5.1 *Wednesday's Theory of the Roadside Attraction*

Early in their travels, Wednesday offers Shadow a theory of American sacred space. In other countries, he says, people recognized the places where power gathered — sometimes a natural formation, sometimes a spot with no visible distinction — and built temples, cathedrals and stone circles there. In Amer-

ica, people still feel the call of such places but have lost the means to answer it. They respond by building roadside attractions: a beer-bottle model of somewhere they have never been, a giant bat house in a region bats have always avoided. The attraction marks the place without knowing what it marks.

Wednesday's theory is an Eliadean theory of misrecognized hierophany. For Mircea Eliade, in *Patterns in Comparative Religion* (1949) and *The Sacred and the Profane* (1957), the sacred manifests itself in a hierophany, an irruption that sets a place apart from homogeneous profane space and gives the world an orientation. Eliade called manifestations of power kratophanies. Sacred space is discovered rather than chosen, and human beings respond by marking it. Wednesday's America is a land of kratophanies without a liturgy. The response survives, but its grammar has been lost, so the marker takes the form of kitsch.

The American roadside attraction has a scholarly literature of its own. Karal Ann Marling's *The Colossus of Roads* (1984) studied the giant statues of the upper Midwest — the Paul Bunyan and Babe the Blue Ox raised at Bemidji in 1937, the fiberglass Vikings and giant fish — as civic monuments of a commercial frontier. Robert Venturi, Denise Scott Brown and Steven Izenour's *Learning from Las Vegas* (1972) distinguished the "decorated shed," a plain building with a sign, from the "duck," a building shaped as its own symbol, named for a Long Island poultry stand built in 1931 in the form of a giant duck. The duck is the roadside idol in its purest form: an image that is also a building, a sign that is also a shrine.

Wednesday's own examples repay attention. A beer-bottle model of a place never visited and a bat house where there are no bats are both offerings to an absence. The model replicates a sacred elsewhere; the bat house awaits a congregation that does not come. The roadside attraction is the American form of the cenotaph and the empty shrine, built for gods who have not arrived.

Susan Stewart's *On Longing* (1984) supplies the categories. Stewart reads the miniature, the gigantic, the souvenir and the collection as narratives of desire. The miniature offers interiority and control, a world held in the hand; the gigantic offers exteriority and awe, a world that holds the viewer. The souvenir authenticates an experience and stands metonymically for a place; the collection replaces history with classification. The roadside attraction deploys all four. Rock City miniaturizes the world, the colossi magnify it, the gift shop sells it in pieces, and the House on the Rock collects it.

5.2 *Ritual as Attention: The Billboard Liturgy*

Jonathan Z. Smith's *To Take Place: Toward Theory in Ritual* (1987) answered Eliade with a theory that this study takes as the hinge between the economy of attention (Chapter 4) and the geography of the sacred. Against hierophany, Smith argued that places are not sacred in themselves but are made sacred by human practices of emplacement. "Ritual," he wrote, "is, first and foremost, a mode of paying attention." An object or act becomes sacred by having attention focused on it in a highly marked way.

If Smith is right, the roadside attraction is a ritual technology in the strict sense. Its entire function is to capture and focus the attention of passing motorists, and its signage is liturgy: an imperative to attend. The billboard does what the bell tower did.

Rock City is the exemplary case. Garnet Carter, who had launched the miniature-golf craze with his "Tom Thumb Golf" course on Lookout Mountain in the late 1920s, opened Rock City Gardens with his wife Frieda in 1932. Frieda Carter laid out its paths among the sandstone formations and populated them with imported gnomes and figures from fairy tales. Beginning in 1935, the sign painter Clark Byers painted the words SEE ROCK CITY on the roofs of barns across the South and Midwest; by the time he retired in 1969, he had painted some nine hundred barns in nineteen states.

SEE ROCK CITY is a command to look. For decades the attention of millions of motorists was solicited mile by mile and directed toward a single site. In Smith's terms, the campaign consecrated the mountain. In the terms of this study, it capitalized it: few places in America have received a more sustained or more widely dispersed investment of directed attention. It is no accident that the novel's war is staged there.

The roadside attraction is thus the place where the two currencies of the fiduciary order are exchanged. It converts the attention of travelers, the currency of the new gods, into the sacrality of a site, the collateral of the old. It is the bureau de change of the American sacred, and Wednesday, a merchant god, does his business there.

The American equation of holiness with visibility is older than the billboard. John Winthrop's lay sermon "A Model of Christian Charity" (1630), delivered to the Puritan emigrants, founded their colony on its being watched: "For we must consider that we shall be as a city upon a hill. The eyes of all people are upon us." The founding sermon of English America defines the colony's holiness as exposure to the gaze of others. The city upon a hill and SEE ROCK CITY belong to one economy of attention.

5.3 *The House on the Rock and the Accumulative Sublime*

The House on the Rock, near Spring Green, Wisconsin, is the first of the novel's sacred sites to be explained as such, and the most elaborate. Alex Jordan Jr. began building a retreat atop Deer Shelter Rock, a sandstone chimney, in the 1940s and opened it to the public in 1960. Over the following decades he extended it into a labyrinth of rooms crowded with collections: automaton orchestras, a model circus, dollhouses, suits of armor, an immense sea creature locked in combat with a squid, and the world's largest carousel, which bears some 269 animals, none of them horses, beneath thousands of lights. A local legend of doubtful truth holds that Jordan built the house to spite Frank Lloyd Wright, whose estate, Taliesin, stands a few miles away, after Wright had dismissed his father's designs.

The legend sets the two great Wisconsin houses in theological opposition. Wright's organic architecture sought harmony between building and site, a house that grows from its hill; Taliesin, named for the Welsh bard, means "shining brow." Jordan's house sits on its rock as an accumulation, a building that expresses no site but hoards a world. Wright's is the architecture of the spirit of place; Jordan's is the architecture of the collection.

Stewart's analysis explains why Wednesday convenes the old gods there. The collection, she argues, replaces the context of origin with the order of the series, effacing the history of its objects in the act of preserving them. The House on the Rock is a museum of decontextualized objects, as Gaiman's America is a museum of decontextualized gods. Walter Benjamin, in "Unpacking My Library" (1931), described the collector as one who renews the old world by freeing things from the drudgery of usefulness, and called ownership the most intimate relation one can have to objects. The old gods assembled in Jordan's house are themselves a collection: freed from usefulness and owned by no one.

The carousel is the gateway. When the gods ride it, they pass to a hall behind the world, where they appear in their true forms and hear Wednesday's call to war. The novel's figure for this realm is theatrical: the gods' world lies backstage of America's. Erving Goffman's *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life* (1956; 1959) distinguished the front region, where a performance is given, from the back region, where performers drop the impressions fostered in front. America's attractions are the front region of the sacred; the gods' hall is its back region. The backstage is where the gods stop pretending to be roadside attractions.

The carousel's form carries its own argument. It is a machine of cyclical motion, a wheel that returns to where it began. Eliade's *The Myth of the Eternal Return* (1949) contrasted archaic cyclical time, periodically regenerated by ritual, with the linear and irreversible time of history. The old gods, whose festivals recur, enter their sanctuary on a wheel; the new gods inhabit the line of progress. The world's largest carousel is the ritual apparatus of eternal return reduced to an amusement — and still capable, for those who know how to ride it, of carrying them back to the time of origins.

5.4 *The Cardboard Omphalos*

The exchange of Wednesday's body takes place under truce at a run-down motel near the geographic center of the contiguous United States, outside Lebanon, Kansas. Every cosmology has a center. For Eliade, the center is the point at which heaven, earth and underworld communicate, the *axis mundi*, and every sacred place repeats it. At Delphi, the omphalos stone marked the navel of the earth, where two eagles released by Zeus from the ends of the world met.

The center of America has a different origin. It was fixed in 1918 by the U.S. Coast and Geodetic Survey, which, by the account usually given, balanced a cardboard cutout of the country on a point. The site is marked by a small stone monument, and a tiny chapel stands nearby. The American omphalos was located not by eagles or hierophany but by mensuration, and it moves whenever the territory it summarizes changes. The admission of Alaska and Hawaii in 1959 shifted the center of the fifty states to South Dakota, a fact to which Section 5.6 returns.

J. Z. Smith's essay "The Wobbling Pivot" (1972) argued that Eliade's center is not a given but an unstable and contested construction — a pivot that wobbles. The center of the contiguous United States was found by balancing; it is a wobbling pivot in the literal sense. It is also not a place of power but of neutrality. In the novel it serves as a no-man's-land where enemies can meet under truce, the one place defined by the absence of any god's claim. The center of America is an average, not an origin.

The transaction conducted there is fitting. At the cardboard omphalos, under truce, the parties exchange a dead god's body. The nation's sacred center is the site of a settlement: not an altar but a clearing-house.

5.5 *Little Egypt: Cairo and the Industry of the Dead*

Southern Illinois has been called Little Egypt since the nineteenth century. Local tradition explains the name by the crop failures that followed the deep snow of 1830–31, when farmers from the north came south to buy grain, as the sons of Jacob went down into Egypt. The region's towns bear Egyptian names: Cairo, Thebes, Karnak. Cairo stands at the confluence of the Ohio and the Mississippi, on low ground that recalls a delta. Herodotus, following Hecataeus, called Egypt "the gift of the river" (2.5); Cairo is the gift of two.

Gaiman installs the Egyptian gods of death there. Mr. Ibis and Mr. Jacquel run a funeral home, Bast keeps house as a cat, and Shadow works for them while the war gathers. The setting is shaped by its rivers. T. S. Eliot, born upriver in St. Louis, opened "The Dry Salvages" (1941) by calling the Mississippi "a strong brown god": a deity forgotten by the dwellers in cities, demoted to a problem for the builders of bridges, but waiting. Eliot's river is a god of place that does not depend on worship. Gaiman's Egyptians live beside it on its sufferance.

Cairo's history adds another register. In November 1909, a crowd of thousands lynched William James in the town. After the Second World War the town's white establishment resisted desegregation, and the civil-rights struggle there in the late 1960s and early 1970s was among the most protracted and violent in the North. Cairo's population fell from more than fifteen thousand in 1920 to under four thousand by 2000. Gaiman's gods of the dead keep their business in a town whose public life has itself been a long dying. Chapter 10 returns to the lynching as an American rite of sacrifice.

The Egyptian gods have found employment in the one American industry that is a direct heir of Egypt: the preservation of the dead body for display. That industry was born of the Civil War. Embalmers followed the armies, preparing the bodies of officers and soldiers for shipment home; Thomas Holmes, often called the father of American embalming, claimed to have embalmed more than four thousand. The war's most famous corpse was Lincoln's. After his assassination, his embalmed body traveled by train from Washington to Springfield between April 21 and May 3, 1865, retracing in reverse much of the route of his inaugural journey, through some 180 cities and before millions of mourners along the way. The embalmed president, displayed and re-dressed at each stop, was the nation's first mummy, and his funeral train its first pilgrimage of the dead.

Gary Laderman's *The Sacred Remains* (1996) and *Rest in Peace* (2003) trace how the funeral director became a ritual specialist of American life; Jessica

Mitford's *The American Way of Death* (1963) satirized his commercial theology. Drew Gilpin Faust's *This Republic of Suffering* (2008) shows how the Civil War's dead produced the national cemetery and the modern rituals of American mourning. Anubis, the god who presided over embalming, and Thoth, who recorded the judgment of the dead, are at home in a business founded by the war that consecrated the nation's ground. The psychopomps of the Nile work in the industry created by Gettysburg, as Chapter 10 argues at length.

5.6 *The Spirit of Place: Lawrence, Deloria, and the Land That Does Not Need Belief*

In the opening chapter of *Studies in Classic American Literature* (1923), D. H. Lawrence set out the premise on which Gaiman's novel builds:

> Every continent has its own great spirit of place. Every people is polarized in some particular locality, which is home, the homeland. Different places on the face of the earth have different vital effluence, different vibration, different chemical exhalation, different polarity with different stars: call it what you like. But the spirit of place is a great reality.

In his essay on Fenimore Cooper's white novels, Lawrence describes that spirit as hostile to its colonizers:

> America hurts, because it has a powerful disintegrative influence upon the white psyche. It is full of grinning, unappeased aboriginal demons, too, ghosts, and it persecutes the white men, like some Eumenides, until the white men give up their absolute whiteness.

Lawrence's figure bears on Gaiman's career with unusual precision. The Eumenides are the Furies of Aeschylus's *Oresteia*, avengers of kindred blood, who at the end of the trilogy are given a home beneath the Areopagus and transformed into protectors of the city. Gaiman had used them for the penultimate arc of *The Sandman*, "The Kindly Ones" (1994–95), in which they pursue Dream to his death in settlement of a blood debt. Lawrence's America is haunted by Furies: spirits of the land who pursue the blood guilt of conquest.

Gaiman's land is not. The buffalo-headed man who speaks to Shadow from a fire in his dreams, and whom Whiskey Jack later identifies with the land itself, neither pursues nor accuses. He is older than the gods, and he stands apart from their war and from the economy that has drawn every other god into it. The difference between Lawrence's Furies and Gaiman's buffalo is the difference between a land that demands the settlement of a debt and a land

that is owed nothing because it was never part of the transaction. Chapter 6 asks what that difference costs.

Vine Deloria Jr.'s *God Is Red* (1973) supplies the theory Lawrence lacked. Deloria argued that the religions of Europe and its colonies are temporal, organized around a sacred history unfolding in time, while the religions of the indigenous peoples of North America are spatial, organized around sacred places. A temporal religion can be carried anywhere; a spatial religion cannot be moved. In J. Z. Smith's vocabulary, the first is utopian and the second locative.

Deloria's distinction maps the novel's metaphysics exactly. Both warring pantheons are temporal. The immigrant gods subsist on memory, carried across the sea in the minds of their worshippers and fading with each generation; the new gods subsist on attention, which is a quantity of time. Only the land is spatial, and that is why the land stands outside the war. A god made of time can be starved of time. A god made of place cannot be starved, only displaced from.

Keith Basso's *Wisdom Sits in Places* (1996) showed how Western Apache place-names carry moral narratives, so that the landscape stores a community's stories and instructs those who know them. N. Scott Momaday, in "The Man Made of Words" (1970), described a people's relation to its land as reciprocal appropriation: the people invests itself in the land and incorporates the land into its own experience. On these accounts, the land is not a god that needs belief but a reservoir that holds story — the function the novel otherwise assigns to Mr. Ibis.

Three historical facts give Deloria's distinction its force in a fiduciary reading.

The first concerns the buffalo. By the late 1880s the great herds of the Plains, once numbering in the tens of millions, had been reduced to a few hundred animals, in part by a policy that sought to defeat the Plains nations by destroying their food. On January 1, 1889, during a total eclipse of the sun, the Paiute prophet Wovoka received the vision from which the Ghost Dance spread across the West. As the ethnologist James Mooney recorded in *The Ghost-Dance Religion and the Sioux Outbreak of 1890* (1896), the dance promised the return of the dead and the restoration of the land and its game. Among the Lakota, the movement ended at Wounded Knee on December 29, 1890. That year's census reported that a frontier line could no longer be traced, a finding Frederick Jackson Turner made the occasion of his frontier thesis in 1893. A

religion of the land's return was born in an eclipse. The hero of Gaiman's novel, whose name describes an eclipse, is visited in dreams by a buffalo.

The second concerns coinage. From 1913 to 1938 the United States Mint struck James Earle Fraser's five-cent piece, with the head of an American Indian on one face and a bison on the other. Fraser named Iron Tail, an Oglala Lakota, and Two Moons, a Northern Cheyenne, among the men whose features he combined. The nation put the buffalo and the Indian on its currency at the moment both had been reduced to remnants: the land's sacred, minted as small change. The buffalo nickel is the fiduciary order's trophy of what it could not otherwise absorb.

The third concerns money refused. The Treaty of Fort Laramie of 1868 guaranteed the Black Hills, the Paha Sapa, to the Lakota; after gold was found there, the United States seized them by an act of 1877. Within them, at Mount Rushmore, the sculptor Gutzon Borglum carved four presidents between 1927 and 1941. In *United States v. Sioux Nation of Indians* (1980), the Supreme Court held that the taking required just compensation and affirmed an award of $17.5 million plus interest from 1877, some $106 million in all. The Lakota nations refused the money, insisting that the Black Hills were not for sale. The award remains in a federal account, accruing interest, and now exceeds a billion dollars.

The refused award is the clearest emblem in American history of a sacred that will not enter the fiduciary order. It is a pledge that compounds indefinitely because its owners will not draw on it: a well of Mímir whose depositors decline to drink. To accept the money would be to convert the land into credit, and its holders have refused that conversion for more than four decades. The land in *American Gods* is, in this precise sense, the one god that cannot be bought.

Geography completes the point. The geographic center of the fifty states, displaced in 1959 from Kansas to a point north of Belle Fourche, South Dakota, lies within the boundaries of the Great Sioux Reservation as the treaty of 1868 defined them. The true center of the nation lies on land the nation took. The novel's cardboard omphalos in Kansas, neutral ground for a settlement between gods, is the center only of the contiguous states.

Leslie Marmon Silko's *Ceremony* (1977) answers the novel's question about dying gods from the other side. Its hero, Tayo, a Laguna Pueblo veteran of the Second World War, is healed by the ceremonies of Betonie, a medicine man of mixed descent who insists that ceremonies must change in order to stay alive. Silko's land is wounded by uranium mining and by the atomic test at

Trinity, which her novel binds into a single story of "witchery," but it is not dead, and its ceremonies live because they adapt. Gaiman's immigrant gods die because their rites did not travel or did not change. Silko's ceremonies survive because they are remade in place. The land, in Silko as in Gaiman, outlasts every economy imposed on it.

5.7 *Map and Territory*

The novel's prefatory caveat — that its geography has been altered while its gods are real — reverses the relation between map and territory. Alfred Korzybski's dictum that a map is not the territory (*Science and Sanity*, 1933) became, in J. Z. Smith's hands, the title of an argument about religion: traditions are maps, the scholar must not confuse them with what they map, and the most revealing moments occur where map and territory fail to match. Jorge Luis Borges's one-paragraph fable "On Exactitude in Science" (1946) imagines an empire whose cartographers draw a map at the scale of one to one, which later generations abandon to sun and winter; its tatters survive in the western deserts, sheltering animals and beggars.

Gaiman's novel is a map of the American sacred whose roads are unreliable and whose gods are accurate. Its sacred geography is a counter-map, drawn not from surveys but from attractions, funeral homes, motels and reservations: the places where the nation's credit and collateral are exchanged, and the one place, the land, where they are not.

The three kinds of place correspond to the three registers of the fiduciary order. The roadside attraction exchanges attention for sacrality; it is the site of confidence, where Wednesday works. The battlefield and the funeral home hold the dead; they are sites of collateral. The land neither circulates nor collateralizes; it stands outside the economy and therefore outside the war.

The novel's figuration of the land is not, however, innocent. Its buffalo spirit speaks in dreams to a settler narrative that has first redescribed the continent's original peoples as its earliest immigrants. The next chapter examines that redescription.

CHAPTER

6

A Nation of Immigrants

Pluralism and the Settler-Colonial Unconscious

The "Coming to America" interludes, which the novel attributes to the pen of Mr. Ibis, compose a chronicle of arrivals. They stand to the main narrative as Genesis stands to Exodus: a prehistory of the gods' presence. Criticism has generally read the chronicle as an affirmation of American pluralism, the gods of a nation of immigrants arriving with every boatload. This chapter reads it otherwise.

Read for the modes of arrival it records, the chronicle documents migration, armed voyage, penal transportation, enslavement and immigration; only the last corresponds to the ideology the novel is taken to celebrate. Read for the god it places first, it redescribes the continent's original peoples as its earliest immigrants, a move that settler-colonial theory has taught us to recognize. The chapter argues that the novel both knows and disavows these facts. Its disavowal has the structure of fiduciary belief itself, Mannoni's *je sais bien, mais quand même* (Chapter 1).

6.1 *Carrying the Gods: Aeneas, Evocatio, and the Portable Sacred*

The Western archetype of the immigrant is a man carrying gods. The *Aeneid* announces in its sixth line that its hero's labors will last until he can found a city and bring his gods into Latium (*inferretque deos Latio*, 1.6). On the night

Troy falls, the ghost of Hector entrusts Aeneas with the city's sacred objects and household gods: *sacra suosque tibi commendat Troia penatis* (2.293). The verb is fiduciary. *Commendare* is to deposit, to give into another's keeping; Troy makes Aeneas the trustee of its gods.

As the refugees flee, Aeneas tells his father Anchises to take the sacred objects and ancestral gods in his hands (2.717–20). Aeneas, fresh from slaughter, may not touch them until he has washed in a living stream, and so he lifts his father onto his shoulders. The son carries the father, and the father carries the gods, held apart from the blood on the son's hands. Gaiman inverts the tableau. Shadow does not carry a living father who carries the gods; he keeps vigil over the corpse of a father who is a god, and the god demands the blood that Aeneas's gods could not touch.

Both of the pantheons that shaped the European imagination of divine migration are refugees from Troy. Vergil's Penates come from the burning city, and Snorri's Odin, as Chapter 1 showed, is a Trojan prince whose divinity was conferred by the peoples he settled among. The founding pantheons of the classical and northern West are diasporic.

Rome also practiced the inverse of Aeneas's piety. In the rite of *evocatio*, a commander besieging an enemy city called out its tutelary god, promising better worship in Rome. Livy records the most famous instance. Before the fall of Veii in 396 BCE, Camillus prayed: "You too, Queen Juno, who now dwell in Veii, I pray to follow us, the victors, into our city, soon to be yours, where a temple worthy of your greatness will receive you" (5.21.3). After the city fell, a young soldier asked her statue whether she wished to go to Rome, and his comrades declared that she had nodded (5.22). Macrobius preserves a formula of *evocatio* said to have been used against Carthage (*Saturnalia* 3.9).

Evocatio is a takeover offer addressed to a god: the transfer of a divinity's allegiance in exchange for a promissory note on future cult. The American migration of gods may be read as an *evocatio* without a counterparty. The promotional literature of colonization, from Thomas Hariot's *Briefe and True Report of the New Found Land of Virginia* (1588) onward, promised land, plenty and a new life, and the gods came over in the heads of those who believed it. No magistrate stood surety for the temple. The note was never honored.

J. Z. Smith's distinction between locative and utopian religion (Introduction) states the problem in structural terms. Most of the gods in Ibis's chronicle were locative in origin: gods of a household, a valley, a harvest, a coast. Migration required them to become utopian, portable without their places.

The novel's immigrant gods are locative deities failing to survive conversion into utopian ones.

6.2 *The Chronicle of Arrivals*

Ibis is Thoth, scribe of the gods and recorder of the judgment of the dead, and his chronicle is the novel's sacred history. It records five kinds of arrival.

1. **Migration.** In the earliest interlude, set some sixteen thousand years ago, a people led by the holy woman Atsula carry their god — Nunyunnini, worshipped in the form of a mammoth's skull — across the land bridge from Siberia. In the new land, within generations, he is forgotten.
2. **Armed voyage.** In a ninth-century interlude, Norse voyagers land on the American coast, build a hall, and hang a captured native man from a tree as an offering to Odin. The native people return and kill them all. The god they brought remains.
3. **Penal transportation.** Essie Tregowan, a Cornish servant convicted of theft, is transported to the American colonies. She keeps up the offerings of her childhood to the little people, and through her the fairy-folk of the Celtic fringe make the crossing.
4. **Enslavement.** The West African twins Wututu and Agasu are sold into slavery by their uncle. Wututu survives the Middle Passage and becomes, in New Orleans, Mama Zouzou, who instructs the young Marie Laveau. Agasu is shipped to Saint-Domingue, the colony whose slave revolution would make it Haiti.
5. **Immigration.** Among the "Somewhere in America" vignettes, Salim, a salesman from Oman, comes to New York to sell trinkets for his brother-in-law's firm and exchanges identities with a jinn who drives a taxi.

Only the last of these corresponds to the voluntary, individual, economic immigration that the phrase "a nation of immigrants" evokes. The others record a nomadic crossing, a colonizing raid that begins in a killing, the shipment of convicts and the trade in human beings. Between 1718 and 1775 Britain transported some fifty thousand convicts to its American colonies, as A. Roger Ekirch showed in *Bound for America* (1987). Of the roughly twelve and a half million Africans embarked in the transatlantic slave trade, about 388,000 were carried directly to mainland North America.

The chronicle's title has popular echoes: Neil Diamond's immigrant anthem "America" (1980), with its refrain of arrival, and the film *Coming to*

America (1988), in which an African prince seeks a bride in Queens. Ibis's chronicle borrows that cheerful phrase and fills it with coercion. "Coming to America" is, in most of its entries, a euphemism, and the chronicle unpacks it.

The chronicle also confirms the Herodotean principle of Chapter 1. The gods' American history exists because a scribe god writes it. Thoth was the Egyptian patron of writing and reckoning, the god who weighs and records; in Ibis's ledger the arrivals of the gods are entered as a historian's narrative and an accountant's book at once.

6.3 *The Melting Pot, the Orchestra, and the Market*

The ideology of the nation of immigrants has three classic formulations, and the novel refuses each.

The first is the melting pot. In "What Is an American?", the third of his *Letters from an American Farmer* (1782), J. Hector St. John de Crèvecoeur declared: "Here individuals of all nations are melted into a new race of men." The American, he wrote, is one who, "leaving behind him all his ancient prejudices and manners, receives new ones from the new mode of life he has embraced." Among the ancient prejudices left behind were the immigrants' gods. Crèvecoeur's motto for all emigrants was frankly economic: *Ubi panis ibi patria*, "where there is bread, there is one's country."

Israel Zangwill's play *The Melting-Pot* (1908) gave the image its name and its theology. Its hero, the Jewish composer David Quixano, calls America "God's Crucible, the great Melting-Pot where all the races of Europe are melting and re-forming," and cries: "into the Crucible with you all! God is making the American." Zangwill's crucible is an alchemical vessel in which a single God makes a new people out of many. In Gaiman's America, the crucible melts the gods.

The second formulation is cultural pluralism. Horace Kallen's "Democracy Versus the Melting-Pot" (*The Nation*, 1915) rejected assimilation for a federation of nationalities, each preserving its heritage, and offered the image of an orchestra, "an orchestration of mankind," in which each group contributes its own timbre to a common symphony. Randolph Bourne's "Trans-National America" (1916) went further: America was becoming "not a nationality but a trans-nationality, a weaving back and forth, with the other lands, of many threads of all sizes and colors."

The novel stages Kallen's orchestra literally: the automaton orchestras of the House on the Rock, playing mechanically for no one. Its gods do not harmonize. They compete, scheme and starve.

The third formulation is the market. Rodney Stark and Roger Finke's *The Churching of America, 1776–1990: Winners and Losers in Our Religious Economy* (1992) explained American religious vitality by competition among disestablished religious firms. The subtitle names Gaiman's subject. *American Gods* is the history of the losers.

The phrase itself became official late. Franklin Roosevelt told the Daughters of the American Revolution in 1938 to remember "that all of us, and you and I especially, are descended from immigrants and revolutionists." John F. Kennedy's pamphlet *A Nation of Immigrants* (1958), written for the Anti-Defamation League, fixed the phrase in political speech. Oscar Handlin's *The Uprooted* (1951) had already made immigration the master narrative of American history, and alienation its master emotion.

The novel's elegy has precise legal coordinates. The Immigration Act of 1924, the Johnson–Reed Act, imposed national-origins quotas that sharply reduced immigration from southern and eastern Europe for four decades. Communities that had depended on continuing arrivals to renew their languages, parishes and memories were cut off and assimilated. The Slavic gods of Gaiman's Chicago are the gods of such a community.

Czernobog, the black god, recalls his work as a knocker in the stockyards, killing cattle with a sledgehammer until the captive-bolt gun replaced him. His temple is Upton Sinclair's. *The Jungle* (1906) followed a Lithuanian immigrant through the Chicago packinghouses, where, Sinclair reported, they used every part of the hog except the squeal, and where the disassembly of animals by machine became, for Siegfried Giedion's *Mechanization Takes Command* (1948), a model for the assembly line. The industrial slaughterhouse is the blood economy stripped of its god: sacrifice without dedication, death without an altar. Czernobog, the god of the hammer, is displaced from it by a device. The Union Stock Yards closed in 1971.

The Hart–Celler Act of 1965 abolished the national-origins quotas, and its consequences contradict the novel's elegy. Diana Eck's *A New Religious America* (2001), published in the same year as *American Gods*, documented the flourishing of Hindu, Buddhist, Muslim, Sikh and Jain communities across the country, with temples rising in the suburbs. The gods of the post-1965 immigration were not dying. They were being collateralized by communities with institutions, renewed by continuing arrivals and anchored by buildings.

The novel half-acknowledges this. Kali, who attends Wednesday's council as the sharp-tongued Mama-ji, makes clear that she is doing well in India; her American self is a lesser local manifestation. The coda makes the principle explicit, when Shadow meets in Iceland an Odin who is not Wednesday, of whom Wednesday was only one American version.

The novel's gods thus have a corporate ontology. Each national incarnation is a branch, separately capitalized by local belief, and the insolvency of a branch does not bankrupt the parent. Wednesday is a branch manager whose franchise is failing, and his war is a scheme to recapitalize it locally, in blood.

6.4 *The Death of the Gods: Africa in America*

Wututu's interlude is the longest in the chronicle and the most exact in its history. Its premise was a central question of twentieth-century scholarship. Melville Herskovits's *The Myth of the Negro Past* (1941) argued that substantial African cultural and religious "retentions" survived slavery in the Americas. E. Franklin Frazier, in *The Negro Church in America* (1963), countered that enslavement had largely stripped African Americans of their ancestral heritage. Albert Raboteau's *Slave Religion* (1978) reframed the debate in a chapter titled "Death of the Gods."

Raboteau's conclusion is Gaiman's premise stated as history. In Brazil, Cuba and Haiti, the orisha and the lwa survived in Candomblé, Santería and Vodou. In the United States the African gods largely died, while an African sacred sensibility persisted in transformed and Christianized forms: the ring shout, conjure, the spirituals. Raboteau's explanations are demographic and institutional. The United States received only a small share of the trade, and Congress closed the legal importation of slaves from January 1, 1808. Thereafter the enslaved population grew chiefly by natural increase, so the African-born generation that remembered the gods passed away. Holdings were smaller and more dispersed, and the dominant Protestantism offered none of the saints behind whose images African gods were hidden elsewhere. Brazil, by contrast, did not suppress its slave trade until 1850, and Cuba received slave ships into the 1860s.

The fiduciary model reads Raboteau's demography as accountancy. A god survives as long as new deposits of belief arrive. The closure of the trade in 1808 and the quotas of 1924 are the two legal dates on which the replenishment of America's immigrant gods was cut off. The last deposit of the forced kind arrived illegally in 1860, when the schooner *Clotilda* landed its captives

near Mobile. One of them, Oluale Kossola, called Cudjo Lewis, told his story to Zora Neale Hurston in 1927 and 1928; her *Barracoon* appeared, long after her death, in 2018.

Gaiman places Wututu where Raboteau's exception lies. In 1809 nearly ten thousand refugees from Saint-Domingue, expelled from Cuba, arrived in New Orleans — whites, free people of color and enslaved people in roughly equal numbers — and doubled the city's population. They brought the lwa of Agasu's island to Wututu's city. In Congo Square the enslaved gathered on Sundays to dance, as Benjamin Latrobe recorded in 1819: the one place in the antebellum United States where collective effervescence around African gods was publicly tolerated. Marie Laveau, the Widow Paris, presided over the Vodou of New Orleans at mid-century. The twins' separate fates converge in a single history: the gods that survived Agasu's revolution came to rest in Wututu's city.

Zora Neale Hurston's essay "High John de Conquer" (1943) gives the African American answer to Dorson's informants. High John, she writes, came to America with the enslaved, as a whisper and a will to hope, and worked among them as a trickster-hero who made a way out of no way. When freedom came he went back to Africa, but he left his power behind in the root that bears his name. The god survives as a commodity. High John the Conqueror root is still sold by suppliers of hoodoo goods: a deity converted into merchandise without ceasing to work.

Hurston's study of Vodou in Haiti and Jamaica, *Tell My Horse* (1938), takes its title from a phrase spoken through a possessed devotee. In Haitian Vodou the lwa "mount" their devotees, who are called their horses (*chwal*), and the god speaks through the body it rides. A god without a horse is a god without a body. The carousel at the House on the Rock, on which the old gods ride to their council, carries hundreds of animals and not a single horse.

Anansi, the novel's Mr. Nancy, crossed with the enslaved Akan and survived because his medium was the most portable of all. In the Asante tradition recorded by R. S. Rattray, Anansi bought all the stories in the world from the sky god Nyame, paying with a python, a leopard, a swarm of hornets and a fairy, each captured by a trick; thereafter stories were called *Anansesem*, "spider stories." Aunt Nancy tales spread through the Caribbean and the American South, and the trickster tales of the plantation reached white readers through Joel Chandler Harris's *Uncle Remus* (1880) and, later, Disney's *Song of the South* (1946). Anansi is the one African god in the novel who thrives, because a god whose substance is story needs no shrine.

Ishmael Reed's *Mumbo Jumbo* (1972) had already staged a war of gods in America, with the African diaspora on one side. Its Jes Grew — named from James Weldon Johnson's remark that the early ragtime songs "jes' grew," itself an echo of Topsy in *Uncle Tom's Cabin* — is an "anti-plague" of dance, music and joy that spreads from New Orleans in the 1920s in search of its sacred Text. Its enemies are the Atonists, devotees of monotheist order since Akhenaten, and their militant Wallflower Order. Its lost Text is the Book of Thoth, and its champion is PaPa LaBas, a houngan detective.

Reed's novel is the most important precursor that criticism of Gaiman has neglected. It shares Gaiman's premise of a war of gods on American soil, and its scripture belongs to the god Gaiman makes his chronicler. Reed's diasporic gods, however, do not die; they spread. Jes Grew is a sacred contagion — the Technical Boy's virus inverted into joy — that survives by changing its medium from ritual to music. Reed's principle is Silko's (Chapter 5): the gods who live are the gods who change.

The constitutional order has occasionally protected the old economy. In *Church of the Lukumi Babalu Aye v. City of Hialeah* (1993), the Supreme Court struck down ordinances a Florida city had passed to suppress the animal sacrifices of Santería, a religion strengthened in South Florida by Cuban exiles after 1959. The orishas won, before the highest court in the land, the right to blood.

The deepest point of the Wututu interlude is financial. The persons who carried the African gods across the Atlantic were legally constituted as property and pledged as security. Bonnie Martin has documented the routine mortgaging of enslaved people to secure loans ("Slavery's Invisible Engine," 2010). Edward Baptist's *The Half Has Never Been Told* (2014) traces how Louisiana banks of the 1820s and 1830s issued bonds backed by mortgages on enslaved people and sold them to investors in Europe. In 1781 the crew of the slave ship *Zong* threw more than a hundred and thirty captive Africans overboard; the owners claimed for them under their insurance policy, and the English courts heard the claim as a question of marine insurance (*Gregson v. Gilbert*, 1783). Ian Baucom's *Specters of the Atlantic* (2005) reads the *Zong* as the founding scene of a speculative finance capital in which value attaches to human beings as insured abstractions.

In American history, then, the blood standard was not a mythic regime. It was the financial architecture of slavery: human lives pledged as security, insured as cargo and securitized as bonds. Wututu crossed the Atlantic as

collateral, and the gods she carried crossed inside an asset. Chapter 10 builds on this fact.

6.5 *The Ifrit's Taxi*

Salim's story is the chronicle's only account of immigration in the modern sense, and it is an account of exchange. A failed salesman, he cannot sell his brother-in-law's goods in New York. He hails a taxi whose driver, he discovers, has eyes of fire: an ifrit, one of the jinn, whom Islamic tradition describes as created from smokeless fire (Qur'an 55:15). They become lovers for a night. In the morning the ifrit has gone with Salim's clothes, his sample case and his identity, leaving behind his own license, keys and cab. No wish is granted. Instead, two lives are exchanged.

The ifrit's provenance is precise. The word occurs once in the Qur'an, in the same sura that tells of the queen of Sheba (27:39). When Solomon asks which of his court will bring him the queen's throne, an ifrit of the jinn offers to fetch it before the king can rise from his seat, adding that he is strong enough for the task and trustworthy (*amīn*). The adjective shares its root with *īmān*, faith, and *amāna*, a trust or deposit. Gaiman drew two of his figures, Bilquis and the ifrit, from a single chapter of the Qur'an, in which the ifrit's only speech is a claim to be trusted with a transfer of property across distance. In Gaiman's New York, the courier who offered to carry a queen's throne carries fares in a yellow cab.

The exchange inverts the immigrant's usual economy. The American Dream promises transformation through accumulation: money, property, papers and, at length, a new identity. Salim acquires a new identity at once, as a gift he did not purchase, and is freed from a job at which he was failing; the ifrit is freed from driving a cab. Neither is indebted to the other, and neither defaults. It is the first transaction in the novel that dissolves an obligation rather than creating one, and it anticipates the ethics of default developed in Chapter 11.

The story's sexuality is integral to this. It is the novel's most tender sexual encounter, between two men, both foreigners, whom their homeland would censure and their host country ignores. Bilquis's encounters are paid twice, in cash and in life. Salim's is not paid at all, and it stands outside every economy the novel describes.

6.6 *First Immigrants? The Settler-Colonial Unconscious*

The chronicle begins with Nunyunnini. By placing the Beringian crossing first, Ibis — and Gaiman — make the continent's first peoples its first immigrants. Their god, like all the others, is carried in and forgotten. The effect is to fold Indigenous history into the national narrative of arrival: every people in America came from somewhere, and every god in America has died.

The move has a political history. Vine Deloria Jr.'s *Red Earth, White Lies* (1995) attacked the Bering Strait theory as a colonial myth whose function was to make Indians merely earlier immigrants and so to weaken their claims to the land. Deloria's scientific objections have not prevailed. Genetic and archaeological evidence supports a Beringian ancestry for the Indigenous peoples of the Americas, and footprints at White Sands, New Mexico, reported in 2021, suggest a human presence twenty-one to twenty-three thousand years ago.

The political point survives the science. Whatever their remote origins, Indigenous nations hold traditions of emergence in place. Lakota tradition locates the people's emergence at Wind Cave in the Black Hills — the land taken in 1877 and the subject of the refused award discussed in Chapter 5. Hopi tradition locates it at the Sipapu in the gorge of the Little Colorado. To call such peoples immigrants is to translate a cosmology of place into a narrative of arrival.

Settler-colonial theory names the operation. Patrick Wolfe argued that settler invasion "is a structure not an event," governed by a logic of elimination that persists after conquest ("Settler Colonialism and the Elimination of the Native," 2006). Lorenzo Veracini's *Settler Colonialism: A Theoretical Overview* (2010) catalogues the discursive transfers by which settler societies remove Indigenous peoples from the present tense. Eve Tuck and K. Wayne Yang called such maneuvers "settler moves to innocence" ("Decolonization Is Not a Metaphor," 2012): strategies that relieve settler guilt without surrendering land. Roxanne Dunbar-Ortiz's *Not "A Nation of Immigrants"* (2021) indicts the phrase itself as an instrument of erasure.

Jodi Byrd's *The Transit of Empire* (2011) supplies the decisive distinction. Borrowing the term "arrivant" from Kamau Brathwaite's poetic trilogy *The Arrivants* (1973), Byrd distinguishes settlers, arrivants — those forced into the Americas by enslavement and imperial violence — and Indigenous peoples. Ibis's chronicle contains all three: settlers (the Norse, Essie Tregowan, Salim), arrivants (Wututu and Agasu) and natives (the people of the Beringian crossing, whom the chronicle nonetheless records as arrivals). The ideology of the

nation of immigrants collapses the triad into a single category. The chronicle's content preserves the triad; its frame erases it.

The novel's Indigenous figures follow conventions Renée Bergland analyzed in *The National Uncanny: Indian Ghosts and American Subjects* (2000). American literature, Bergland argued, has admitted Indians chiefly as ghosts and spirits, figures of haunting whose spectral presence confirms their absence from the political present. Philip Deloria's *Playing Indian* (1998) traced the parallel practice by which settlers, from the Boston Tea Party onward, have borrowed Indian identity to authenticate an American one. The buffaloman who speaks in Shadow's dreams is an Indian spirit in Bergland's sense, a sovereign who appears only in vision. Whiskey Jack, whose name anglicizes the Cree and Algonquian trickster Wisakedjak, lives on a Lakota reservation — a composite that serves the novel's mythology better than any one nation's history.

Yet the chronicle also knows what its frame denies. The first act of the old gods on American soil, in the Norse interlude, is the hanging of a native man as an offering to Odin. The saga record supports the image. In *Grænlendinga saga*, the first encounter between Norse explorers and the people they called *skrælingar* ends with the explorers killing eight of nine men found sleeping under their skin boats, and their leader, Thorvald Eiriksson, is killed by an arrow in the reprisal. The first settler colony in the Americas fails, and the first sacrifice to Odin on the continent is of a man from that continent. Odin's American cult begins in Indigenous blood.

The English colonization of Virginia offers a second primal scene. Thomas Hariot reported in 1588 that the Algonquian peoples of Roanoke were so astonished by the colonists' compasses, perspective glass, burning glasses, books and "spring clocks that seeme to goe of themselves" that "they thought they were rather the works of gods then of men." He also recorded that villages the English visited sickened and died, and that survivors attributed the deaths to invisible bullets shot by the English. Stephen Greenblatt's essay "Invisible Bullets" (1981) made Hariot's report a parable of colonial power's capacity to produce belief. In English America, the first new gods were the colonists and their machines, and their arrival killed many who took them for gods. The Technical Boy has an ancestor at Roanoke.

The novel's treatment of the land completes the pattern. Lawrence's land pursued its conquerors like the Furies (Chapter 5); Gaiman's buffalo forgives what it was never asked to forgive. The novel thereby makes the land the only native on the continent, a radical ecological claim that no people precedes

the earth. It also makes every human people an immigrant, which levels the Indigenous claim with the settler's. The first move honors Deloria's spatial sacred; the second performs a settler move to innocence.

This double structure is the settler-colonial unconscious. The novel knows — the hanging, the reservation, the land that was taken — and it disavows, through its frame of universal arrival and its benign spirit of place. *Je sais bien, mais quand même.* The structure is that of fiduciary belief (Chapter 1): knowing that the currency is backed by nothing, and continuing to accept it.

6.7 *The Clearing-House*

The nation the chronicle describes is neither Crèvecoeur's melting pot nor Kallen's orchestra. It is Whitman's portfolio (Chapter 2): a clearing-house in which gods circulate as instruments of credit, their value dependent on the solvency of the memories that carry them. New deposits of belief arrived voluntarily with immigrants and involuntarily in the holds of slave ships, and the law cut them off in 1808 and 1924. The persons who carried the gods were sometimes themselves collateral. One sacred, the land, never entered the clearing-house at all.

The figure who flourishes in a clearing-house is the one who trades on confidence. The next chapter turns to him.

PART

IV

Dramaturgies

7 *"It Is Good to Be Shifty in a New Country"*

8 *The Clunker on the Ice*

9 *The Rotting Bride*



CHAPTER

7

"It Is Good to Be Shifty in a New Country"

The Confidence-Man as American Deity

This chapter's title is the motto of Captain Simon Suggs, the swindler-hero of Johnson Jones Hooper's frontier sketches (1845). It could serve as Wednesday's. The chapter argues that the most American god in *American Gods* is not any of the imported deities but the confidence man, and that Wednesday is the point at which the Eddic Odin and the American con man become indistinguishable.

The argument traces the type from its naming in 1849 through Melville, the Eddic sources, Wednesday's own cons, the frontier humorists and Barnum, and the prophet-banker Joseph Smith. It ends by distinguishing the con man, who demands belief, from the trickster who announces his trick.

7.1 *"Have You Confidence in Me?": The Naming of a Type*

The phrase "confidence man" entered American English in July 1849, when the *New York Herald* reported the arrest of William Thompson. A man of genteel appearance, he would strike up an acquaintance with a stranger in the street and ask, in the *Herald*'s words, "have you confidence in me to trust me with your watch until to-morrow"; the stranger, to prove his confidence, would hand it over. The swindle consisted entirely of a request for trust, and its object was a timepiece. The first American confidence man stole time.

Herman Melville's *The Confidence-Man: His Masquerade* was published on April 1, 1857, April Fools' Day, the day on which its action also takes place. Its setting is a Mississippi steamboat named the *Fidèle*, the faithful one, and its protagonist, if he is one, appears in a succession of guises. A deaf-mute in cream-colored clothes writes the clauses of Paul's hymn to charity on a slate: charity thinketh no evil, suffereth long, believeth all things, never faileth (1 Corinthians 13). Then come a crippled Black beggar called Black Guinea; a man in mourning with a weed in his hat; an agent collecting for a Seminole widows' and orphans' asylum; the president of the Black Rapids Coal Company, selling stock; an herb-doctor peddling an Omni-Balsamic Reinvigorator; an agent of a Philosophical Intelligence Office; and, finally, the genial cosmopolitan Frank Goodman.

Melville's book is a theology of confidence. Each avatar solicits the same thing — trust, extended in advance and without proof — and each passenger's willingness to extend it is weighed against his refusal. The deaf-mute's text, "Charity believeth all things," makes belief itself the con man's scripture, and the ship's name is the Latin *fides* in French dress. Melville's avatars are what Odin's names are in the *Grímnismál*: one power circulating under many faces.

The novel appeared four months before the Panic of 1857, which began in August with the failure of the Ohio Life Insurance and Trust Company. A book about the extension of confidence was followed by a national withdrawal of it. *American Gods*, written during the dot-com bubble and published after the crash (Chapter 4), stands in the inverse relation.

The darkest chapters of *The Confidence-Man* concern the Indian-hater, Colonel John Moredock, whose "metaphysics of Indian-hating" Melville develops from James Hall's *Sketches of History, Life, and Manners in the West* (1835). Moredock devotes his life to killing Indians as a vow, a vocation with the structure of a religious order. Melville sets this frontier creed of extermination inside a novel of confidence tricks, as though the nation's founding violence were the con's dark twin. The juxtaposition anticipates the settler-colonial unconscious of Chapter 6.

The book ends with an extinguished light. In the last chapter, the cosmopolitan sits with an old man reading the Bible beneath a solar lamp whose shade shows a horned altar and a robed figure with a halo. The lamp is failing; the cosmopolitan puts it out and, in the darkness that follows, kindly leads the old man away. The final sentence promises that something further may follow of this masquerade. The confidence man's last act is an eclipse of

the light of faith, and its sequel is unwritten. Gaiman's hero is named for an eclipse.

7.2 *Bölverkr: The Eddic Con*

The Eddic Odin is the con man's original. In the *Grímnismál*, bound between two fires in the hall of King Geirröðr, Odin recites a catalogue of his names and declares: *einu nafni hétumk aldregi, síz ek með folkum fór* — "by one name I have never been called, since I went among the peoples" (st. 48). A god who wanders among the peoples under many names is a confidence man by definition.

The *Grímnismál* is also a theoxeny, a tale of a god who tests hospitality in disguise. Odin visits Geirröðr as Grímnir, "the masked one," endures eight nights between the fires, and reveals himself only when it is too late for his host. The Epistle to the Hebrews warns that some, by entertaining strangers, "have entertained angels unawares" (13:2). Every confidence man exploits that warning. Wednesday's first appearance, as a stranger in the seat beside Shadow on a plane who already knows Shadow's name, is a theoxeny staged as a con.

The episode in which Odin acquires the mead of poetry is the paradigm of the Odinic con, and Snorri tells it in *Skáldskaparmál*. Calling himself Bölverkr, "evil-worker," Odin comes upon nine thralls mowing hay and offers to sharpen their scythes with a whetstone from his belt. They find the edges so keen that each asks to buy the stone. He throws it into the air, and in the scramble for it they cut one another's throats with their scythes. Odin then hires himself to their master, the giant Baugi, brother of Suttungr, offering to do the work of the nine dead men in exchange for a drink of the mead. When Suttungr refuses, Odin bores into the mountain with the auger Rati, slips through the hole as a snake, sleeps three nights with Gunnlöð, and drains the mead in three draughts.

The whetstone trick is Wednesday's war in miniature. The trickster makes an object desirable by his own performance, throws it among rivals, lets them kill one another for it, and collects what their deaths make available. The mead of poetry, source of all inspired speech in the Norse world, is obtained by a con that costs nine lives. Girard would recognize the mechanism: mimetic rivalry over an object whose value consists in the rivals' desire for it, resolved by mutual violence that profits a third party. The Eddic source contains the novel's plot.

7.3 *The Fiddle Game: Collateral, Mimesis, and the Two-Man Con*

Among Wednesday's first demonstrations to Shadow is a fraud on a bank. In a security guard's uniform, he stands beside a night-deposit box he has marked out of order and receives the night's deposits himself. The con impersonates the fiduciary institution. Its victims trust the uniform as they trust the bank: they are depositors, and the god collects the deposits. Wednesday's American career begins by literalizing the claim of Chapter 1 that a god is a trustee who receives deposits of belief.

Among the swindles Wednesday describes to Shadow is the fiddle game, one of the classic two-man cons. A shabby man eats a meal, discovers he has no money, and leaves his old violin with the proprietor as security while he goes to fetch his wallet. While he is gone, a well-dressed stranger notices the violin, examines it with mounting excitement, pronounces it a rare instrument and offers a large sum for it; but he must leave for an appointment, and he gives the proprietor his card. When the shabby man returns, the proprietor, anticipating a profit, buys the violin from him for a sum far below the stranger's offer but far above its worth. The stranger never returns, and the partners split the proceeds.

The fiddle game is a theory of value in the form of a crime. The violin is collateral, left as security for a debt. Its value is conjured by a confederate's performed desire, and the mark pays real money for a fictional value he expects to realize from a buyer who exists only as a role. René Girard's *Mensonge romantique et vérité romanesque* (1961) argued that desire is triangular: we desire objects because a mediator appears to desire them. The fiddle game is triangular desire monetized, with the stranger as mediator.

John Maynard Keynes's "beauty contest" (*The General Theory*, 1936, ch. 12) described professional investment in the same terms: investors choose not what they judge valuable but what they expect others to judge valuable. André Orléan's theory of money as self-referential belief (Chapter 1) generalizes the point. The fiddle game is a market in miniature.

Shadow's revelation on Lookout Mountain identifies the war as a con of this structure: a two-man con in which the partners pretend to be strangers. Wednesday plays the shabby man, offering collateral of dubious value — a pantheon of starving gods and a grievance. Loki, as Mr. World, plays the stranger whose performed appetite for war makes the war seem valuable to the new gods. Both pantheons are marks. The violin is the war itself, an instrument worthless in itself and made precious by the partners' performance of opposition. The take is split: the dead to Odin, the chaos to Loki.

David Maurer's *The Big Con* (1940), the classic study of the professional confidence man's argot and method, describes the roper who finds the mark, the inside man who works him, the "store" in which the scene is staged, and the "blow-off" that separates him from his money. Erving Goffman generalized the aftermath in "On Cooling the Mark Out" (1952). After the sting, one confederate stays with the victim to console him and help him accept his loss quietly, so that he does not go to the police. Every society, Goffman argued, needs institutions that cool out its marks: the dismissed employee, the rejected suitor, the defeated candidate.

The novel's resolution reverses the blow-off. Shadow does not cool out the marks; he tells them they have been conned. The revelation of the con, rather than its consummation, ends the war. Chapter 11 argues that this act of disclosure is the novel's ethical center.

7.4 *"It Is Good to Be Shifty in a New Country": Revival, Humbug, and the Frontier*

The American literature of the con begins with a sacrifice. Charles Brockden Brown's *Wieland; or, The Transformation* (1798) drew on the case of a New York farmer who killed his family in 1781 at what he believed was God's command. Its setting is a religiously intense household on a Pennsylvania estate. A mysterious stranger, Carwin, practices "biloquism," the art of throwing his voice, and his imitations of disembodied speech unsettle a family already given to enthusiasm. Theodore Wieland then hears a voice commanding him to sacrifice his wife and children, and he obeys. Carwin confesses to the earlier voices but denies the last, and the novel never settles whether the command came from the ventriloquist, from God or from Wieland's own mind.

Wieland is the American ur-text of the con that becomes a sacrifice. A trickster's acoustic illusions enter a mind trained to hear God, and the result is an Akedah in which no angel stays the father's hand. It is also the first American case of an illusion whose owner cannot be found, the condition Chapter 11 identifies as the precondition of sacrifice. Brown's ventriloquist worked a household; his successors worked the frontier.

The American confidence man was born on the frontier, and he worked revivals. In Johnson Jones Hooper's *Some Adventures of Captain Simon Suggs, Late of the Tallapoosa Volunteers* (1845), Simon attends a camp-meeting, stages a spectacular conversion, offers to found a church in his own neighborhood, collects the congregation's money for the purpose and rides away with it. His

motto, printed in capitals, gives this chapter its title: "IT IS GOOD TO BE SHIFTY IN A NEW COUNTRY."

The country was new because it had just been taken. Hooper's sketches are set in east Alabama in the years of the Creek removal, and the Tallapoosa Volunteers of the title are a militia of the Creek War of 1836. Under the Treaty of Cusseta (1832), Muscogee Creek lands were allotted to individuals and then passed to speculators in a wave of fraud, even as their owners were driven west. The shiftiness Simon praises flourishes on land just emptied of its people. The American confidence man is a creature of the settler frontier.

Mark Twain reworked the scene four decades later. In chapter 20 of *Adventures of Huckleberry Finn* (1884–85), the swindler called the King attends a camp meeting at Pokeville, poses as a pirate converted to Christ who will return to the Indian Ocean to convert his old comrades, and collects eighty-seven dollars and seventy-five cents. The King claims to be the lost Dauphin, Louis XVII, and his partner claims to be the rightful Duke of Bridgewater. Later, posing as the English brothers of a dead man, they attempt to steal his estate. They are false sovereigns in exile and false immigrants, Heine's exiled gods (Chapter 2) reborn as grifters. Wednesday, a deposed king of the gods who may be nothing but a swindler, is their heir. Twain's "The Man That Corrupted Hadleyburg" (1899), in which a stranger's sack of false gold exposes a town that has staked its identity on its incorruptibility, is read beside Lakeside in Chapter 8.

Phineas Taylor Barnum made the humbug a public art. His first great exhibit, in 1835, was Joice Heth, an elderly enslaved woman whom he advertised as the 161-year-old former nurse of George Washington. When she died in 1836, Barnum staged a public autopsy before a paying audience, at which a surgeon judged her to be about eighty. Benjamin Reiss's *The Showman and the Slave* (2001) reconstructs the case. Its elements are the novel's: a false relic of the nation's sacred founding, a Black woman's body as the instrument of a con, and an autopsy performed for profit. Gaiman's Egyptian gods perform autopsies in Cairo, Illinois, as an office of their divinity; Barnum performed one as entertainment.

Barnum's Feejee Mermaid (1842), the upper body of a monkey sewn to the tail of a fish, drew crowds who suspected a hoax and came to judge for themselves. Neil Harris, in *Humbug: The Art of P. T. Barnum* (1973), called this pleasure the "operational aesthetic": an audience's delight in examining how a trick is done, in being fooled while knowing that it may be fooled. Har-

ris's concept is indispensable to Chapter 11, where the operational aesthetic becomes the basis of the conjuror's covenant.

The Cardiff Giant of 1869 is the most compact American parable of fiduciary religion. George Hull, an atheist tobacconist, had argued with a Methodist revivalist who insisted on the literal truth of Genesis 6:4: "There were giants in the earth in those days." To mock such literalism, Hull had a ten-foot man carved from gypsum, aged and buried on a relative's farm at Cardiff, New York. When it was "discovered" in October 1869, crowds paid to see it, and some clergy hailed it as confirmation of scripture. Barnum, refused the chance to lease it, had a plaster copy made and exhibited his counterfeit of the counterfeit in New York, where it outdrew the original. The phrase "there's a sucker born every minute," usually misattributed to Barnum, is said to have been coined in this affair by one of the original's owners, describing the crowds at Barnum's copy.

The Cardiff Giant contains the novel's metaphysics in a single object: a giant made by a hoaxer, sustained by believers, and outcompeted by a copy whose value lies entirely in its circulation. It is the American theogony in gypsum.

Edgar Allan Poe had already reduced the type to a science. "Diddling Considered as One of the Exact Sciences" (1843) defines man as "an animal that diddles" and itemizes the diddler's ingredients: minuteness, interest, perseverance, ingenuity, audacity, nonchalance, originality, impertinence and, last, grin. "Your true diddler," Poe concludes, "winds up all with a grin." Wednesday's grin, delighted and predatory at once, is the diddler's signature.

7.5 *Prophet, Banker, Swindler: Charisma as Credit*

Max Weber's theory of charismatic authority, set out in *Economy and Society* (1922), is a fiduciary theory. Charisma, for Weber, is a quality attributed to a person by virtue of which he is treated as endowed with extraordinary powers. What matters sociologically is not whether the powers are real but whether followers recognize them, and charisma that fails to prove itself in success is withdrawn. Charisma is credit extended by followers and called in at the first default.

Among Weber's examples are the berserker, the Norse warrior in battle frenzy, consecrated in the sagas to Odin, and Joseph Smith, the founder of Mormonism. Of Smith, Weber remarks that he may have been a very sophisticated type of deliberate swindler, and he insists that sociological analysis

must treat such figures on the same level as the greatest heroes, prophets and saviors. Weber's discussion sets Odin's berserker beside an American prophet whose sincerity is undecidable. It is the closest theoretical description of Wednesday ever written.

Smith's career joins revelation, treasure and banking. In 1826 he was brought before a justice of the peace in Chenango County, New York, as a disorderly person and an impostor, for seeking buried treasure with a seer stone. By the accounts of several witnesses, he later used a seer stone in translating the golden plates of the Book of Mormon. D. Michael Quinn's *Early Mormonism and the Magic World View* (1987) traced these roots in the folk magic of treasure-digging.

In January 1837 Smith and his associates, having been refused a bank charter, organized the Kirtland Safety Society Anti-Banking Company in Ohio. It issued notes and failed within the year in the Panic of 1837, leaving its notes worthless. The American prophet was a treasure-seeker before he was a revelator, and a banker after. Revelation, money-digging and the issue of paper credit were, in his career, one continuous practice.

Charles Ponzi gave the fiduciary con its modern name. In 1920 he promised Boston investors returns of fifty percent in forty-five days, ostensibly from arbitrage in international postal reply coupons, and paid early investors with the deposits of later ones until the scheme collapsed. A Ponzi scheme is solvent only so long as new money arrives faster than old obligations fall due.

By that definition, every god in the novel's immigrant pantheon is a Ponzi structure. Its obligations to old worshippers are met by the deposits of new ones, and when the deposits stop — in 1808, in 1924 — the structure collapses. Wednesday's war is an attempt to meet a run on the bank with a final, enormous and illegitimate deposit.

7.6 *Trickster and Shadow*

The confidence man descends from the trickster, but he is not the trickster. The distinction is the hinge of the novel's ethics.

Paul Radin's *The Trickster: A Study in American Indian Mythology* (1956) published the trickster cycle of the Winnebago, the Ho-Chunk, whose homeland is the Wisconsin of Gaiman's novel. The cycle's Wakdjunkaga is creator and destroyer, giver and negator, dupe and duper; his foolishness makes the world. Radin's volume included a commentary by C. G. Jung, "On the Psy-

chology of the Trickster-Figure," which describes the trickster as a collective shadow figure: a summation of the inferior traits of individuals, preserved in myth so that a culture can recognize what it has repressed.

The novel's protagonist is named Shadow, and he lives among tricksters: Wednesday, Loki, Anansi, Whiskey Jack, and the cellmate Low Key Lyesmith. In Jung's terms, the hero bears the name of what the tricksters around him embody.

William Hynes and William Doty's *Mythical Trickster Figures* (1993) list the trickster's recurrent traits: he is ambiguous and anomalous, a deceiver and trick-player, a shape-shifter, a situation-inverter, a messenger and imitator of the gods, and a sacred and lewd bricoleur. Lewis Hyde's *Trickster Makes This World* (1998) adds the decisive function: the trickster crosses boundaries and thereby creates culture. Henry Louis Gates Jr.'s *The Signifying Monkey* (1988) traced the Yoruba Esu-Elegbara — the Papa Legba of Vodou, guardian of crossroads and translator between gods and humans — into the African American Signifying Monkey and the double-voiced practice of signifyin(g). Ralph Ellison's *Invisible Man* (1952) gave the protean con man his African American form in Rinehart: runner, gambler, briber, lover and reverend, a man who is whatever the observer takes him to be.

The novel divides the trickster's legacy between two figures. Wednesday and Loki are tricksters who have entered the market: they cross boundaries in order to extract. Anansi is a trickster who has remained a storyteller. His tales make the gods' councils bearable, and his laughter, as Chapter 2 suggested, is the alternative to the twilight.

The Akan tradition from which Anansi comes marks the difference with a formula. Rattray recorded that Asante storytellers opened their tales with a disclaimer: "We do not really mean, we do not really mean, that what we are going to say is true." They closed by releasing the story into circulation: whether it was sweet or not, the listener should take some elsewhere and let some come back. The story-trickster announces his fiction before he begins. The con man asks, "Have you confidence in me?" The first is a covenant of acknowledged illusion; the second is a demand for credit.

This distinction structures the rest of the study. The con conceals its trick and demands belief; the story discloses its trick and asks only for attention. Shadow's coin tricks, practiced throughout the novel and performed at its close, belong to the second kind.

7.7 *The Confidence-God*

The most American god in *American Gods* is not an import. Odin, Anansi, Czernobog and Bilquis came from elsewhere; the confidence man was named in New York in 1849, raised on the frontier and canonized by Melville on April Fools' Day. Wednesday is the point at which the Eddic Odin and the American confidence man become indistinguishable: Bölverkr on the *Fidèle*, Grímnir at a night-deposit box, a god who has never been called by one name.

If the novel's title names a single deity, it is confidence itself: the power by which gods, money and nations pass so long as nobody refuses them. The con man is its priest, and the mark is its congregation. The next chapter examines a congregation that knows exactly what it is paying for.

CHAPTER

8

The Clunker on the Ice

Lakeside, Folk Horror, and the Theodicy of Good Fortune

Lakeside is a detective story embedded in a myth. Wednesday hides Shadow in a small town in northern Wisconsin under the name Mike Ainsel, and Shadow, waiting there through the winter, discovers that the town's unusual prosperity is purchased with a child each year. The children vanish one per winter. Their bodies are hidden in the trunk of the old car, the "clunker," that the town sets on the frozen lake and raffles off, the prize going to whoever guesses the moment it will break through the ice. The keeper of the bargain is Hinzelmann, the town's oldest resident and most genial storyteller, who is a kobold, a household spirit of the German forests.

This chapter argues that Lakeside is the blood standard at the scale of a town, and the novel's most disturbing image of it, because there it works. Wednesday's war is a sacrifice extracted by deception from marks who do not know they are paying. Lakeside is a sacrifice tacitly consented to by a community that prefers not to know what it pays. The chapter reads the town through the kobold tradition, the lottery as a sacrificial institution, the folk-horror town from Hawthorne to Stephen King, and the philosophical problem of a happiness bought with a child's suffering.

8.1 *My Ain Sel: The Hiding Place*

Shadow's alias carries a warning. In the Northumbrian tale that Joseph Jacobs printed as "My Own Self" (*More English Fairy Tales*, 1894), a boy sitting late by the fire is visited by a fairy child who asks his name. He answers "My ainsel" — my own self. When he burns her with a coal and her fairy mother demands to know who hurt her, the child can only cry "My ainsel!", and the mother, concluding that her daughter hurt herself, takes no revenge. The name is a defense against the vengeance of the hidden folk. Wednesday gives it to a man about to live beside one of them.

The name also states the novel's question about its hero. "Mike Ainsel" is "my own self," the identity that Shadow, an instrument of his father's scheme, does not yet possess. Lakeside is where he begins to acquire it.

The town is a hiding place in a second sense. Freud's essay "Das Unheimliche" (1919) begins with the German word *heimlich*, which means both "homely, familiar" and "secret, concealed," and shows how its meaning develops until it coincides with its opposite, *unheimlich*. Freud adopts Schelling's definition: the uncanny is everything that ought to have remained secret and hidden but has come to light. Lakeside is *heimlich* in both senses, a homely town with a hidden heart. The kobold is literally a household spirit, a god of the *Heim*. The discovery of the child in the trunk is the uncanny in Freud's exact sense: the return to light of what the home had hidden.

Lakeside's prosperity is itself uncanny. In a region where logging, mining and family farming had been failing for decades, and where the farm crisis of the 1980s hollowed out small towns (as Osha Gray Davidson documented in *Broken Heartland*, 1990), Lakeside's busy main street is an anomaly that demands explanation. Mark Fisher, in *The Weird and the Eerie* (2016), located the eerie in the question of hidden agency — what is acting here, and to what end — and observed that capital is an eerie entity, conjured from nothing yet more powerful than any substantial thing. Lakeside's luck is eerie in Fisher's sense. The agent behind it is a god.

8.2 *The Kobold: Household God and Counterfeit Ore*

German folklore knows the kobold in two forms. The household kobold lives in a farmhouse or castle, does chores, brings luck and demands offerings — a bowl of milk, a portion of food — on pain of mischief or ruin if neglected. The most celebrated was Hinzelmann, who haunted the castle of Hudemühlen on the Lüneburg Heath in the 1580s. His doings were recorded

in a pastor's chronicle of 1704 and retold by the Brothers Grimm in *Deutsche Sagen* (1816) and by Thomas Keightley in *The Fairy Mythology* (1828); Gaiman took his kobold's name from that legend. In August Kopisch's poem "Die Heinzelmännchen zu Köln" (1836), the little men of Cologne secretly do the townspeople's work by night until a tailor's curious wife scatters peas on the stairs to trip them and see them, and they vanish forever. In Cologne, curiosity ends the town's good fortune. In Lakeside, curiosity is what the town has learned to suppress.

The mining kobold is the other form, and it bears directly on this study's argument. Miners in the ore mountains of Saxony blamed kobolds for ores that looked rich but yielded no silver and gave off poisonous fumes when smelted. The element later isolated from such ores was named for the goblin: cobalt, from *Kobold*. Nickel has a parallel history; miners called a deceptive copper-colored ore *Kupfernickel*, "copper-demon," because it yielded no copper. The kobold is a spirit of false value, the counterfeiter of the underground who substitutes worthless ore for precious metal. The five-cent coin of the United States is named for one such demon.

Gaiman adds a theogony of his own. The novel explains that in the old country a kobold was made by sacrificing a child, kept in darkness, fed and then killed, so that its spirit became the protecting god of its people. Hinzelmann was such a child. Brought to America with immigrants, he kept Lakeside prosperous in exchange for the death, each winter, of one of its children.

The invention literalizes René Girard's account of the origin of gods. For Girard, the sacred begins in a founding murder: a community's violence converges on a victim whose death restores peace, and the victim, credited with the restoration, is divinized. Ritual sacrifice then repeats the founding murder to renew its effect. Hinzelmann is the sacrificed child who becomes the god who demands sacrificed children: the victim divinized, the founding murder repeated every winter. He is the most purely Girardian god in the novel, and his rite its most purely Girardian institution.

8.3 *The Clunker Raffle: Lottery, Divination, Sacrifice*

The clunker raffle has real counterparts. Towns across the upper Midwest hold "ice-out" contests in which residents bet on the moment an old car set on a frozen lake will break through. The most famous such lottery, the Nenana Ice Classic in Alaska, has since 1917 sold tickets on the day, hour and minute at which the ice of the Tanana River will break up, measured by a tripod on the

ice tied to a clock. These contests are lotteries on a natural event: divinations of spring.

The lot has an ancient relation to sacrifice. On the Day of Atonement, Aaron is to "cast lots upon the two goats; one lot for the LORD, and the other lot for the scapegoat" (Leviticus 16:8). The second goat is driven into the wilderness bearing the people's sins, and William Tyndale coined the English word "scapegoat" for the passage in 1530. When a storm threatens Jonah's ship, the sailors "cast lots, and the lot fell upon Jonah" (Jonah 1:7), and the sea grows calm only after they throw him overboard. Girard read both scenes as the scapegoat mechanism at work: chance conceals the community's own choice of victim.

Shirley Jackson's "The Lottery" (*The New Yorker*, June 26, 1948) made the connection an American nightmare. In a pleasant village on a fine summer morning, the townspeople gather for their annual lottery, and the winner is stoned to death by her neighbors and family. The village's oldest man recalls a saying that ties the June lottery to a heavy harvest of corn. The story provoked more mail than any work of fiction the magazine had published.

Gaiman inverts Jackson. In "The Lottery," the lot selects the victim, and the winner dies. In Lakeside, the raffle selects only a winner of money, and the victim is chosen by no lot: the child is taken in secret by the god, and the raffle's chance disguises a predetermined killing as a civic game. Jackson's village sacrifices openly and pretends it is chance. Lakeside sacrifices secretly and pretends it is a raffle. The clunker is the novel's most compact image of a sacrificial economy laundered through an institution of luck.

8.4 *Summerisle, Derry, Castle Rock: The Folk-Horror Town*

Adam Scovell's *Folk Horror* (2017) describes a recurring "folk horror chain": a landscape that isolates, a community whose beliefs and morals have become skewed, and a "happening" — a summoning or sacrifice in which those beliefs culminate. The British films later grouped as the genre's "unholy trinity" — *Witchfinder General* (1968), *The Blood on Satan's Claw* (1971) and *The Wicker Man* (1973) — set the pattern. Lakeside completes Scovell's chain in an American key: the snowbound Northwoods, a town whose prosperity has become its morality, and a death each winter.

The Wicker Man, directed by Robin Hardy from Anthony Shaffer's screenplay, is the closest comparator. A devout police sergeant, Neil Howie, comes to the Scottish island of Summerisle to investigate the disappearance of a girl.

He finds a community that worships the old gods, led by its laird, Lord Summerisle. The revival, the laird explains, was his grandfather's work: a Victorian agronomist who bred new strains of fruit for the island's poor soil and restored the old gods to the islanders to make them work it. When the harvest fails, the island needs a sacrifice, and the missing girl is a lure. Howie — a virgin, a representative of the king's law, a fool, and one who has come of his own free will — is the victim, burned in a giant wicker effigy.

Summerisle's paganism is a confidence game founded for agricultural productivity. Its gods were reintroduced by an improver, its rites are bound to an export crop, and its blood sacrifice is required by a crop failure. *The Wicker Man* is the fiduciary religion of this study in its purest cinematic form: belief installed to secure a harvest, and called in, in blood, when the harvest defaults.

The film's central image comes from Caesar. In *De bello Gallico* (6.16), Caesar reports that the Gauls built images of enormous size whose limbs, woven of wicker, they filled with living men and set alight. They believed, he writes, that the gods could not be appeased unless a human life was rendered for a human life: *pro vita hominis nisi hominis vita reddatur*. They preferred thieves and criminals as victims, but when the supply of such men failed — *cum eius generis copia defecit* — they descended even to the execution of the innocent. Caesar describes an economy of sacrifice with a fixed rate of exchange, one life for one life, and a provision for default. When the supply of the guilty runs out, the innocent are spent. Lakeside's children are the innocents of a town whose rate is fixed.

Stephen King's *It* (1986) is the American comparator. In Derry, Maine, an entity that most often takes the form of a clown wakes roughly every twenty-seven years to feed on the town's children, and the town's adults look away. The novel's "Derry Interludes" are written by the town librarian, Mike Hanlon, who chronicles the cycles of violence the town has absorbed and forgotten. Hanlon's interludes do for Derry what Ibis's do for America: they are the chronicle of a sacred horror, kept by its only historian.

King's *Needful Things* (1991) supplies the merchant. Leland Gaunt opens a shop in Castle Rock and sells each resident the object of his or her desire, for a small sum and a "prank" played on a neighbor; the pranks ignite the town's grievances until it destroys itself, and Gaunt collects his customers' souls. Gaunt is Wednesday at the scale of a town, a merchant who profits from the mimetic violence he arranges. King's sheriff, Alan Pangborn, is an

amateur magician, and the merchant is undone, at the last, by the arts of illusion turned against him.

Thomas Tryon's *Harvest Home* (1973), in which a New England village's harvest festival culminates in the sacrifice of a man to the corn goddess, and King's "Children of the Corn" (1977), in which the children of a Nebraska farm town kill their elders for a god who walks behind the rows, complete the American field. The pattern descends from Hawthorne. In "Young Goodman Brown" (1835), a Salem husband follows the devil into the forest and finds the pillars of his community, his minister and his wife among them, gathered at a witches' sabbath, where the devil welcomes his congregation "to the communion of your race." The American folk-horror town is a community whose respectability rests on a secret covenant.

Ray Bradbury's *Something Wicked This Way Comes* (1962) links the folk-horror town to the House on the Rock. Cooger and Dark's Pandemonium Shadow Show arrives in Green Town, Illinois, with a carousel that adds a year of age for each forward revolution and removes one for each backward turn, and the carnival feeds on the townspeople's longings. The father who defeats it, a library janitor named Charles Halloway, destroys its Dust Witch with laughter. Bradbury's carousel trades in time, as the new gods do, and his weapon against the merchant of desire is the weapon Chapter 2 assigned to Anansi. Gaiman's tribute to Bradbury, "The Man Who Forgot Ray Bradbury," appeared in an anthology named for the carnival, *Shadow Show* (2012).

Twain's "The Man That Corrupted Hadleyburg" (1899) is the comic counterpart. A stranger avenges himself on a town proud of its incorruptibility by leaving a sack of supposed gold for the citizen who once did him a kindness. Every leading citizen falsely claims it, and the sack proves to hold gilded lead. Hadleyburg's moral currency is exposed as counterfeit by a counterfeit. Lakeside's prosperity is counterfeit in the kobold's sense, false ore, and its exposure, like Hadleyburg's, requires a stranger.

8.5 *The Theodicy of Good Fortune*

Max Weber, in the introduction to his studies of the economic ethics of the world religions (1915), coined the phrase "theodicy of good fortune" (*Theodizee des Glückes*). The fortunate, Weber observed, are seldom content with the fact of their good fortune. They need to know that they have a right to it, that they deserve it, and above all that they deserve it in comparison

with others. Religion supplies this legitimation as readily as it consoles the suffering.

Lakeside's theodicy is civic. Its people know they are lucky, and their boosterism — the civic religion Sinclair Lewis satirized in *Babbitt* (1922) — tells them they have earned it. Hinzelmann is the town's most devoted booster and its best storyteller. His tall tales, delivered with a straight face, belong to the genre Mark Twain described in "How to Tell a Story" (1895): the humorous story told gravely, its teller concealing that he suspects anything funny in it. Everyone knows the tall tale is a lie, and its acknowledged falsehood gives pleasure. Hinzelmann's acknowledged lies conceal an unacknowledged one. The kobold uses the conjuror's own instrument, misdirection, to keep the town's eyes off the lake.

This complicates the argument of Chapter 7. Acknowledged fiction is not innocent in itself. What distinguishes the conjuror's covenant from Hinzelmann's tall tales is not that the conjuror's fiction is acknowledged — both are — but that the conjuror's fiction conceals no victim. Chapter 11 develops the criterion.

The philosophical problem Lakeside dramatizes has a canonical form. In Dostoevsky's *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880), Ivan Karamazov tells his brother Alyosha that no future harmony can be worth the tears of a single tortured child, and that he therefore declines to enter it. In Constance Garnett's translation: "It's not God that I don't accept, Alyosha, only I most respectfully return Him the ticket." Ivan returns his ticket. The people of Lakeside buy theirs every winter.

In the next chapter of Dostoevsky's novel, Ivan's Grand Inquisitor explains how the church has made humanity happy by relieving it of freedom through "miracle, mystery and authority," deceiving the people for their own good. Hinzelmann is a Grand Inquisitor of the Northwoods: a benevolent fraud who gives a community happiness on condition that it never ask what the happiness costs.

William James gave the problem its American form. In "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life" (1891), he imagined a world in which millions were kept permanently happy "on the one simple condition that a certain lost soul on the far-off edge of things should lead a life of lonely torture." Only an independent moral emotion, he argued, could make us feel "how hideous a thing would be its enjoyment when deliberately accepted as the fruit of such a bargain." Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), subtitled "Variations on a theme by William James," built a city on

James's bargain. Its happiness depends on the misery of one child locked in a cellar; every citizen knows it; and a few, having seen the child, walk away.

James is the philosopher of this study's central metaphor, truth on a credit system (Chapter 1). He is also the author of Lakeside's moral problem, and the two are connected. A truth that lives on credit can be sustained by anything that keeps the notes passing, including a lost soul at the edge of things. James's "Moral Philosopher" supplies the limit that his *Pragmatism* lacks: some bargains are hideous however well they pay.

Lakeside is Omelas without anyone walking away. Its police chief, Chad Mulligan — whose name recalls the sociologist-seer of John Brunner's *Stand on Zanzibar* (1968) — does not walk away either. Late in the novel, Shadow goes through the ice beside the clunker and finds a missing girl's body in its trunk. Pulled from the water, he wakes in Hinzelmann's house, where the old man admits what he is, and Mulligan, having heard enough, shoots him.

Neither Shadow nor Mulligan walks away from Omelas; they break it. The novel's answer to Le Guin's question is a third option: neither to accept the bargain nor to leave, but to disclose it and end it.

8.6 *Lakeside and the War: The Local and the National Blood Standard*

Lakeside and the war are mirror images. The war is a sacrifice extracted from marks by deception; Lakeside is a sacrifice tacitly consented to by beneficiaries who prefer not to see. The war fails, and Lakeside works, winter after winter, for more than a century. Lakeside is what Wednesday wants America to be: a community that pays blood for prosperity and calls it luck.

Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok's theory of the crypt and the phantom (*L'écorce et le noyau*, 1978) describes how a family or a community transmits an unspeakable secret across generations. The secret is entombed in the psyche as a crypt, and its traces pass to descendants as a phantom: a gap in their knowledge that shapes their lives without their knowing why. Lakeside's prosperity is a phantom of this kind, and the clunker's trunk is a literal crypt, sunk each spring beneath the ice.

Dante reserved the lowest circle of hell for traitors, frozen in the lake of Cocytus (*Inferno* 32–34). Lakeside's crime is the betrayal of its own children, and its victims lie beneath a frozen lake. Shadow's fall through the ice is a descent into Cocytus.

It is also a baptism. Shadow nearly drowns and is drawn from the water knowing the truth. The scene repeats his death on the tree in another element:

the hanged man reborn of air, the drowned man reborn of water. In both, he returns from death with knowledge of a hidden sacrifice, and in both his response is disclosure. Lakeside and Lookout Mountain are the same scene at two scales, and the ethics of default that Chapter 11 describes is practiced at both.

CHAPTER

9

The Rotting Bride

Laura, Revenance, and the Economy of the Goddess

Laura Moon is the novel's most consequential agent and its least theorized character. Shadow's wife dies in a car crash days before his release from prison, in the company of his best friend, Robbie, with whom she was having an affair. At her funeral Shadow throws into her grave the gold coin that Mad Sweeney gave him, and she returns: cold, decaying, and unwavering in her protection of the husband she betrayed. She kills Mr. Wood and Mr. Stone, and at Rock City she kills Loki.

This chapter argues that Laura is the novel's figure of the fiduciary body, a life sustained by a token and decaying because the token is not life. It reads her through the Norse revenant, Charon's obol, the rotting wives of comparative myth and modern horror, and the alchemical marriage of sun and moon. It then places her among the novel's goddesses, whose economies divide between consumption and gift. Her release, when Shadow takes back the coin, is the first act of the ethics of default.

9.1 *The Obol Reversed*

The gold coin in Laura's grave inverts one of the oldest customs of the dead. In Greek practice a coin, an obol, was placed with the dead, often in the mouth, as the fare for Charon, ferryman of the dead; in Aristophanes' *Frogs* (405

BCE), Heracles tells Dionysus that the old ferryman will take him across for two obols (139–40). Bernhard Laum, as Chapter 1 noted, derived the obol from the *obelos*, the iron spit on which sacrificial meat was shared out. The coin in the grave is money and sacrifice at once: the fare for passage into death.

Shadow's coin pays for passage back. It is Charon's obol reversed, a fare that buys return rather than crossing. Laura's undeath is purchased, and the purchase is a debt: she is alive on credit, and her creditor is a gold piece.

The coin's provenance makes the credit precarious. Mad Sweeney, its owner, is a leprechaun, the novel's Irish god of luck. His name descends from Suibhne, king of the medieval Irish *Buile Shuibhne*, who was cursed by Saint Rónán into madness and lived in the treetops like a bird. Flann O'Brien brought Sweeney into *At Swim-Two-Birds* (1939), and Seamus Heaney translated his story as *Sweeney Astray* (1983). Sweeney's coin is a leprechaun's gold, and folklore knows what fairy gold does when it leaves the economy that issued it: it turns to leaves, ashes or dross.

Laura's body behaves like fairy gold. The vitality the coin confers holds only within the economy of the gods; carried into the human world, it decays. She is animated by a value that is real only where it was issued. She is, in the strictest sense, a fiduciary body. The coin, meanwhile, stays with her, and Sweeney, deprived of his luck, dies.

9.2 *Draugr*

Laura is a *draugr*, the revenant of the Old Norse sagas, and the identification explains her better than the vampire or the zombie. The draugr is not a ghost but a walking corpse: physically present, decaying, preternaturally strong, jealous of the living and fiercely possessive of what was buried with it. In *Grettis saga* (ch. 18), Grettir breaks into the burial mound of Kárr the Old, wrestles the dead man for his treasure and carries it out. Later in the saga (chs. 32–35), Grettir fights the draugr Glámr by moonlight. As the moon breaks from the clouds and Grettir sees Glámr's eyes, his strength fails him, and before he beheads the revenant, Glámr curses him with a lifelong fear of the dark.

Laura holds the coin as a draugr holds its grave-goods: the treasure of the grave belongs to the dead who keep it. Her violence is a draugr's violence, delivered with a strength no living woman has, and her cold, her smell and her slow corruption are the draugr's physical signs.

The saga tradition also knew how to end revenance. In *Eyrbyggja saga* (chs. 50–55), the dead of the farm at Fróðá return each evening to sit by the fire, and the household sickens. The haunting ends only when a door-court (*duradómr*) is held: the living summon the revenants one by one and prosecute them for trespass, and each departs when judgment is pronounced. The revenant is laid by a legal settlement.

Medieval England knew harsher remedies. William of Newburgh, writing in the 1190s (*Historia rerum Anglicarum* 5.22–24), recorded revenants at Berwick, at Melrose and elsewhere, laid by exhumation and the burning of the heart. Claude Lecouteux (*Fantômes et revenants au Moyen Âge*, 1986) and Nancy Caciola (*Afterlives*, 2016) have reconstructed the medieval conviction that the dead return when something remains unsettled: an obligation unmet, a rite omitted, a possession withheld.

Laura is laid, in the end, by a settlement of the Icelandic kind. Shadow takes back the coin, the claim that kept her among the living is extinguished, and she can die. Section 9.6 returns to the scene.

9.3 *Izanami's Ledger: The Rotting Wife in Myth and Horror*

The husband who looks upon his wife's decaying body is one of the oldest scenes in world mythology. In the *Kojiki* (712), the god Izanagi follows his dead wife Izanami to Yomi, the land of the dead, to bring her back. She asks him not to look at her while she consults the gods of the underworld. He breaks a tooth from his comb, lights it as a torch, and sees her body swarming with maggots. He flees, pursued by the hags of Yomi, and blocks the pass between the worlds with a great boulder. Through the stone, Izanami vows to strangle a thousand of his people each day; Izanagi answers that he will cause fifteen hundred birthing huts to be built each day.

The divorce of the first couple is settled as a ledger. Death is entered at a thousand a day and birth at fifteen hundred, and the margin is the growth of the human race. The oldest Japanese account of mortality is a balance sheet negotiated between estranged spouses across a sealed door. Shadow and Laura conduct their marriage across the same threshold, and its settlement is likewise a matter of account: a coin given and a coin returned.

The Greek version turns on the gaze. Orpheus wins Eurydice back from Hades on condition that he not look at her until they reach the upper air; he looks, and loses her (Vergil, *Georgics* 4.453–527; Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 10.1–85). Orpheus loses his wife by looking, and Izanagi by seeing what she has

become. Shadow sees what Laura has become and keeps looking. The novel's marriage survives the look that ends the myths, and it is ended instead by a choice.

Modern horror absorbed the rotting beloved into the economy of the wish. In W. W. Jacobs's "The Monkey's Paw" (1902), a mummified paw grants three wishes. The second brings a dead son back from the grave in the state in which the machinery that killed him left him, and the third sends him back unseen. The coin in Laura's grave is a monkey's paw: an object that grants a return its holder did not specify. Stephen King's *Pet Sematary* (1983) set the same structure on an Indigenous burial ground in Maine. Its wise neighbor warns that sometimes dead is better, and its last pages bring the protagonist's wife back from that ground.

Edgar Allan Poe declared in "The Philosophy of Composition" (1846) that "the death, then, of a beautiful woman is, unquestionably, the most poetical topic in the world." His "Ligeia" (1838), in which a dead wife returns through the body of her successor, made the beautiful dead woman an agent. Elisabeth Bronfen's *Over Her Dead Body* (1992) analyzed how Western art makes the female corpse an aesthetic object. Laura refuses that role. She is not beautiful in death and does not lie still to be mourned: she smells, she rots, she acts.

Julia Kristeva's *Pouvoirs de l'horreur* (1980) identified the corpse as the utmost of abjection, death infecting life, the thing that must be thrust aside for the self to remain itself. Barbara Creed's *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993) traced the abject woman through horror cinema. Laura is abject in Kristeva's sense, and she is also the novel's most loyal and effective protector. The novel joins what horror usually separates: the abject body and the faithful heart.

9.4 *Sol and Luna: The Alchemical Marriage*

The coins that bind husband and wife form an alchemical pair. Laura's coin is gold, the metal of the sun in every alchemical table. Shadow's is the moon itself, plucked from the sky by Zorya Polunochnaya, the midnight sister, and given to him as a silver dollar. Gold and silver, Sol and Luna, are the king and queen of alchemy, and their union, the *coniunctio*, is the central mystery of the Great Work.

The *Rosarium philosophorum* (Frankfurt, 1550) illustrates the stages of that union in a sequence of woodcuts that C. G. Jung analyzed in *Die Psychologie der Übertragung* (1946) and *Mysterium Coniunctionis* (1955–56). The king and

queen meet, unclothe, bathe and unite. Then, in the stage the *Rosarium* calls *putrefactio*, the united pair lies dead in a tomb, decaying, before the soul ascends, the body is purified and the soul returns. Putrefaction is not the end of the alchemical marriage but a necessary passage within it. The *Chymische Hochzeit Christiani Rosencreutz* (1616) made the royal wedding, death and resurrection into a Rosicrucian romance.

The marriage of Shadow and Laura is the *putrefactio* of the *coniunctio*: the union of sun and moon passing through death and decay. Its alchemy, however, is inverted. In the tradition the king is Sol and the queen Luna. In the novel the bride holds the sun, and the husband, whose name is Moon, holds the moon. Laura is solar: she acts, burns and strikes. Shadow is lunar: he reflects, waits and endures. The moon has no light of its own and shines with the sun's. Shadow's passivity through most of the novel is the passivity of a body that shines by borrowed light.

Laura names this condition. She tells Shadow, in effect, that he has never been fully alive — that he is less a man than an absence in a man's shape. The dead wife is more alive than the living husband, and her diagnosis states the task the novel sets him: to become a self, his own self, Mike Ainsel. The alchemical work of the marriage is directed not at Laura's revival, which is impossible, but at Shadow's.

An eclipse is an alignment of sun, earth and moon in which a shadow falls across one of them. The hero whose name describes a lunar eclipse is married to a woman who holds the sun, and their relation is an eclipse: two bodies aligned, one darkened by the alignment, until it passes.

9.5 *The Economy of the Goddess*

The novel's goddesses can be classified by the economies they inhabit.

Goddess	Economy	Relation to the worshipper or to Shadow
Bilquis	Payment and consumption	Takes the worshipper's life in exchange for worship
Media	Attention	Takes time; returns images
Easter	Festival commerce and recurrence	Thrives on a commercial calendar; restores Shadow to life
Kali (Mama-ji)	Solvency abroad	A local manifestation of a goddess flourishing in India

Goddess	Economy	Relation to the worshipper or to Shadow
The Zorya	Guardianship and gift	Watch over a creature chained in the Little Bear; give Shadow the moon
Bast	Healing and desire as gift	Heals Shadow's wounds in Cairo
The Norns	Fate	Keep the farm where the ash tree stands
Laura	Debt and protection	Lives on a coin; spends her undeath defending Shadow

The table discloses a pattern. The novel's goddesses divide between those who consume and those who give. Bilquis and Media devour. The Zorya, Bast and Easter give, and what they give is life, healing, protection or light. Kali's fierce iconography has been read by Western interpreters, Erich Neumann among them, as the terrible mother, though in her own devotional traditions she is a protective and beloved mother. Neumann's *The Great Mother* (1955) described this ambivalence as the archetypal goddess's two faces, the nourishing and the terrible.

Robert Graves's *The White Goddess* (1948), whose triple goddess of maiden, mother and crone shaped a generation of fantasy writing, stands behind Gaiman's triadic women: the three Zorya, the three Norns, and the three Kindly Ones of *The Sandman*. Jane Harrison's *Prolegomena to the Study of Greek Religion* (1903) and Marija Gimbutas's *The Language of the Goddess* (1989) supplied the scholarly myth of a prehistoric goddess religion overthrown by patriarchal sky gods. Cynthia Eller's *The Myth of Matriarchal Prehistory* (2000) dismantled its historical claims while acknowledging its imaginative force.

The novel's sexual economy maps onto the anthropology of the gift. Marcel Mauss's *Essai sur le don* (1925), as Chapter 3 noted, opens with the *Hávamál*. Lewis Hyde's *The Gift* (1983) argued that a gift must keep moving, that it binds those between whom it passes, and that it is destroyed when converted into a commodity. In *American Gods* the male gods lend. Wednesday's wages are advances against service and his favors are investments; Sweeney's coin is a test; Czernobog's game of checkers is a wager on Shadow's head. The giving goddesses give: the moon from the Zorya, healing from Bast, life from Easter, protection from Laura. The devouring goddesses are the gift's dark double, consumption without return.

The pattern is not without its problems. It risks reproducing the oldest binaries of the Western imagination of women: nurturer and devourer, madonna and whore, Neumann's good and terrible mothers. Henry Adams's observation that an American Venus would never dare exist (Chapter 4) points to the historical root. In Gaiman's America, the goddess as sovereign force survives only as consumer or as commodity, and the givers are foreigners — Slavic, Egyptian, Norse. The novel preserves the gift economy in its goddesses because the national economy it depicts has no other place for it.

9.6 *The Spear Through Two Bodies*

Laura's decisive act takes place at Rock City. Loki, as Mr. World, is ready to cast over the battlefield the stick cut from the World Tree on which Shadow hung, the stick that will become the spear of Odin's dedication, as the reed became a spear in *Gautreks saga* (Chapter 3). Laura impales him on it, driving it through her own body and into his. The spear is never thrown, and the dedication never happens.

The act is not a sacrifice. Laura does not offer herself to Odin or to anyone. She turns the instrument of dedication on its bearer and spends her undeath to break the mechanism. Girard's sacrificial scheme requires a victim who is, or is made to seem, the passive object of collective violence. Laura is a victim who refuses the role and a corpse who refuses to become an offering. Her self-impalement is an anti-sacrifice: a death that stops a dedication rather than making one.

The novel's resolution requires both of its protagonists. Laura's violence ends the con's mechanism, and Shadow's speech ends its credibility. The spear that is not thrown and the truth that is spoken are two halves of a single act of default: the refusal to pay the blood standard's price.

Afterward, Laura asks Shadow to take back the coin, and he does. The obol is refunded and the fare that bought her return is withdrawn. The door-court of Fróðá convenes at Rock City, with Shadow as judge and Laura as the revenant who consents to the verdict. The monkey's paw grants its third wish.

The release is the first act of the ethics of default that Chapter 11 develops. A debt that kept a woman in a rotting body is cancelled not by payment but by return: the token is given back, and the debtor is free to die. Shadow's love for Laura is consummated in letting her go.

9.7 *The Conscience of the Body*

Laura is the novel's conscience of the body. She embodies what the fiduciary order conceals: that credit without collateral decays, that a life sustained by a token rots, and that release requires the return of the token rather than its redemption. Her rotting is the truth of fairy gold.

The gold and silver that bind her to Shadow are also the metals of the nation's coinage. The next chapter reads them alongside the nation's sacrificial creed.

PART

V

Synthesis

10 *The Tree of Liberty and the Gallows of Odin*

11 *"Rather a Man than a God"*



CHAPTER

10

The Tree of Liberty and the Gallows of Odin

American Civil Religion as Sacrificial Odinism

The battle for which Wednesday's con is designed is to be fought on Lookout Mountain, above Chattanooga, where Union troops climbed through fog to take the summit on November 24, 1863, in the action remembered as the Battle Above the Clouds. Five days earlier, at the dedication of the soldiers' cemetery at Gettysburg, Abraham Lincoln had declared that the dead had consecrated that ground beyond the power of the living to add or detract. Gaiman sets the gods' war on a field of the American war.

This chapter argues that the setting is the argument. Wednesday's scheme — a war whose dead are dedicated as a single offering, a god sustained by the slain, a son hanged on a tree, a reserve of the dead held against a final battle — reproduces the sacrificial grammar of American civil religion. The Civil War, moreover, is the founding sacrifice of the fiduciary order this study has described. It created the nation's paper currency, whose value rose and fell with the news from the battlefields. It put the profession of trust in God on the coinage, founded the embalming industry and the national cemetery, and gave the civil religion its theology of consecration by blood. The American blood standard was established on a battlefield, and Gaiman's gods return to one to restore it.

10.1 *Civil Religion and Its Sacrifices*

Jean-Jacques Rousseau coined the term "civil religion" in the penultimate chapter of *The Social Contract* (1762). It is a purely civil profession of faith whose articles the sovereign fixes, in G. D. H. Cole's translation, "not exactly as religious dogmas, but as social sentiments without which a man cannot be a good citizen or a faithful subject." Its positive dogmas are "the existence of a mighty, intelligent and beneficent Divinity, possessed of foresight and providence, the life to come, the happiness of the just, the punishment of the wicked, the sanctity of the social contract and the laws."

Robert Bellah's essay "Civil Religion in America" (*Daedalus*, 1967) found such a religion at work in the United States: a body of beliefs, symbols and rituals concerning the nation's relation to a transcendent order, distinct from both church and state, with its own prophets and martyrs, sacred events, places and texts. Bellah dated a turning point precisely. With the Civil War, he wrote, "a new theme of death, sacrifice, and rebirth" entered the civil religion, symbolized above all in the life and death of Lincoln. W. Lloyd Warner's study of Memorial Day in a New England town, *The Living and the Dead* (1959), had already analyzed the holiday as a cult of the dead in Durkheim's sense, a rite in which the community worships itself through its fallen.

Carolyn Marvin and David Ingle took the analysis to its conclusion. In *Blood Sacrifice and the Nation: Totem Rituals and the American Flag* (1999), they argued that American nationalism is a religion whose god is the nation, whose totem is the flag, and whose central rite is the periodic sacrifice of its own members in war. Enduring groups, on their account, are organized around a killing authority and persist by sending some of their own to die. The group's deepest knowledge, which it must also keep from itself, is that it lives by these deaths. Marvin and Ingle called that knowledge the "totem secret." Their synthesis of Durkheim and Girard is this chapter's point of departure. Wednesday's con is the totem secret narrated as a fraud.

Benedict Anderson opened his account of the cultural roots of nationalism in *Imagined Communities* (1983) with the tombs of Unknown Soldiers, which he judged the most arresting emblems of modern nationalism because they are empty of identifiable remains and full of national imaginings. The United States dedicated its Tomb of the Unknown Soldier at Arlington on November 11, 1921. The unknown soldier is the ideal sacrificial victim: anonymous, interchangeable, belonging to no family but the nation. He is the American *einherji*, one of the chosen slain, held in reserve in the national Valhalla. Section 10.4 returns to Arlington.

10.2 *The Tree Refreshed: Liberty, the Gallows, and John Brown*

The arboreal symbolism of American liberty began as a gallows. On August 14, 1765, Boston's opponents of the Stamp Act hanged an effigy of the stamp distributor Andrew Oliver from an old elm near the Common. The elm became the Liberty Tree, the rallying point of the Sons of Liberty and the model for liberty trees and liberty poles across the colonies, until it was cut down for firewood during the siege of Boston in 1775. The first shrine of American liberty was a hanging tree, consecrated by a mock execution. It recalls the mock hanging of *Gautreks saga* (Chapter 3), in which a sacrifice performed as theater became real.

Thomas Jefferson supplied the tree's theology. Writing from Paris on November 13, 1787, after Shays' Rebellion, he told William Stephens Smith: "The tree of liberty must be refreshed from time to time with the blood of patriots & tyrants. It is its natural manure." Jefferson's liberty is a tree that lives on blood, and the blood must be renewed at intervals.

The image is Eddic. The Norns, Snorri reports, draw water each day from the well of Urðr and pour it with clay over the ash Yggdrasil so that its limbs will not rot (*Gylfaginning* 16). The World Tree must be refreshed. Its name is generally interpreted as "the steed of Yggr" — Yggr, "the terrible one," being Odin — because the gallows was the horse the hanged man rode. The World Tree is Odin's gallows. Jefferson's tree, refreshed with blood, and Odin's gallows, refreshed by the Norns, are one tree in two mythologies.

The tree took its first great American victim in 1859. John Brown, captured after his raid on the federal arsenal at Harpers Ferry, was hanged at Charles Town, Virginia, on December 2. In a lecture a month earlier, Ralph Waldo Emerson had called him a new saint who, if he suffered, would "make the gallows glorious like the cross." On the morning of the execution, Henry David Thoreau wrote: "Some eighteen hundred years ago Christ was crucified; this morning, perchance, Captain Brown was hung. These are the two ends of a chain which is not without its links."

Herman Melville's "The Portent" (1859), which opens his collection of war poems *Battle-Pieces* (1866), saw the hanging as the war's omen:

> Hanging from the beam,
> Slowly swaying (such the law),
> Gaunt the shadow on your green,
> Shenandoah!
> The cut is on the crown

> (Lo, John Brown),
> And the stabs shall heal no more.

Melville's hanged man is also wounded: the cut on the crown and the stabs that will not heal are the sword wounds Brown received at his capture. The poem's victim dies the Odinic double death of the *Hávamál*, hanged on a tree and wounded with a blade, and his shadow falls across the land. The poem ends by calling him "the meteor of the war": the hanged man as the sign of the sacrifice to come.

The war's anthems completed the theology. The marching song "John Brown's Body" (1861) sang of a body moldering in the grave while its soul marched on. Julia Ward Howe set new words to its tune in "The Battle Hymn of the Republic" (1862), which ends: "As he died to make men holy, let us die to make men free." The hymn makes Christ's death the model for the soldier's and liberty the god to whom the soldier is offered.

Gaiman's hero is hanged on an ash tree on a Virginia farm, in fulfillment of a contract with his father. He hangs nine days, as Odin hung nine nights, in the state where John Brown was hanged — Charles Town was then in Virginia — and where the tree of liberty was first refreshed in earnest. Shadow inherits the place of the American hanged man whom Emerson, Thoreau and Melville sanctified, in the Norse form that their images had unknowingly repeated.

10.3 *Consecration by the Dead: Gettysburg and Lookout Mountain*

Lincoln's address at Gettysburg on November 19, 1863, is the central text of American civil religion, and its theology is consecration by blood:

> But, in a larger sense, we can not dedicate—we can not consecrate—we can not hallow—this ground. The brave men, living and dead, who struggled here, have consecrated it, far above our poor power to add or detract.

The living, Lincoln continued, must take from "these honored dead" an increased devotion to the cause for which they gave "the last full measure of devotion," so that "this nation, under God, shall have a new birth of freedom." Devotion has a measure, and the dead have paid it in full. Their sacrifice is the price of the nation's rebirth.

Garry Wills, in *Lincoln at Gettysburg* (1992), showed how deeply the address drew on the Athenian funeral oration, the genre that Edward Everett's two-hour speech that day had imitated at length. The model of the genre is the oration Thucydides gives to Pericles (2.35–46), which names the exchange

the funeral oration performs. In Benjamin Jowett's translation: "For the sacrifice which they collectively made was individually repaid to them; for they received again each one for himself a praise which grows not old." In the Greek, they gave their bodies in common and received, each for himself, the ageless praise (*agērōn epainos*).

The funeral oration is the *Hávamál*'s economy made civic. Cattle die and kinsmen die, but the fame of the dead does not (Chapter 3); the city takes the soldiers' bodies and repays them in imperishable reputation. Civil religion is the institution that converts the deaths of citizens into immortal credit.

Five days after the Gettysburg Address, the battle on Lookout Mountain consecrated the ground on which Gaiman would stage his war. The site is a palimpsest of the American sacred. It was Cherokee country, and in 1838 Ross's Landing, at the mountain's foot in what became Chattanooga, was one of the points from which the Cherokee were driven west on the Trail of Tears. In 1863 it was a battlefield. In 1890 Congress made the fields of Chickamauga and Chattanooga the first national military park in the United States, the prototype of the battlefield parks that followed. In 1910 New York dedicated a Peace Monument at Point Park on the summit, crowned by a Union and a Confederate soldier clasping hands beneath one flag. In 1932 Rock City opened a few miles along the ridge, and from 1935 its barn-roof liturgy called the nation to see it.

Each layer belongs to a stage of the fiduciary order: dispossession emptied the land, blood consecrated it, the state commemorated it and commerce capitalized it. The Peace Monument belongs to the culture of reconciliation that David Blight analyzed in *Race and Reunion* (2001), in which the white North and South made peace by honoring the courage of both sides and forgetting the cause, emancipation, for which the war had come to be fought. A shared sacrifice was remembered and its reason erased. Wednesday's war is designed to work the same way: two sides offered to one god, their sacrifice commemorated, its cause concealed.

Ambrose Bierce, who fought at Chickamauga, wrote the battlefield's most unsettling story. In "Chickamauga" (1889), a small boy wanders from his home onto the field after the battle and finds wounded soldiers crawling toward a creek. Taking them for a game, he climbs onto one, as he had once ridden his father's slaves, who crept on their hands and knees for his amusement while he made believe they were his horses. Waving a wooden sword, he leads the procession of the maimed to his own burning house, where he

finds his mother dead. Only in the last sentence does the reader learn that the child is a deaf-mute.

Bierce's story contains this chapter in miniature. A child's make-believe unfolds among the dying, the slave and the soldier alike are made into mounts, and the spectator cannot hear. It is the American battlefield as Gaiman's gods would use it: a field of sacrifice on which play and death are indistinguishable to those who do not know what they are seeing.

10.4 *The Greenback and the Grave: The War as Collateral*

The Civil War created the national paper currency. The Legal Tender Act of February 1862 authorized the Treasury to issue United States Notes — the "greenbacks" — which were legal tender for most debts and could not be redeemed in gold. They were fiat money in the strict sense, backed by nothing but the government's credit and the public's willingness to accept them, and the government's credit depended on the war. Contemporaries watched the greenback's price in gold move with the news from the front. Wesley Clair Mitchell's *A History of the Greenbacks* (1903) traced the fluctuations, and Kristen Willard, Timothy Guinnane and Harvey Rosen, in "Turning Points in the Civil War: Views from the Greenback Market" (*American Economic Review*, 1996), used them to identify the moments at which markets judged the Union's prospects to have changed. In the summer of 1864, with the Union armies stalled, a greenback dollar fell to little more than a third of its face value in gold.

In the fiduciary terms of this study, the war dead were the collateral of the national credit. The value of American paper money was set, in the most literal way, by the outcome of battles. The blood standard of Chapter 3 is not only a figure for Wednesday's scheme. It describes the actual monetary regime of the United States from 1862 until the resumption of specie payments in 1879.

The war also put trust on the coinage. In November 1861 a Pennsylvania minister, Mark R. Watkinson, asked the Treasury to recognize the Almighty on the nation's coins. Secretary Salmon P. Chase instructed the director of the Mint: "No nation can be strong except in the strength of God, or safe except in His defense. The trust of our people in God should be declared on our national coins." The motto IN GOD WE TRUST first appeared on the two-cent piece of 1864, minted in the war's last full year. The same Chase had put his own portrait on the first one-dollar greenback.

The motto that preceded it has its own history. E PLURIBUS UNUM, adopted for the Great Seal in 1782 and placed on coins from the 1790s, echoes a line of the *Moretum*, a Latin poem once attributed to Vergil, in which a peasant grinds garlic, herbs and cheese in a mortar until their colors become one (*color est e pluribus unus*). The motto of the pluralist republic describes many things ground into one: Zangwill's crucible (Chapter 6) in a mortar.

The postwar decades made the monetary standard the explicit subject of sacrificial rhetoric. At the Democratic convention in Chicago on July 9, 1896, William Jennings Bryan closed his speech against the gold standard: "You shall not press down upon the brow of labor this crown of thorns, you shall not crucify mankind upon a cross of gold." He ended with his arms outstretched. The most famous speech in American monetary history imagined the gold standard as a crucifixion and the people as its victim. Bryan's alternative was free silver, coined at sixteen to one. The nation's monetary politics was a struggle between the metal of the sun and the metal of the moon — the metals of Laura's coin and Shadow's.

The war founded the industry and the architecture of the American dead. Chapter 5 traced the rise of embalming from the battlefields and the funeral train of Lincoln's embalmed body. The national cemetery system began in 1862, and its most sacred ground was taken from an enemy. In June 1864 Quartermaster General Montgomery Meigs designated the Arlington estate of Robert E. Lee's family — seized after a tax sale at which the government had refused payment offered by the family's agent — as a military cemetery, and he had graves dug close to the mansion so that the family could never live there again. In *United States v. Lee* (1882), the Supreme Court held the seizure unlawful, and in 1883 Congress paid Lee's son $150,000 for the land. The national Valhalla was consecrated by burials made to defeat a property claim, and its title was settled by purchase.

Between 620,000 and 750,000 Americans died in the war, by traditional and revised estimates. From their deaths came the national paper currency, the motto of trust on the coinage, the embalming industry, the national cemetery, the first battlefield parks and the civil religion's theology of sacrifice. The Civil War is the founding sacrifice of fiduciary America. Gaiman's gods return to its battlefield because the American sacred was capitalized there.

10.5 *The Cross and the Lynching Tree*

Lincoln's Second Inaugural Address, delivered on March 4, 1865, gave the war its theology of debt. If God willed that the war continue, Lincoln said, "until all the wealth piled by the bondsman's two hundred and fifty years of unrequited toil shall be sunk, and until every drop of blood drawn with the lash shall be paid by another drawn with the sword," it must still be said that "the judgments of the Lord are true and righteous altogether."

The sentence is a ledger. The unpaid labor of two and a half centuries is entered against the wealth it piled up, and the blood of the lash against the blood of the sword, drop for drop. It is Caesar's Gallic rate of exchange (Chapter 8), a life for a life, raised to the scale of a nation and attributed to God. It is also the most profound statement of the blood standard in American letters, because it understands slavery itself as a debt and the war as its settlement.

The same address turns, in its final paragraph, from the ledger to its cancellation. "With malice toward none, with charity for all," the nation is to "bind up the nation's wounds" and care for the soldier, his widow and his orphan. Lincoln holds both theologies, settlement by blood and release by charity, in a single speech. *American Gods* chooses the second, and Chapter 11 follows that choice.

The settlement was not completed. After Reconstruction the blood standard took a new and terrible form. Between the 1880s and the 1930s, thousands of African Americans were lynched, often before crowds and often with ceremony. Orlando Patterson's essay "Feast of Blood," in *Rituals of Blood* (1998), and Donald Mathews's "The Southern Rite of Human Sacrifice" (2000) read the spectacle lynchings of the postbellum South as human sacrifice in the strict sense, conducted with the imagery and fervor of evangelical religion. Amy Louise Wood's *Lynching and Spectacle* (2009) and the photographs collected in *Without Sanctuary* (2000) document the postcards and body parts carried home as souvenirs: the sacrifice converted into the souvenir, in Susan Stewart's term (Chapter 5). The lynching of William James before thousands in Cairo, Illinois, in 1909 took place in the town where Gaiman's gods of the dead keep their funeral home.

James Cone's *The Cross and the Lynching Tree* (2011) argued that the crucifixion and the lynching tree must be seen together: in America, the cross is legible only in the light of the trees on which Black men and women were hanged. Billie Holiday's "Strange Fruit" (1939), set to Abel Meeropol's poem, made the Southern hanging tree an image the nation could not unsee.

In this setting, the hanging of Gaiman's hero cannot be read as Norse alone. Shadow, whom the novel presents as a man of uncertain ancestry and whom Gaiman has described as mixed-race, is hanged on a tree in Virginia as an offering to a god. Whatever its author intended, the scene stands in the landscape of the lynching tree, and the novel's Odinic sacrifice is legible in America only alongside the American one.

The blood standard also had a bureaucratic form: race measured in blood. Virginia's Racial Integrity Act of 1924, passed in the same year as the national-origins quotas (Chapter 6), defined a white person as one with no trace of any blood but Caucasian, except those with one-sixteenth or less of American Indian blood. The so-called Pocahontas exception protected the many Virginians who claimed descent from Pocahontas and John Rolfe. Federal Indian policy, from the Dawes Rolls of 1898–1914 onward, recorded "blood quantum" for tribal enrollment. Patrick Wolfe's "Land, Labor, and Difference" (2001) explained the asymmetry. The one-drop rule enlarged the population that could be enslaved and racially subordinated, while blood quantum shrank the population with claims to land. American racial law kept two ledgers in blood, one to multiply labor and the other to divide land.

10.6 *Odin in America: Blood and Troth*

Odin did return to America in the decades before the novel, and the struggle over his meaning was a struggle over the blood standard. In 1971 Else Christensen founded the Odinist Fellowship, which joined Norse religion to racial nationalism and later ministered to prisoners. In 1972 Stephen McNallen founded the Viking Brotherhood, forerunner of the Asatru Free Assembly. In the 1990s the white-supremacist Wotansvolk movement promoted Odin as a god of racial war. Mattias Gardell's *Gods of the Blood: The Pagan Revival and White Separatism* (2003) documented this racialist wing, and Jennifer Snook's *American Heathens* (2015) described the movement as a whole and its deep division.

Against the "folkish" groups, which tie the worship of the Norse gods to ancestry, stand inclusive organizations that welcome worshippers of any descent. The most prominent, founded in 1987, calls itself the Troth. The word is Old English *trēowþ*, "faith, fidelity, pledge," the root of *betroth* and a cousin of *truth* and *trust*. American Heathenry is divided between blood and troth: between reading the gods' claim as a matter of descent and reading

it as a matter of pledged faith. The *Hávamál*'s ring-oath (Chapter 3) has an American afterlife in both.

The American Odin also lives in prison. In *Cutter v. Wilkinson* (2005), the Supreme Court upheld a federal law protecting the religious exercise of prisoners, in a suit brought by Ohio inmates who included adherents of Ásatrú. Gaiman's novel begins in a prison, where Shadow's cellmate is Loki.

Wednesday is not a god of race. He is a grifter, indifferent to the descent of his marks and of his son. But the novel appeared as American Odinism was dividing over whether the god's blood meant ancestry or pledge. Its own answer, in Shadow, is a son of Odin of uncertain ancestry who releases every pledge he has been given.

10.7 *Sacrificial Odinism*

The civil religion of the United States, at its most solemn, is Odinic. It hangs its prophets on trees and calls the gallows glorious. It consecrates ground with the dead and repays their bodies with imperishable fame. It keeps a reserve of the honored dead at Arlington, around an unknown soldier, as Odin keeps the *einherjar* in Valhalla. It financed its survival on the collateral of the battlefield, stamped its trust in God on its coins in the last full year of its war, and, in its greatest speech, understood its history as a debt to be paid drop for drop. D. H. Lawrence wrote in *Studies in Classic American Literature* that "the essential American soul is hard, isolate, stoic, and a killer," and Richard Slotkin's *Regeneration Through Violence* (1973) traced the frontier myth by which Americans sought renewal through the deaths of others.

Wednesday's scheme is this civil religion's secret made visible: Marvin and Ingle's totem secret narrated as a con. The war between old and new gods reproduces the reconciliationist memory of the Civil War — two sides offered to one god, their sacrifice honored, its cause concealed — and stages it on a field where that memory is carved in stone.

The novel's question is whether the American sacred can be uncoupled from blood. The final chapter argues that its answer is yes, and that the uncoupling takes three forms: disclosure, default and the conjuror's covenant.

CHAPTER

11

"Rather a Man than a God"

Default, Jubilee, and the Conjuror's Covenant

The preceding chapters described a sacred economy: gods as credit, sacrifice as collateral, the con as its engine, and a nation whose civil religion consecrates itself in blood. This chapter describes the novel's way out, which has three moments. The first is disclosure: Shadow ends the war by revealing the con, which no sacrificial mechanism can survive. The second is default: a series of acts by which Shadow cancels, rather than pays, the debts that bind him and others — an ethics of jubilee. The third is the conjuror's covenant: a form of belief that knows itself to be illusion, is owned by its performer and consented to by its audience, and therefore cannot demand a victim.

The chapter ends with Shadow's conclusion that he would rather be a man than a god. This study reads that conclusion as the novel's final ontological claim: a human being, unlike a god, is not a liability on anyone's books.

11.1 *Disclosure: The End of* Méconnaissance

Shadow dies on the tree and returns. Restored to life, he goes to the battlefield behind Lookout Mountain, where the old and new gods have gathered, and tells them the truth. The war has been arranged by Wednesday and Loki, partners posing as enemies, and its dead were meant as an offering to Odin. Laura

has already killed Loki and stopped the spear. The gods, informed, have no reason to fight, and they disperse. Wednesday's spirit appears, furious at the loss of his offering, and fades.

René Girard spent his later career arguing that the scriptures of Israel and the Gospels reveal the mechanism that every sacrificial culture conceals. The title of *Des choses cachées depuis la fondation du monde* (1978) comes from Matthew 13:35: "I will utter things which have been kept secret from the foundation of the world." On Girard's account, the founding murder works only so long as it is misrecognized. Once the victim is seen to be innocent and the violence to be the community's own, the mechanism can no longer produce peace, and a culture must find another way to live. Revelation makes sacrifice impossible.

Shadow's return is often read as a resurrection that answers sacrifice with sacrifice: the son of Odin dies on the tree and rises with power. This study reads it otherwise. Shadow does not return to found a cult, demand worship or lead the gods. He returns to explain. His resurrection is not a counter-sacrifice but a revelation, and its fruit is not a new religion but the end of a war.

The form of his speech matters. Shadow does not denounce the gods or claim superiority over them. He tells both sides that they are afraid — the old gods of being forgotten, the new of being superseded — and that they have been conned. In Goffman's terms (Chapter 7), the confederate who should have cooled out the marks tells them the truth instead.

In Pfaller's terms (Chapter 1), he converts an illusion without owners into an illusion with owners. The war had been sustained by each side's attribution of hostility to the other; Shadow names its authors. A sacrifice requires that no one be responsible for it — the lot fell, the gods demanded it, the nation required it. Disclosure assigns responsibility, and once it is assigned the sacrifice cannot be performed.

11.2 *The Weighing of the Heart*

Before he returns, Shadow is judged. In the land of the dead he meets Mr. Jacquel and Mr. Ibis in their ancient offices, and his heart is weighed against the feather of Ma'at, as in the judgment scene of the Egyptian *Book of the Dead*. In that scene, recorded in the spell now numbered 125, Anubis tends the scales, Thoth records the verdict, and the devourer Ammit waits to eat any heart that proves heavy. The deceased recites a long series of de-

nials, swearing that he has not killed, stolen or lied — and also that he has not falsified the scales or short-measured the grain.

The Egyptian judgment is an audit. The final settlement of a life is conducted with a balance, and among the sins it examines are commercial frauds. Shadow's heart is weighed and found neither heavy nor light. Offered the choice of afterlives, he chooses none of them and passes into nothingness.

The choice deserves more attention than it has received. Every afterlife on offer is a settlement of accounts: reward for merit, payment for service. Shadow declines to be paid. He chooses nothing — not damnation, but the absence of any return on his life.

He is brought back by Easter. The goddess whom Chapter 4 identified as recurrent rather than continuous, renewed each spring by the moon, restores him to life. Her name, if Bede is right, descends from a goddess of the dawn; Old English *Eostre* is related to Greek *Ēōs*, Latin *Aurora* and Sanskrit *Uṣas*, all from a common Indo-European word for dawn. Shadow's return is not earned. It is given, as the dawn is given, by a goddess whose cult survives because it recurs.

The *Völuspá* ends its vision of the world's destruction with renewal: the earth rises again from the sea, green, and *böls mun alls batna, Baldr mun koma* — all ills will be healed; Baldr will come (st. 62). Baldr, the beloved son of Odin, killed through Loki's contrivance, returns after Ragnarök to a renewed world. Shadow, the son of Odin who dies and returns, occupies Baldr's place in the Eddic scheme. But he returns without Ragnarök. The renewal that the *Völuspá* places after the twilight of the gods, the novel achieves instead of it.

11.3 *The Ethics of Default*

After the war, Shadow performs a series of acts that share a single form. Each cancels a debt rather than paying it.

1. **He releases Laura.** He takes back the coin that kept her alive, refunding the obol and ending her undeath (Chapter 9).
2. **He keeps his word to Czernobog, and is released.** Shadow returns to Chicago to submit to the hammer he wagered in the game of checkers. Czernobog, whose dark aspect has yielded with the season to the brighter Bielebog, swings, stops with a touch to Shadow's brow, and declares the wager settled. The creditor forgives the debt in the act of collecting it.

3. **He returns the pledge.** In Iceland, he gives Wednesday's glass eye to an older Odin, of whom Wednesday was only an American version. The eye the god pledged for wisdom, the *veð* in Mímir's well (Chapter 3), returns to its owner as a gift, outside the economy in which it was pawned.
4. **He leaves.** Rather than remain among the gods, he leaves America altogether.

This is the ethics of default, and the term is chosen deliberately. *Default*, from Old French *defaute* and ultimately Latin *fallere*, means a failure to pay. In the vocabulary of finance it is a catastrophe. In the vocabulary of this study it is a refusal to honor the blood standard: a decision not to pay the gods in the currency they demand, and not to let them collect. Plutarch's *defectus*, Heidegger's *Fehl Gottes* and the eclipse in Shadow's name (Chapter 2) converge here. The man named for an eclipse is the agent of a default.

The default is not repudiation. Repudiation refuses to pay out of spite and leaves the creditor injured. Shadow's acts release creditors and debtors alike: Laura from undeath, Czernobog from a vengeance he no longer wants, the Icelandic Odin from the loss of his eye, the gods from a war that would have consumed them, and Shadow himself from his father's contract. A release that frees both parties has an ancient name: jubilee.

The law of Leviticus commands that every fiftieth year be hallowed: "proclaim liberty throughout all the land unto all the inhabitants thereof: it shall be a jubile unto you; and ye shall return every man unto his possession, and ye shall return every man unto his family" (25:10). Land returns to its original holders, and those sold into bondage for debt go free. Deuteronomy adds a release of debts every seventh year: "Every creditor that lendeth ought unto his neighbour shall release it" (15:2). The Hebrew word translated "liberty," *derôr*, is cognate with Akkadian *andurārum*, the term for the royal edicts of debt cancellation issued by Mesopotamian kings. Michael Hudson's *...and forgive them their debts* (2018) reconstructed this tradition of clean slates. David Graeber's *Debt: The First 5,000 Years* (2011) observed that the first recorded word for freedom, the Sumerian *amargi*, referred to the release of debt-bondsmen and meant, literally, "return to the mother."

The verse appears on the most sacred object of American civil religion. The bell cast for the Pennsylvania State House in 1752–53 bears the inscription "Proclaim LIBERTY Throughout all the Land unto all the Inhabitants thereof Lev. XXV X." Abolitionists named it the Liberty Bell in the 1830s, reading the verse as a command to free the enslaved. The word on the bell, and on American silver dollars of the kind the Zorya gave Shadow, is the word of

the jubilee. American liberty, in its own scripture, means the cancellation of debt and the release of bondsmen. The ethics of default is the civil religion's suppressed second theology — the one Lincoln reached for at the end of the Second Inaugural — and the novel restores it.

The Gospels made the jubilee their charter. In the synagogue at Nazareth, Jesus reads from Isaiah the commission "to preach deliverance to the captives" and "to preach the acceptable year of the Lord" (Luke 4:18–19), and the prayer he teaches asks: "forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors" (Matthew 6:12). Nietzsche hoped that the decline of faith might bring a "second innocence," a freedom from the debt to ancestors and gods (Chapter 1). Benjamin described capitalism as a cult that creates guilt and debt without atonement. Shadow's ethics of default is Nietzsche's second innocence reached not through atheism but through jubilee. The gods are not denied; they are released, and so are their debtors.

11.4 *The Conjuror's Covenant*

What kind of belief survives the end of the blood standard? The novel's answer is the belief of an audience at a magic show.

Samuel Taylor Coleridge described it in the fourteenth chapter of *Biographia Literaria* (1817). In planning *Lyrical Ballads*, he wrote, his task was to treat persons and characters supernatural, or at least romantic, "so as to transfer from our inward nature a human interest and a semblance of truth sufficient to procure for these shadows of imagination that willing suspension of disbelief for the moment, which constitutes poetic faith." Coleridge's name for the creatures of fiction is "shadows of imagination," and the faith they receive is willing, momentary and poetic. The novel's hero is named Shadow. In Coleridge's terms he is a shadow of imagination to whom the reader extends poetic faith, and in the course of the novel he learns to extend that faith himself without demanding anything more of it.

This study calls that form of belief the conjuror's covenant. Its terms are four. The illusion is acknowledged: both parties know that what is shown is a trick. It is owned: the performer takes responsibility for the effect. It is consented to: the audience agrees to be fooled, for the pleasure of it. And it is revocable: when the show ends, so does the belief, and nothing is owed. Because the illusion is owned and consented to, no victim can be hidden inside it. Because it is revocable, it cannot accumulate into a debt.

The covenant has an American pedigree. Neil Harris's "operational aesthetic" (Chapter 7) named the pleasure Barnum's audiences took in examining how a humbug was done: being fooled while knowing that they might be fooled, and enjoying the effort to find out how. The conjuror's covenant is the operational aesthetic made into an ethics — belief that keeps one eye on the method.

The covenant resolves the problem raised in Chapter 8. Hinzelmann's tall tales are acknowledged fictions, but they serve as misdirection for an illusion without owners, the town's luck, inside which a child is killed. Acknowledgment alone is not the criterion. The criterion is that every illusion in play be owned. The con fails this test, because its partners hide their partnership. The conjuror passes it, because his trick has an author.

The great theorist of stage magic gave the covenant its formula. Jean-Eugène Robert-Houdin, the father of modern conjuring, held that a conjuror is not a juggler but an actor playing the part of a magician (*Les Secrets de la prestidigitation et de la magie*, 1868). He titled his memoirs *Confidences d'un prestidigitateur* (1858), a phrase that joins the two figures this study has opposed, the confidence man and the conjuror. His own career shows the difference between them. In 1856 the French government sent him to Algeria to undermine the authority of the marabouts by performing feats that seemed to exceed their powers, and he presented his tricks there not as tricks but as demonstrations of a superior force. In Algeria the conjuror was used as a con, in the service of empire.

Harry Houdini embodied the covenant. In the 1920s he devoted his last years to exposing Spiritualist mediums, whose séances claimed as real what he could reproduce as illusion; *A Magician Among the Spirits* (1924) records the campaign. Before his death in 1926, he agreed with his wife, Bess, on a secret code by which she could test any message claiming to come from him. For ten years she held séances on the anniversary of his death; no message came, and she stopped. Houdini refused in advance to become a revenant. The conjuror's covenant, applied to death, is the opposite of Laura's coin: no token is left in the grave to buy a return.

The novel enacts the covenant in Shadow's coin magic. A coin manipulator since his years in prison, he practices palms and vanishes throughout the story, in the tradition of the "Miser's Dream," the production of coins from the air that T. Nelson Downs, the "King of Koins," made famous at the turn of the twentieth century. In the economy of this novel, the coin is the unit of every transaction between gods and men: the obol in Laura's grave, the

moon from the Zorya, the deposits in Wednesday's box. In Shadow's hands at the end, the coin becomes a prop in a game of make-believe, in Kendall Walton's sense (*Mimesis as Make-Believe*, 1990): an object whose appearances and disappearances everyone agrees to enjoy and no one mistakes for value.

Hans Vaihinger's *Die Philosophie des Als Ob* (1911) distinguished hypotheses, which claim to be true, from fictions, which are known to be false and kept because they are useful. Simon During's *Modern Enchantments* (2002) identified "secular magic," the conjuring of the stage, as a central and neglected form of modern culture. Michael Saler's *As If* (2012) described a modern "disenchanted enchantment" that delights without deluding. The conjuror's covenant belongs to this tradition. It is enchantment that knows itself, and so it is enchantment that cannot be cashed in blood.

L. Frank Baum's *The Wonderful Wizard of Oz* (1900) contains the American parable of the covenant. The great and terrible Oz, worshipped as a god in the Emerald City, is exposed when Dorothy's dog knocks over a screen and reveals a little old man from Omaha, once a ventriloquist and circus balloonist. "I'm really a very good man," he confesses, "but I'm a very bad Wizard, I must admit." The city, he explains, is green only because "my people have worn green glasses on their eyes so long that most of them think it really is an Emerald City." Henry Littlefield's well-known reading (1964) took the book as an allegory of the money debates of the 1890s, with a yellow brick road of gold, Dorothy's silver shoes and the greenback green of the capital. Whatever Baum intended, the Emerald City is a fiat illusion, sustained by spectacles everyone has agreed to wear.

What the Wizard does after his exposure is the covenant in action. He gives the Scarecrow brains of bran and pins, the Tin Woodman a silk heart, and the Lion a drink of courage. They know what he is, and the gifts work anyway, because they confirm what each already possessed. The exposed humbug becomes a benevolent conjuror. Wednesday is the inverse: a very good wizard and a very bad man. Shadow's choice, in the end, is the Wizard's: to be a good man rather than a great god.

Samantha Black Crow, the young hitchhiker Shadow meets on the road, gives the covenant a human voice. Her credo, a long, comic and defiant list of the things she believes, sets sincere convictions beside absurd ones and holds them all as her own. Hers is belief as an act of freedom rather than debt, owned by the believer and offered without demand for return. It is the novel's only creed, and it asks for no sacrifice.

William James had already distinguished the trust that sustains human communities from the credit that sustains gods. In "The Will to Believe" (1896), he observed that "wherever a desired result is achieved by the co-operation of many independent persons, its existence as a fact is a pure consequence of the precursive faith in one another of those immediately concerned." Such faith is horizontal: it runs between persons who extend it to one another and are bound reciprocally. The conjuror's covenant is a contract of this kind, between a performer and an audience. Fiduciary polytheism is vertical: credit extended upward to beings who demand payment in blood. The novel does not abolish trust. It moves trust from the altar to the stage.

11.5 *"Rather a Man than a God"*

Near the end of the novel, Shadow concludes that he would rather be a man than a god. A man, he reasons, does not need anyone to believe in him in order to go on.

The sentence completes the novel's ontology. A god exists as credit; it lives as long as its notes pass and dies when they are refused. A human being does not exist on credit. No one's belief sustains Shadow, and no one's disbelief can kill him. To be a man is to be, in the precise sense of this study, a non-fiduciary being: an existence that is not a liability on anyone's books.

In this the human resembles the land. The buffalo-headed figure of Shadow's dreams, the novel's spirit of place, neither needs nor solicits belief (Chapter 5). The novel has three non-fiduciary terms: the land, which does not circulate; the human being, who does not need to be believed in; and the acknowledged story, which announces its own fiction. Shadow's choice aligns him with the land and the story, and against the gods.

Martin Heidegger said, in an interview given in 1966 and published after his death, that only a god can still save us (*Nur noch ein Gott kann uns retten*). *American Gods* answers that no god will, and that the one who ends the war is a man who has declined to become one. Whitman, in "Song of Myself" (Chapter 2), proposed to distribute divinity to every citizen. Shadow proposes something more modest and more radical: to let every citizen be a person, owed nothing by the gods and owing them nothing.

The novel ends with an emigration. Every "Coming to America" in Ibis's chronicle carried a god across the ocean. Shadow goes the other way, to Iceland, to return a god's eye to the god it belonged to. He is the only figure in

the novel who closes the circuit of arrival. The book leaves him walking on, a man with a coin trick and no god to serve.

11.6 *Toward a Post-Sacrificial Sacred*

The argument of this study can now be stated as a correspondence. The fiduciary order has three registers, each embodied in particular figures and each answered by one of the novel's acts.

Register	Fiduciary form	Embodied in	The novel's answer
Credit	Divinity sustained by belief and attention	The new gods: Media, the Technical Boy, the intangibles	The human being, who needs no belief in order to exist
Collateral	Sacrifice, blood and the consecrated dead	Odin; Hinzelmann; the civil religion of the battlefield	Default as jubilee: debts cancelled, pledges returned
Confidence	The con that profits between credit and collateral	Wednesday and Loki	Disclosure, and the conjuror's covenant of owned illusion

Beyond the economy stands the land, which never entered it.

The post-sacrificial sacred the novel imagines is not a new pantheon but a new relation to the old ones. Its gods are stories that announce they are stories, its trust runs between persons, its debts are released, and its land is owed what was taken from it. The word for such a sacred is already inscribed on the nation's bell and on its coins. It is *liberty*, in the oldest sense of the word: the jubilee.

CONCLUSION

After the Storm

The Novel as Its Own Conjuring

Wednesday's refrain throughout the novel is that a storm is coming. The storm never breaks. The war it portends is exposed as a con and called off, and the book ends not in apocalypse but in an emigration and a coin trick. This conclusion argues that the novel performs on its reader the covenant it recommends. It then reads the book's textual and adaptive afterlives as demonstrations of its thesis and restates the argument as a whole.

I. *The Novel as Conjuring*

American Gods opens with a caveat, and the caveat is a conjuror's patter. It warns travelers that the book's American geography has been altered, then reverses the conventional disclaimer of fiction by insisting that the gods, at least, are real. The reader is told at the outset that the book is a trick and invited to enjoy it as one. The novel begins, in effect, with Anansi's formula (Chapter 7) spoken with a wink: we do not really mean that what we are going to say is true, except for the part that matters.

The reader's belief in the novel's gods has every feature of the covenant. It is acknowledged, since no reader takes the book for ethnography. It is owned, since the book has an author who signs it. It is consented to, for pleasure. And it is revocable: when the book is closed, nothing is owed. The novel asks for attention, the currency of the new gods, but on the conjuror's terms rather than Media's — attention given knowingly, for a bounded time, to a fiction that announces itself. Coleridge's poetic faith is extended to shadows of imag-

ination, and one of them is named Shadow. In the reader's own experience, the novel demonstrates that gods can be believed in vividly, for hundreds of pages, without being paid in anything but attention and without a hidden victim.

The critic's position is Mr. Ibis's (Prefatory Note). The chronicler preserves the gods by retelling them otherwise. This study has paraphrased rather than quoted the novel, and so has kept its gods in circulation in the one way the covenant allows: as stories told again, with their teller named.

II. *Recension*

The novel has a textual history of the kind its gods would recognize. The first edition of 2001 was cut in editing. The author's preferred text, restoring some twelve thousand words, first appeared in a limited edition and reached a mass readership in the tenth-anniversary edition of 2011. Readers thus possess two canonical versions, a received text and a restored one, and the relation between them is the one that textual critics of scripture study as recension and redaction: the claim of an original against the authority of what has been received.

The Machen effect (Chapter 2) governs both versions. A text, like a god, belongs to those who sustain it. The preferred text restores the author's intention, but the text that made the novel's reputation was the shorter one, and both now pass. Neither can recall the other.

III. *The Gods Before the Screen*

The novel's adaptation history reads as a demonstration of Chapter 4. A television series developed by Bryan Fuller and Michael Green premiered on the cable network Starz in April 2017. Its first season was praised for the visual extravagance of its gods, and it made explicit what the novel left implicit. Its second episode opens with Mr. Nancy addressing captive Africans in the hold of a slave ship in 1697, telling them what awaits their descendants in America and urging them to revolt. Its Easter receives a crowd of simultaneous Jesuses, ethnic and national manifestations of one god: a literal staging of the corporate ontology described in Chapter 6, one deity with many locally capitalized branches.

The production then suffered the fate the novel assigns to the gods of the old world. Its original showrunners left after the first season, and their suc-

cessors came and went. Cast members departed, among them Orlando Jones, the series' Mr. Nancy, whose dismissal before the third season was followed by a public dispute with the production. Ratings declined, and in 2021, after three seasons, the network canceled the series before it reached the novel's climax. On screen, the war between the gods did not take place.

The gods of *American Gods*, brought before Media, lived on her terms. They were sustained as long as their notes passed — as long as viewers attended — and they defaulted when attention was withdrawn. The adaptation performed the novel's thesis in the medium of the new gods.

IV. *The Argument in Retrospect*

This study began by rejecting the census model of divinity, on which a god's reality is proportional to the number of its believers, and proposed in its place a fiduciary model. In *American Gods*, divinity is credit: extended by human attention, secured by sacrifice and exploited by confidence. The model explains what the census model cannot — why the most religiously fertile nation of modernity is also the most destructive of gods. Where gods are issued freely on credit, they default freely.

The Odinic corpus supplied the model's mythic grammar: the pledge in Mímir's well, the measured sacrifice, the compounding yield of self-expenditure, the reserve of the slain in Valhalla and the fraud of the ring-oath. Wednesday's war is an attempt to restore the blood standard, re-pegging floating divinity to sacrificial death. The new gods are gods of inconvertible credit, drinking hours as the old gods drank blood. The roadside attraction is the bureau de change between the two economies, and the land stands outside both.

The nation's history gave the model its force. The chronicle of arrivals records not only immigration but conquest, penal transportation and enslavement, and in the Middle Passage the blood standard was the literal financial architecture of slavery. The confidence man is the American god par excellence. Lakeside shows a community that pays blood for prosperity and calls it luck, and Laura's rotting body shows what a life on credit becomes. The civil religion of the United States, from the Liberty Tree to Arlington, is sacrificial in the Odinic sense; its currency, its motto of trust and its sacred ground were capitalized by the Civil War dead, on whose battlefield Gaiman sets his gods' war.

Melville had already written the American novel of the sacrificial war. In *Moby-Dick* (1851), Ahab binds the crew of the *Pequod* — a ship named for a

nation nearly destroyed by the Puritans in 1637 — to his quest with an oath drunk from the sockets of the harpoons. He nails a gold doubloon to the mainmast as the reward for the first sight of the whale, and he tempers his harpoon in the harpooneers' blood, baptizing it in the name not of the Father but of the devil. In the chapter devoted to the coin, each sailor reads its emblems according to his own nature, and Pip, the ship's boy driven mad, calls it the ship's navel. Melville's doubloon is the fiduciary coin of this study: an omphalos whose value is whatever its beholders project onto it, nailed to the mast of a ship that sails to its own sacrifice. Ahab's war ends in the death of all but one. Gaiman's ends before it begins.

Against the sacrificial order the novel sets three acts. Disclosure ends the war, because a sacrifice cannot survive the naming of its authors. Default, in the form of jubilee, cancels debts rather than paying them. The conjuror's covenant preserves belief as acknowledged, owned, consented and revocable illusion, which cannot hide a victim.

Jacques Derrida's *Donner le temps* (1991) reads Baudelaire's prose poem "La Fausse Monnaie" (1869), in which a man gives a beggar a counterfeit coin, and argues that a pure gift is impossible: a gift recognized as such obliges a return and so annuls itself in debt. The novel's ethics of default answers the aporia obliquely. Its acts of release are not gifts that open new debts but cancellations that close old ones, and the conjuror's coin is the one counterfeit in the book that is offered and received as exactly what it is.

Shadow's conclusion that he would rather be a man than a god names the being in whom the three acts meet: a person who exists without being believed in, and who owes the gods nothing.

V. *After the Storm*

The novel was published in June 2001. Three months later, the attacks of September 11 opened a period in which the sacrificial vocabulary of American civil religion was invoked with new intensity, and many readers met the book's war between gods alongside public talk of a "clash of civilizations," the phrase Samuel Huntington had made famous in 1993. The chronicle of arrivals acquired a further resonance in February 2018, when U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services removed the phrase "a nation of immigrants" from its mission statement. The novel has been read in these moments as a myth of pluralism, as a critique of that myth and as a requiem. It accommo-

dates each reading because its own argument concerns the conditions under which stories, like gods, continue to pass.

Gaiman returned to Shadow in two novellas, "The Monarch of the Glen" (2004) and "Black Dog" (2015), which follow him through Scotland and England and so continue the reverse migration with which the novel ends. He returned to Mr. Nancy's sons in *Anansi Boys* (2005), a comedy in which the ownership of the world's stories is once again at stake. The god of stories had heirs.

Dorson's informants said that the spirits of the old country were afraid to make the crossing. This study has argued that they made it, in the heads of migrants, convicts, captives and salesmen; that they were sustained on credit and secured by blood; that the nation built its own sacred on the same collateral; and that the novel imagines a way of holding the sacred without paying for it in lives. The crossing the gods could make safely was the one they made in stories.

The Asante storytellers whom Rattray heard closed each tale by releasing it into circulation: whether it was sweet or not, the listener should take some of it elsewhere and let some come back. This study ends on that formula. Its argument is offered as a story is offered under the covenant — acknowledged, owned, consented to and revocable — to be carried elsewhere and, if it is any good, to come back.

APPENDIX A

Concordance of Deities, Sources, and Functions

The concordance lists the novel's principal divine and semi-divine figures, their traditional identities, the sources on which this study draws for them, and their place in the fiduciary order. "Register" refers to the argument's categories: credit, collateral and confidence (Introduction), together with the gift, the story, the record, recurrence and what stands outside the economy.

Figure in the novel	Traditional identity	Principal sources	Register	Chapters
Wednesday	Odin (Óðinn), Norse god of sovereignty, war and poetry	*Hávamál*, *Völuspá*, *Grímnismál*; Snorri, *Gylfaginning*, *Skáldskaparmál*, *Ynglinga saga*; Saxo, *Gesta Danorum* 7–8; Tacitus, *Germania* 9	Confidence; architect of the blood standard	3, 7, 10
Low Key Lyesmith / Mr. World	Loki, Norse trickster	Snorri, *Gylfaginning*; *Lokasenna*	Confidence; executive of the new gods	4, 7
Mr. Nancy	Anansi, Akan spider trickster and owner of stories	Rattray, *Akan-Ashanti Folk-Tales* (1930); Caribbean and African American Aunt Nancy tales	Story	6, 7

Figure in the novel	Traditional identity	Principal sources	Register	Chapters
Czernobog	Chernobog, the Slavic "black god"; his bright twin Bielebog is a later scholarly reconstruction	Helmold of Bosau, *Chronica Slavorum* 1.52 (c. 1170)	Collateral; the forgiven wager	6, 11
The Zorya	Slavic personifications of morning, evening and midnight	Russian folk charms; Afanasyev, *Poetic Views of the Slavs on Nature* (1865–69)	Gift; the moon coin	9
Mad Sweeney	Suibhne Geilt; the leprechaun	*Buile Shuibhne*; Irish fairy lore	Luck as credit; the gold coin	9
Mr. Ibis	Thoth, Egyptian scribe and recorder of the judgment of the dead	*Book of the Dead* 125	Record; the chronicle of arrivals	6, 11
Mr. Jacquel	Anubis, Egyptian god of embalming and guide of the dead	*Book of the Dead* 125	Record; the scales	5, 11
Bast	Bastet, Egyptian cat goddess	Egyptian cult	Gift; healing	9
Easter	Eostre / Ostara	Bede, *De temporum ratione* 15 (725); Grimm, *Deutsche Mythologie* (1835)	Recurrence; restores Shadow to life	4, 11
Bilquis	The Queen of Sheba (Makeda, Bilqis)	1 Kings 10; Qur'an 27; *Kebra Nagast*	Collateral; payment in cash and in life	4, 9
The ifrit	Ifrit, a class of jinn	Qur'an 27:39, 55:15	Gift; the exchange of lives	6
Mama-ji	Kali	*Devī Māhātmya*; Hindu devotional traditions	Solvency abroad	6, 9

Figure in the novel	Traditional identity	Principal sources	Register	Chapters
Hinzelmann	Kobold; the house spirit of Hudemühlen	Grimm, *Deutsche Sagen* (1816); Keightley, *The Fairy Mythology* (1828)	Collateral; child sacrifice	8
Whiskey Jack	Wisakedjak, Cree and Algonquian trickster	Cree and related narrative traditions	Trickster of the land	5, 6
John Chapman	Johnny Appleseed (1774–1845), American folk saint	W. D. Haley, "Johnny Appleseed: A Pioneer Hero" (*Harper's*, 1871)	American folk sacred	—
Paul Bunyan (mentioned)	Lumberjack giant of advertising	W. B. Laughead's pamphlets for the Red River Lumber Company (from 1914); Dorson on "fakelore" (1950)	Counterfeit; fakelore	Introduction
The buffalo man	The land, in Lakota-coded form	Lakota tradition of the Buffalo Nation; Vine Deloria Jr., *God Is Red* (1973)	Outside the economy	5, 6, 11
Nunyunnini	Mammoth-skull god of Beringian migrants	Gaiman's invention	Forgotten credit	6
The orisha and lwa of the Wututu interlude	West African and Haitian deities	Yoruba and Fon traditions; Haitian Vodou; Hurston, *Tell My Horse* (1938)	Arrivant gods, carried as collateral	6
Media	Television	—	Credit (attention)	4
The Technical Boy	Computing and the network	—	Credit (attention)	4
The intangibles	The market	—	Credit (expectation)	4
Mr. Wood, Mr. Stone, Mr. Town	Enforcers of the new gods; the "men in black"	Deuteronomy 4:28; Isaiah 44; Genesis 4:17; Barker, *They Knew Too Much About Flying Saucers* (1956)	Enforcement; idols of wood and stone	4

Figure in the novel	Traditional identity	Principal sources	Register	Chapters
The Norns	Urðr, Verðandi, Skuld	*Völuspá* 20; Snorri, *Gylfaginning* 15–16	Fate; keepers of the tree	9, 10
Laura Moon	Human revenant of the draugr type	*Grettis saga*; *Eyrbyggja saga*	Debt; the fiduciary body	9
Shadow Moon	Son of Odin (Baldr type); Jung's shadow	*Völuspá* 62; Jung, "On the Psychology of the Trickster-Figure" (1956)	The non-fiduciary person	8–11

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KEYWORDS

Neil Gaiman; *American Gods*; fiduciary polytheism; the blood standard; the conjuror's covenant; ethics of default; jubilee; credit theory of money; attention economy; spectacle; sacrifice; scapegoat mechanism; René Girard; Émile Durkheim; Max Weber; disenchantment; civil religion; Odin; Norse mythology; *Poetic Edda*; comparative mythology; trickster; confidence man; Herman Melville; folk horror; Stephen King; revenant; draugr; alchemy; the goddess; gift economy; secular magic; Coleridge; poetic faith; immigration; settler colonialism; Indigenous sacred space; American Civil War; lynching; Ásatrú; roadside attractions; fakelore; myth-and-symbol criticism; American studies; fantasy literature; the postsecular.